

The Determined African Boy

Thomas A. Baafi



A Journey Unveiled

A Biography by John Acquaye-Awah

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This chronicle of my life's journey is dedicated to my
mother, Akua Addae, Uncle Guyman, my first wife,
Deidra, and my current beloved wife, Afua Adomah.
Each of these heroes and heroines in my life have played key
roles in my aspirations and ascent to the pinnacle of my career.
I am forever grateful for their selfless contributions
and their unconditional love.
They made it possible for me to stand tall among men,
a virtue that can never be taken away from me.
For their sake, I am forever blessed.

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INTRODUCTION

I was handpicked as the mantle of my family. By chance or destiny, it probably did not matter.

We were six siblings, yet I became the chosen one. The village was Mabang. It was remote, devoid of the conveniences and comfort of the modern day. The absence of the television, telephone, or Internet did not bother us. We did not miss what we did not know.

Family planning in a village where life was rudimentary was limited to the body's internal clock. It, therefore, came as no surprise when, by the age of twenty-six, my mother, Akua Addae, already had six of us.

As children, our whole world was limited to playing. We had no problem. We were close in age. We became each other's playmate. We could play with each other all day.

The interactions with our father were like a touristic arrangement. He lived in one village in his father's house at Akwasiase. Our mother lived in the next village, Mabang, in her mother's house. We only saw our father when necessary.

On our blind side, oblivious to all the children, was a brewing discourse between the two of them. Then one day our father came and left and waved us all goodbye. Little did we know that it was the last time we would see him.

Our mother began to pick up the pieces and plod along. She took the dejection in stride. She put up a facade that life was normal. But with six mouths to feed, her toil became more evident when

her smiles began to fade, giving way to apparent stress and internal agony.

Our harmonious childhood happiness, which until now seemed to be in a perfect equilibrium, suddenly began to wither. Food was becoming inadequate. We were outgrowing our clothes. We were getting sick often, as my mother could not afford medicine for the family.

One day, my uncle Osei Kofi (a.k.a., Guyman) visited. I was the first to rush to him. As short as I was, I was only able to reach his legs, which I embraced and did not want to let go. He carried me in the air and whirled me around. My siblings looked on with infantile envy.

It had been a few months since we last saw Dad, and Uncle's presence represented what I longed for as a fatherly figure and a role model.

Though Uncle Guyman spent a few hours with us, he filled a considerable vacuum our dad had left behind.

In retrospect, it was a visit to console Mum and discuss support if she needed it. It was meant to ease Mum's burden of raising us and to go and plead with my dad for reconciliation. But my dad's mind was made up.

A few days passed, and just as Dad waved us his final goodbye, Uncle Guyman did the same amidst the cries and wailings of all the kids. This time he explained that he had to go back to his family in Kumasi and that he would surely be back.

He did come back after a few months, as promised, but this time it was rather brief. He came with a message that changed my life forever.

Among all the siblings, I was selected to live with Uncle Guyman. Even though I was elated to have a live-in father figure in my life, I was sad to leave my mum and other siblings in the village.

The move-in with my uncle was a giant stepping stone for me. With the absence of basic predicaments, such as a lack of food and inadequate clothing in my new home, my academic prowess became evident.

I went through the echelon of academia with great ease. I began to dream big and about the heights I could attain. Then the epiphany set in that I could achieve anything I set my mind to.

With Ghana's limited resources to excel, I fantasized about going to the land of opportunities—the United States. There I could educate myself and hopefully land a good job.

This was, apparently, an insurmountable task, given the prevailing factors in my life. I had no money and no acquaintances in the United States. I was just a boy aspiring to enter the land of opportunity with absolutely no frills.

But aspiring for the heights required planning and determination. At that time in African history, during which Nigeria was the flourishing economic giant of the West Coast of Africa, it became a greener pasture for many economic migrants.

I was one of many Ghanaians who flocked to Nigeria. It was after my secondary education, the crossroad of my destiny. Unlike many of my contemporaries whose sole aim was to make money, I went there for a purpose. I needed money for my airline ticket in order to begin the journey to my promised land.

Agege, in Nigeria, was my destination. Even though it was a slum, I had no choice but to make it a temporary home. After all, the end would eventually justify the means.

When I eventually secured the money to make the airline ticket, the realization set in that the journey to my promised land of opportunities required multiple detours.

The budget of \$2,000 was enough to begin the journey to my dreamland. I secured an airline ticket on a Balkan airline to the communist Bulgaria.

The capital, Sofia, was the first European city I ever set foot in. It was going to be the stepping stone to my promised land and the launch pad for my asylum in West Germany.

The transition through East Berlin to asylum status in Hamburg, West Germany, was a great eye-opener for an African boy seeking a better life for himself and his extended family. This not only toughened me in my formative years but proved my point that I could do anything I dared to.

I met the love of my life as a refugee in Bremerhaven, West Germany. She played an enormous role, which was pivotal in elevating me to the status that allowed me to be admitted to the dreamland.

But contrary to my expectation, life in my dreamland was a whole drama in itself. Yet the tertiary education I obtained in the United States helped me to even off the playing field.

And despite all the nuances, I was able to get a job that shaped my destiny.

My new career as a software engineer allowed me the opportunity to return to Ghana as an Oracle partner. Life took on new meaning as I walked through the corridors of business institutions in Ghana, selling American-made software.

Branching off to set up my own company, Bsystems Limited, became the game changer. Bsystems Limited became a software giant not only in Ghana but also in multiple countries across the globe.

I appreciate the opportunities given to me by multiple people I met during my journey to the pinnacle. I am now able to turn back and say it was all meant to be just as it began. It was *destiny*.

I am now capable of giving back to my family, my country, and all the good people who made it possible.

MABANG

In August 1959, at a health post tucked away in a remote village in the forest of the Ahafo Region of Ghana—the Akwasiase Health Center—I took my first breath of life. I was told it was a murky, gloomy, and rainy day, which my mother remembered vividly. As there was scarcity of public transport at the time, and the ambulance could only be dreamed of as a futuristic necessity, my mother, in labor, made the three-mile journey on foot on the muddy, untarred road from her home village of Mabang to Akwasiase.

It was recounted to me that the first yell that emanated from me after my mother extruded me into the world could be heard outside the walls of the health center. This was, perhaps, to underscore the fact that I was not ready to come and add on to the misery of my already burdened mother.

The Akwasiase Health Center was an upscale birthing place compared to the usual home births handled by the traditional birth attendants at the time. I supposed my parents wanted to give me the best chance of survival.

With limited resources in such health centers, perinatal complications usually ended up in disaster. The presence of high maternal and infant mortality rate at the time meant that birth in these health centers, without incident, was considered a treasure.

The underpinnings of such health centers at the time was that they could not handle perinatal complications. But in the midst of absolute poverty that engulfed the whole village, it was the best there was at the time. Many children who had complicated births were

unlucky to make the first cry, and likewise, their mothers perished in the process.

My mother was already a professional in having babies at the time it was my turn, and my birth went smoothly without an incident. I was lucky.

Mabang was my sweet village where my mother brought me back after my successful birth at Akwasiase Health Center.

The beginning of my life's journey

The village sprang up from a thick forest that was, at the time, a perfect ecology for wild animals. Antelopes, grasscutters, baboons, and snakes abounded and ruled the forest. By this virtue, it was a dreamland for hunters.

The chiefs from the nearest metropolitan city of Kumasi, ninety-four kilometers (eighty miles) away, would send their hunters to this location to hunt for wild animals. The animals were treasured for their meat, but more particularly, for their skin, which was used for various ornaments, garments, and craftwork.

Many of the hunters made stopovers in huts in the forest. These huts clustered near a major river in the forest. The modern-day Mabang developed from these clusters.

Today, one main road, running from nearby Tepa, crosses the village to the forest beyond. This was the ancient hunting route that has now been tarred.

Unlike many other villages in other parts of the country, the early settlers had some kind of town planning in place. Even though there was no particular order of the footprints of the huts, there were clear demarcations of major pathways that allowed easy access to their homes and movement of goods. This was a semblance of town planning.

Among the clusters of huts splattered in the forests, there appeared to be a pattern. Each cluster probably represented closer family members living at earshot from each other.

Today, with modern civilization, the major pathways became streets and avenues that perfectly separated the splattered huts into blocks. A credit for the early intelligence of my ancestors.

Many homes in Mabang were constructed with red clay. The wealthier would plaster the walls with cement and flavor it with colorful paint.

The roof also made a statement about your wealth. While the rich used iron sheets, the poor resorted to cheap and abundant grass roofing—the thatched roof.

The windows were paradoxically but purposefully made small. In the tropical heat, one would expect larger windows to allow free fresh air. But our ancestors were rather preoccupied with limiting the entry of flying creatures whose access into the dwelling might be reduced by a smaller opening in the wall.

The flooring was mostly hardened dry clay. Cemented floors were for rich folks. Tiling was not in their vocabulary and, indeed, futuristic.

Life in Mabang was very rudimentary. There was no electricity. The nights that rapidly crept on us when the sun set were pitch dark. Moonlight represented streetlights. The cyclical moonlight days were joyous as the fuzzy clarity gave the additional extension of the day. The additional visibility allowed us to roam the streets at night.

On periodic occasions, which occurred in a *blue moon*, we were mesmerized by the clarity of the visibility when the moon appeared larger than usual. In retrospect, it was an astrological rarity—the *supermoon*.

But as we were secluded from modern civilization, this was a phenomenon I never had a word for until well into my adulthood.

On the moonless nights, the starry skies on cloudless nights in the distance lightened the pitch darkness and gave us hope that all was not lost.

The shooting stars, a mystical experience of most nights, indicated to me the complexity of the world that the village could ever have imagined. The occasional close encounters of these flying lights as they came close to Earth became the talk of the town for many days.

Mabang had no running water. A spring, gushing out from the nearest mountain, was the main river that meandered around the village. It was half a mile away from the nearest house and was our main source of drinking water.

This was equally the main source of drinking water for any living creature that required hydration for survival in our vicinity. It was indeed a shared natural resource—animals by night and humans by day.

When dawn broke, every household in the village would pay homage to the river, one bucketful at a time, to fetch water. The more upstream we fetched the water, the more we thought it was cleaner.

The drinking water would be stored in a large pot made of baked clay. In order to keep the water cool, the whole pot was buried in a lump of clay in one corner of the kitchen. A lid over the pot prevented flying objects from entering the pot. Water for other household chores was stored in barrels on the compound.

We drank the river water without any processing. Perhaps it was wholesome. It just came out of the mountain. But it was evidently mineral-rich as we had strong, healthy teeth and very infrequent iodine-deficient goiters.

The many impurities of bacteria and sediment that it carried from the riverbed did not deter us from drinking the water. We had no other choice. After all, it was not obvious to the naked eye. It was probably an immunization booster that prepared us for the prevailing rough health terrain.

The sanitation in Mabang was a challenge. Open defecation was common. You could urinate anywhere you felt was private to you.

Community toilets were created to avert diseases that were associated with open defecation. These were the latrines.

With voluntary labor from the community, a trench would be dug in the ground approximately six feet deep and ten feet long. Long planks separated by squatting distance would span the trench. The perimeter was covered with wood for privacy. Roofing was provided with sheets of aluminum or thatch.

The latrines were usually located on the outskirts of the village. There was one for males and another for females. There was no provision of handwashing in these latrines. This contributed to the high incidence of communicable diseases that spread by the fecal-oral route. Typhoid and worm infestations were common, and periodically, cholera outbreaks would come in and sweep away a few lives.

Flies abounded in Mabang and were a nuisance in most homes. They had a perfect nursery, man-made for their perpetuation—the latrines.

The maggots and young flies that filled these latrines and the stench that emanated from them made defecation an endurance. With each droplet, wailing flies were displaced, and many would touch parts of our sacred bodies.

Old newspapers were substitutes for toilet rolls.

Some households averted the use of the public latrines. These were the relatively elite and wealthy. They had toilets in their homes.

A raised concrete platform, in a room designated for a toilet, had a round hole at the top and opened at the back of the room to accommodate a collecting bucket. The human waste was collected in the bucket. Interval collection of the waste was performed by a department of latrine men.

The latrine men department was made up of a workforce comprising men at the lowest socioeconomic echelon. Many of these men would be alien to the village in search of better jobs.

Mabang was blessed with rich natural resources. The virgin thick tropical forest was a source of rich timber for construction and furniture. This was mostly exploited by timber companies alien to the village. They did not have a heart to replant to replace what they took.

Today Mabang is now a savanna land. There are remnants of occasional trees with no commercial value to remind itself of its past rich forest and the basis of which the village came into being.

Just like timber, Mabang sits on an abundance of gold. Multinational companies found this village a breadbasket. They mercilessly took away the gold. With lack of compassion to the local

economy and the indigenous residents, they left no footprint of the wealth that they usurped.

By virtue of its rich natural resources, Mabang could have stood tall and been counted among cities such as Johannesburg, South Africa, whose development was solely based on its local natural resources.

But the reckless depletion of the natural resources has left the village impoverished. Many buildings, marketplaces, and my former childhood recreational centers are pitifully crumbling down in absolute shame. As if that was not enough, the only source of drinking water has been polluted with dirt and mercury by the gold mining activities.

Mabang prided itself on beautiful tropical weather. It was hot all year round. The occasional humidity sometimes made the heat unbearable. Two rainy seasons, major and minor, gave a reprieve from the constant hot weather. The split rainy season allowed farmers, whose agricultural practices were weather-dependent, to grow crops twice a year to feed its inhabitants.

During these rainy seasons, amid spectacular lightning and roaring thunder, the skies would open and flood the little village's rudimentary drainage system. Movement of people and goods would be impeded for many hours or even days after the rains.

The *harmattan* weather came once a year. It was a relatively cold weather, during which southward winds, gathering dust blowing over the Sahara Desert, polluted our atmosphere. The whole air would be foggy from the dust—perhaps a hotter version of gloomy, wintery, snowy days of the temperate regions—and reminded us that Christmas was just around the corner.

Christmas was a cherished annual festivity during which we could be lucky to eat chicken, drink Coca-Cola, and have new clothes for church.

The main economic activity of Mabang was farming. Every household produced their own food, and the excess was sold for cash. The rich, fertile soil could grow any crop. The main ones included cocoa, maize, cassava, and cocoyam.

The market, which is now in ruins, was the center for trading our agricultural products. There were set market days each week during which traders from far and wide would convene. Many households were able to exchange their farm produce for cash, but others would simply do so for items such as fish, groceries, and household items—a barter system that benefited both parties.

We had no television in the entire village. In our secluded world it did not matter. It was not in our vocabulary. We did not miss what we did not have.

The transistor radio was our main contact with the external world. The Akasanoma Radio was the brand. It was a square box with the entire front end taken over by a large loudspeaker, and a long, lanky, extensible antenna extruded from one corner.

This radio was a luxury item and the pride of wealth in a household. It took the center stage of any living room decoration and was adorned with expensive lace material befitting its status. Not many households could pride themselves on this luxury.

It broadcast only limited channels, mainly the government-controlled stations of GBC 1 and GBC 2. This was our only exposure to the external world.

The village was, literally, timeless. We had no watches. This was, again, a luxury item. The wealthy homes had a wall clock whose hourly chimes would aid neighbors in telling the time. But the majority of the village folks would depend on nature for time.

The equatorial sunrise and sunset were used to measure time. It was fairly accurate for their purposes. Sunrise was 6:00 a.m., your shadow directly under you was midday, and sunset was 6:00 p.m.

The cock's crow was an additional aid to predicting the rise of the sun. The first crow was usually 3:00 a.m.; this would be solo and appeared to emanate from the wisest male chicken. The second was 4:00 a.m., from a location other than the first. The third one, the noisiest—when all the cocks would crow somehow in unison and appeared to be in jubilation of the dawning next day—was at 5:00 a.m.

The main religion of the village was Christianity. The Presbyterian denomination took a dominant foothold in the village.

It was represented with a prominent rectangular edifice, perhaps the biggest building in the village at the time. The huge sign of the cross mounted in front provided its legitimacy as an uncontested religious monument.

Today, the church still stands, but lack of maintenance has taken its toll, and one can only dream of the good old days of the building.

There were other people in the village who did not count themselves as Christians, or perhaps not yet converted from their ancestral worship practices by the invading alien missionaries. They were the pagans.

The pagans worshipped other deities. The smaller gods represented a bigger spirit above, whom they considered to be the Almighty Creator.

Indeed, until Western civilization arrived in Africa to make inferior our religious practices, all of Africa had their own religion. The missionaries usurped our religious heritage by polluting our minds that Christianity and Islam were the only way to the Almighty.

But a critical look at the principles of belief of our ancestors and that of Western civilizations shows many similarities. For example, they all believed in the presence of a supernatural creator, whom our ancestors named *Nyame*. This is equivalent to God the Almighty.

The religious practices of our ancestors that began from the beginning of their existence have been passed on from generation to generation. They worshipped the Almighty through mundane objects such as stones and rivers.

The juju men became the distinguished representatives of the African religion. They were the men who performed rituals and interceded between man and spirit.

When we were growing up, these spiritualists were revered by their dichotomous powers. On one hand, they were believed to be healers that would cast evil spirits and demons out of the sick. On the other hand, they were believed to inflict harm on people when consulted to do so. You dare not challenge a juju man.

The village was also gripped by many superstitions. Christians and non-Christians were equally afflicted. The strong overpowering

presence of witchcraft in the community added additional driving force to the individual's religious inclination.

In retrospect, the whole village was shortsighted and naive. Many unexplained phenomena were attributed to spirits or the devil. Sickness, deaths, and even the wrath of natural phenomena—from lightning to the wind—all had spiritual connotations.

These beliefs were the underpinnings that inflamed religious practices. Spiritual interception was the only way of allaying the fears from these spurious and outlandish beliefs. Women, the witches, were accused in disproportionate abundance compared to men, the wizards. The basis of the accusation was very bizarre. Any unexplained disease, death, or accident was attributed to a spiritual attack by witchcraft.

The characteristics of a typical witch were as follows: elderly, widowed, childless, aunt, lonely, *edentulous* facial disfigurement. Indeed, many women fell into this category.

You only had to wait to grow old, and it would be your turn to be accused.

Women accused of witchcraft became psychologically tarnished, and many would flee into exile to escape the mental torture.

Modern healthcare delivery system in Mabang was practically nonexistent. Management of the sick was dependent on the beliefs of the family. Healing was provided by the herbalist, juju men, or spiritual healers.

The semblance to any orthodox healthcare delivery system was the health post at Akwasiase. This was about three miles away. The highest level of the provider was an experienced nurse.

Many people becoming incapacitated by minor ailments rode the wave and relied on the body's own immune system. Sickness usually took its natural course, and the outcome was accepted. Others might seek the assistance of a herbalist or a juju man to expedite the healing process.

The association of sickness and the spirit was so strong that serious illnesses such as stroke were immediately taken to the juju man or the spiritual healer, depending on their religious affiliation.

Many villagers survived minor illnesses, but those who succumbed to the major diseases would attribute it to nature's natural selection.

The distinction between the juju man and the herbalist sometimes paled. The herbalist, who acquired the skill from his ancestors, might add a bit of *juju* to appear credible and legitimate. This was simply and purely in tandem with people's beliefs of the origin of disease.

The healing ritual of a juju man was usually performed with the blood of a sacrificed chicken or goat. He would use herbs to prepare concoctions. Doses were administered in cupfuls. The same concoction would treat multiple ailments.

The juju man might go further to offer an explanation of the cause of the ailments. The spiritually skewed-minded clients were quick to accept causative factors such as a family curse, witchcraft, and so on.

Spiritual healers also played a role in the health of the villagers. This was the port of call for some unbelievers in the African religion. Hope was the backdrop of their beliefs, and prayers would produce a miraculous healing. The seriously ill would be gathered in prayer camps where they hoped intense prayers would drive away the devil that possessed them.

Indeed ailments that afflicted the village were very basic. Infections were the main bulk. Affliction by illnesses such as hypertension, diabetes, glaucoma, kidney failures were simply a ticking time bomb.

Mabang did not have a dentist. We kept our teeth clean in our own traditional way. We chewed on a piece of wood, and the frayed portion was then used to thoroughly clean the teeth. The process was associated with spitting out the excess saliva anywhere convenient around you. It was a morning ritual that our parents would insist on.

Many of us had strong, healthy teeth despite the lack of modern dentistry. The chewing sticks—such as *sokodua*, *obrofonkatee*, and the *nim*—contained chemicals such as lectins and tannic acid. These are potent antibacterial agents that prevent periodontal diseases and tooth decay by reducing oral bacterial growth.

Eye care in Mabang was also nonexistent. The aged were afflicted with perpetual loss of sight. Age-related refraction deficiencies, glaucoma, and cataracts were rampant. Many artisans, whose trade depended on high visual acuity, got affected. Tailors and seamstresses prematurely lost their ability to make a living from their profession.

Indeed, in the face of the limited resources during sickness, growing up into adulthood in Mabang was only a miracle. Life expectancy was short. People died prematurely. We battled our sicknesses with inferior means. We lived because our immune systems were able to withstand the odds.

Living beyond the age of fifty-five in Mabang was a feat. Women had a bit more advantage. At the time, I thought people were much older. But on the contrary, manual labor in the scorching sun, edentulous facial disfigurement, eye loss from glaucoma, and so on made them appear so.

However, there were a few age-barrier breakers. These were the occasional octogenarians and even centenarians. They were the diehards. They had exceptional traits that defied all the odds. They were endowed with a longevity gene that made mockery of the harsh and unforgiving environmental encumbrances.

Premature deaths in the village meant rampant funeral ceremonies were a major part of the village activity. I can recall this as being more of a real mourning when compared to the modern-day fashion-oriented celebration of death.

Mourners really cried. A cry that was so infectious that it sent neighbors and friends doing so. The solemn moment was marked by many days of mourning, a prolonged parting goodbye in a world where time appeared relatively abundant.

Formal education system extended to Mabang. The school, made up of two main structures, was located on one end of the village across the main road. One was a basic structure of six rooms with a long veranda to represent class one to class six; and the other had a set of four rooms to represent form one to form four.

The structures were constructed with clay. The roofing, made from iron sheets, was a perfectly undesired heat transducer into a

classroom on a hot sunny day. The large uncovered windows allowed for ventilation. The floors were usually cemented.

The whole structure looked unfinished. It needed a few touches to be conducive for a classroom. But in my lifetime, it was the best we ever got. The alternative was to have our lessons under the trees.

Today the school has seen its better days. The merciless weather and lack of maintenance culture of the society have rendered the structures deplorable and unsafe. The leaking roof hardly provides shelter on rainy days.

The school had a huge park to serve as a playground. Provisions were made for the main sporting activities of football, netball, and volleyball, respectively.

The few tables and chairs provided by the government were not enough to seat every child. We improvised by doubling up. Few pupils brought their own furniture.

The system of education was British. The criteria to begin the first year of school was very strict. You must be at least six years of age. That is, if you could prove it. Many of us were born with unrecorded birth dates and had no birth certificates.

In order to circumvent this problem, another eligibility criterion was put in place. Wrap one arm over your head to touch the opposite ear. If you could do that without a struggle, you were at least six years old. You were mature enough to start your primary education.

Indeed many children in the village with challenges of physical growth and without certificates to prove their age found themselves starting school very late.

The primary education was for six years. This was followed by another four years in middle school. You would graduate with a middle school leaving certificate that allowed you to enter the workforce.

Further education was a secondary school for five years, followed by a sixth form education for another two years. Finally you would be admitted into the university.

The criterion to enter into secondary school was a success in a common entrance examination. This was open to any pupil from the second year of middle school education.

Secondary education was only available to financially able families; not all smart children had the privilege for further education.

Pupils and students in the educational system were supervised with iron hands. Corporal punishment was the order of the day. Inability to mentally recall certain basic facts like the multiplication table, attending school late, making noise in class, and truancy were some of the infringements that would call for the cane.

In retrospect, many of the truant children had unidentified psychosocial problems, such as attention deficit disorder, whose solution lay in psychotherapy. *Canning* was a flame that made their condition even worse. Indeed they endured a miserable formal education.

The British educational system was good to some extent but had undesirable fringes. Many products of this educational system were left with the opinion that our culture was inferior. This was a brainwash with undesirable consequences. And, compared to other civilizations, this educational system focused on the ability to memorize and regurgitate rather than application to real-life situations.

Today Mabang is a ghost of its potential richness. It has been usurped by heartless exploiters who took away its natural resources—gold and timber—and left behind absolute poverty and dilapidated homes.

I met some of my childhood friends when I visited. They never had the opportunity to leave the village. They are cheerful and happy to see me and ask for little coins. They are the pride of Mabang patriots, for better or for worse. But they have weathered and look much older.

MY MOTHER

My mother, Akua Addae, was the architect of my success. The actions she took in the face of glaring poverty became my stepping stone—a rolling stone that opened many doors for my existence. This had set the stage that, either by destiny or serendipity, made me the jewel in the crown of my family.

I am a direct replica of her endurance and epitome of her tenacity. These were the virtues that permitted her to withstand all the odds she weathered in Mabang.

She was a true breed of Mabang. The Wednesday-born, Akua Addae, was an indigenous patriot who knew no other place as a home than the forestry village of Mabang.

Her father, Kweku Dwemoh, emigrated to Mabang in search of greener pastures. He was among the early pioneers that settled in huts that eventually became Mabang. Large-scale farming was his main objective, and emigrating from Kumasi to the Ahafo region in search of virgin lands was the order of the day for young and ambitious farmers.

Her mother, Abena Kwabena, was a successful businesswoman—a general trader with distinguished repute and well established in Mabang. She was well-known for her magnanimity and provided employment for the youth in the community, some of whom she housed in her premises.

As many as ten youths would share a room. They were just as happy to find shelter to sleep whilst earning some money from the generous employer.

Grandma Abena Kwabena lived in the only upscale rented compound home in Mabang. The pearl of the village had a manned security gate and house toilet for the residents—an abode that distinguished the haves and have-nots.

My mother was a product of two distinguished grandparents. It was a *mélange* that defined her adult life—a go-getter that was not only ambitious but also astute. She was unstoppable. She had a lighter brown complexion than her peers and an average physical height for a Ghanaian woman. Her physical fitness was a reflection of hard labor on the farm and home chores when she was growing up. Laziness was not in her vocabulary.

She did not have any formal education. At the time, formal education was reserved for boys. Girls were reared for marriage. Educated girls could sometimes have challenges in finding husbands.

My mother had a calm and imposing demeanor, a virtue I have also proudly inherited. She had fewer words, and her utterances carried a lot of weight that could move mountains.

She was a good listener and adjudged an unbiased arbitrator—a go-to person during major family and neighbor brawls.

My mother took after her mother's line of work—an astute trader. Her main merchandise was plantains. She applied the principles she had learned from working with her mother in her own business. The trustworthiness that was inculcated in her became the backdrop to a successful business.

Her plantain business took her to markets outside the local area. She would bring truckloads of plantains credited from the local farmers to Mabang. Now a distributor of plantain, the young, astute businesswoman would replicate herself by allowing multiple market women in Mabang to resell her merchandise.

My mother also had an exceptional ability that she passed on to her kids, a gift that could have made a difference had she had the opportunity to acquire a formal education. She was extremely intelligent.

This became evident when she mentored an old schoolteacher who wanted to learn the trade. The former followed her with pen

and paper to record the transactions, but Mum, who could not read nor write, looked on in amazement.

She did not have to do any paperwork. She was like a computer making a mental register of all her transactions. Her magnetic memory and mental alacrity were rare feats that dropped the jaw of the schoolteacher.

My father met my mother in the market. An astute businesswoman with lighter complexion and a unique physique did not escape the relatively more educated tax collector. He was put off his tracks whilst performing his normal duties. It was love at first sight.

Polygamy was well entrenched in the village, and my father was no exception. He already had multiple concubines before meeting my mother. He could not resist another trophy—the stunning and intelligent teenager—to his collections. There were probably no laws prohibiting underage marriages at the time.

In polygamous unions, the women did not necessarily have to live with the man. And my dad did not allow any of the concubines to live with him in Akwasiase. Even my mother, who was legally married to my dad, continued to live in her own home with my grandmother. It was a kind of distant marriage. She lived in Mabang, and her husband lived three miles away in Akwasiase.

My mother served my father when it was her turn. During this period, she would cook and ask one of the children to walk the three-mile journey to Akwasiase to serve my father. And in the night, she would walk the three-mile journey to be with him. This appeared to be work, but it did not matter when your pride of being married to a tax collector was a rare prestige in the community.

Soon my teenage mother became pregnant when she was fourteen years old. She had my elder brother. I was next to come.

The cry of my entry into this world, displayed at the Akwasiase Health Post, was probably an expectation of a tough childhood to come.

My mother was young, with a very high fertility index. My father was only interested in producing children, with no particular interest in nurturing them.

The union was a perfect storm for our production. We popped out, one after the other, like popcorn. By the time she was twenty-six years old, my mother was a young mother with six children—four boys and two girls.

As our numbers increased and there was no nanny, we became each other's keeper. The older ones looked after the younger ones. My father was missing in action. He contributed very little to our upkeep.

The voracious appetite of four growing boys and two girls would dent the finances of even the well-to-do. But my mother was not wealthy.

Even though she had a good head start as a trader, the sheer burden of an apparent single parent with multiple mouths to feed quickly crippled her thriving enterprise.

The anguish on Mum's face during mealtimes told it all. We all ate from the same bowl. To get full, you had to eat faster than your sibling. And even using these tactics, we were still hungry after the meal. Mum would eat less so that we could eat more.

The youngest siblings, who could not keep up with the pace, were receiving the short end of the stick. Occasionally they would stop in the middle of the feeding race and sob in despair. Some would throw in the towel and totally abandon the meal. Mum would helplessly look on and endure the psychological trauma. Even after giving up her portion, the children could still not have a square meal.

Mom only persevered to give us a better life. She kept the vending stall in the local market. With the constraint of six children putting her plantain wholesale business in tatters, she continued the small-scale retail business. This prevented the debacle that could have wrecked the little struggling family.

In the 1980s, there was a failed government policy that attempted to make the country self-reliant on agricultural products. There was a ban on importation of food. The unforeseen severe drought that hit the country that period created extreme shortage of locally produced foodstuff.

Prices of food items rose as the shortage got worse. Government tried to arrest the situation by artificially fixing the retail prices for

almost anything. Any trader selling above the set prices was summoned by the law enforcement personnel.

My mother, in dire need of the extra cash to feed her hungry children, became a culprit of overpricing. Indeed she was only doing simple economics—price controlled by supply and demand.

She was arrested and charged with overpricing. The then military regime did not have the luxury of a civil trial. A corporal punishment usually settled the charge and served as a deterrent for prospective offenders.

Then came the divorce. My father, who was scarcely seen in our lives, decided to close the chapter and officially leave my mother. He left the scene, never to be seen again. We had no one to point to as a father.

Anguish gripped us all. The pain and suffering were evident, a psychological torture from an already dire situation. We were helpless kids with nothing to offer but to console Mom.

But Mother did not cry over the spilled milk. She took it all in her stride. She did not have to bother over what had not been present in the first place. She felt it was only a bump in the road. She needed to be strong and handle the situation.

She wiped the dust off her back and faced life head-on.

She devised a strategy that would have changed our lives forever. Little did I know it was a call of destiny that became a watershed moment for my success. At the time, it was heartbreaking, but it all made sense as the dawn broke and everything started falling into place.

One by one, Mom distributed us among her brothers and sisters. Our union of little boys and girls was physically disintegrated. We were literally scattered across Ghana, depending on where she could find a willing sibling—from extreme north to the south, my mom's soul had contact on the ground.

We sincerely missed each other. The opportunity of siblings growing up together eluded us. But every one of us, including my mom, benefited from the breakup.

Mom was able to pick up her trading business again. She became even more successful. She regained her glory as a business tycoon, well-respected among her contemporaries.

The village was no longer able to contain her business empire. Everything was on a smaller scale. She wanted to relocate to a larger city—an opportunity that would give her access to a larger market. The metropolitan city of Kumasi, the home of her father, was the obvious choice. The move was rewarding.

At a ripe age of seventy-eight years, Mom gracefully transitioned to the Lord from natural causes after being afflicted for many years by hypertension and diabetes.

MY FATHER

Dad was Kwaku Amankwa. I had little to no contact with him when I was growing up. Nor did I have the boisterous encounters as would in a typical coupled family. I did not have him as a father to run to when I was scolded by my mother and grandmother.

But I knew I had a dad. As did all my siblings, full-blooded and half-blooded alike. We shared the same experience and sentiments of not having the presence of a father in our lives. He was like a mirage. One moment he was there. The next moment he would disappear.

He was a producer of babies. He had no intention to nurture them in his image. The long absences of a father made us mommy boys. He was present but absent from my life's experience. And so we grew up with values reflecting that of our beloved mother.

The characteristics of our paternal grandparents have, obviously, eluded us. It was a mystery. He never talked about them during the brief encounters we had with him. I never knew anything about his mother. I never saw her before. He never talked about her.

His father, my paternal grandfather, appeared to be a local hero. He was well-to-do by the measure of the village hierarchy. I vaguely remembered him. His wealth was tangible.

Like most of the villagers, my paternal grandfather had a house that was made of mud. The difference was that the multiple rooms, each representing a unit for each wife, joined into a square. The center was an open compound and was gated. It had a kitchen and a toilet.

This house, now in ruins in Akwasiase, was where my dad lived most of his life. This was where he was served by multiple wives who never had the opportunity to live with him. A house that appeared also to be a tourist center for the many children. We came and went with no attachment.

Like most children growing up, we thought our parents were much taller; but indeed, my dad was average built and much shorter than his peers. He looked physically fit and did not have much redundant fat. He was a beneficiary of the automatic physical activity imposed on all the villagers.

Farming activity was a default exercise by all the villagers. Lack of vehicular transport made walking the only means to get around.

His darker complexion blended in with general characteristics of the Ashanti tribe. Certainly he would have spotted my mom from a distance among the crowd due to her lighter complexion.

Like my mom, he was soft-spoken and mellowed in mannerism.

By the village standard, my dad was among village elites. He achieved the highest level of education there was in the village. A Middle Leaving Certificate was the pride of any household. A certificate, acquired at the age of sixteen to seventeen years, ensured a position in the government workforce. And he did it.

My father became a Kwame Nkrumalite. These were the postindependence elites chosen for the Town Council. All must possess, as a minimum, the prestigious qualification of a middle school leaving certificate.

The Town Council was put in place by the first president of the republic, Osagefo Dr. Kwame Nkrumah. Their function was to ensure tax was collected from every taxable item. This included every trading activity, however small, property taxes, and so on.

They were also charged with environmental hygiene. They ensured all households kept their homes and surroundings clean and without litter. Garbage was collected and disposed of according to the approved norm.

The employees of the town council were revered and feared by their high level of integrity. They were uncorrupted and performed

their duty according to the inherited principles of the outgoing British colonial rulers.

They were simply called the *Tancas*, a shortened version of town council, that the villagers could not get their tongue around. And so my father was a *Tancas*, a man of integrity revered and feared.

My dad would have been performing his duty in the market in the distinctive uniform of the *Tancas*: Khaki shorts, khaki shirt, a helmetlike headgear, and well-polished shoes, when he chanced upon my teenage mother.

A proposal from a *Tancas*, a village giant, was an honor that could not be declined. And so my mother fell in love with the tax collector.

Following the overthrow of Osagyefo Dr. Kwame Nkrumah, the ensuing government and their policies belittled the function of the *Tancas* people. Local tax collection, environmental hygiene, and so on splattered on the ground and dissipated into oblivion.

With the dwindling income from the vanishing lucrative job of a *Tancas*, Dad decided to establish a cocoa farm. This was in another village further in the Ahafo Region. It was called Gambia No. 2, a couple of miles away from Mim, where he was accompanied by my mother.

He initially lived on the farm until it was well established. This was with the help of paid alien manual laborers from different parts of Ghana. The farm was scaled up and the income would have been above average.

He moved back to Akwasiase after a while to live separately from my mum. But I still remembered his trips with us, the kids, to the cocoa farm during his visits. He would take supplies and goodies to the farm laborers in appreciation of their labor.

But life was not the same after he moved back. Sentiments with my mother were different and began to turn sour. The relationship started a downward decline. Dad had found another woman.

Eventually, Dad called for divorce. He married the new woman. Reminiscent of the rapid extrusion of babies with my mother, Dad had a rapid succession of births, seven of them, with the new wife who also lived in a different abode.

Dad had other children with other women. In all, he had about seventeen children. We did not grow up together in the same space as siblings. Today we could pass each other by without recognizing we share the same father.

One peculiarity about Dad was that he never had the intention of living with any of his wives. As weird as this may sound, it may be a characteristic of many people who just do not want to be bothered with the tentacles of their wife when they live under the same roof. And lack of the responsibility of parenting may just as well be a consequence of this egoistic behavior.

Dad lived in the village all his life. He was counted among the die-hards as he was able to withstand all the nuances of health hazards prevalent in the village. He broke the age barrier of early deaths.

About the age of seventy-five, he suffered a stroke. With the strong bond of blood, one of his uncared-for sons, my junior brother, was the family hero that came to his rescue. He moved our ailing father from the Akwasiase to live with him in Kumasi.

The laudable end to the paternal drama was the care and comfort my junior brother provided to the woman who accompanied my ailing dad. She was the very woman whom my father left my mother for.

Had karma taken its full compliments, the contrary would have been expressed, and the deserved effect would have caused undesirable pain and suffering.

MY CHILDHOOD

Many people may not remember the beginning of the earlier years of their childhood. You entered the world as a newborn, totally became dependent on a parent who cared for you and nurtured you. You fussed around with tantrums, you ransacked the house, and yet you could remember none of those.

Then a moment dawned when you were able to remember your existence by your deeds and experiences. This was a self-awareness period. It was a watershed moment that you were no longer a baby. The age to achieve this developmental milestone varied from person to person.

This was followed by a period of self-consciousness, which defined how you felt people perceived you. You suddenly became aware of your private body parts and began to feel shy when exposed naked.

I vaguely remembered when we used to run naked in the rain during the heavy storms and rode the waves of the floodwater on my mother's blind side. We did this naively and were exposed to infected floodwater. This contained washed human excrement scattered around the bushes as a result of the practice of open defecation.

I must have been about four years old—the commencement of my unintentional exposure to potential health hazards. Obviously, the challenge to my immune system started very early, probably too prematurely. I survived it and, most likely, it toughened me up.

I remembered my transition from the self-awareness period to the self-conscious period. My usual routine of bathing my body

naked in plain view of the household in the compound of our house became more and more uncomfortable. I became progressively shy in doing so until, eventually, I had to use the designated shower room.

Therefore the watershed moment of the recollection of my childhood memory started around the age of four to five years. From this point onward, I was able to vividly remember my life's story, though some of it came with a deep extraction of the memorable events.

My mother was obviously in a distant relationship with my dad. Whilst my father lived separately in Akwasiase, my teenage mother continued to live with her mother in Mabang. And so my grandmother's home became the abode for six children and a quasi-single mother.

Therefore we were happily raised by two mothers—a stern grandmother and a loving mother. We were in our own world: happy children, a whole life's journey in front of us, with all its nuances and complexities.

The luxury of having multiple clothes and changing them at will was alien to us. We wore the same clothes every day of the year. We kept them clean by washing them at night just before we went to bed. By the following morning, the residual night heat and the gentle breeze had dried them.

The redundant moisture in the clothes usually dried up when we wore them in the heat generated by the fast-rising equatorial sun.

The clothes were replaced only when they were in complete tatters or when we had outgrown them. But my mother tried to get a good mileage from the clothes by buying them a bit larger for me. When I complained, she would tell me I would grow into them.

Shopping for our clothing was very straightforward. We did not have a say in what was given to us. It was an autocratic regime, and we wore what was given to us.

The clothes seller was in the same market as my mother. The clothes were secondhand ones. We called them *obroniwawu*. This means “the clothes from a dead White man.”

We did not have any footwear. We all walked barefooted. You were easily noticed if you wore one. And if you did, even with slip-

pers, it could be misconstrued as showing off by a pompous, privileged child.

The Christmas season was different and always memorable. We had a special treat. There were no Santa Claus hypes of gullible generosity. But even if there were, any gift we got was anything other than generous. They were just pragmatic.

In order to appear decent in church during the Christmas festivities, my mother dug into her savings to provide us with new clothes and footwear.

The local tailors were tasked to make that happen. We did not have the choice of choosing the material. But during the measurement, we would, for the first time, have a say in the design.

Our additional Christmas goodies were the opportunity to have new footwear, either a pair of sandals or a pair of shoes.

The footwear was only adorned to go to church. When we came back from church, we removed them and continued our normal living—barefooted.

This probably explained the unique culture peculiar to Ghanaians, and probably to deprived societies: To put on the best clothes, as if going to a party, when they were going to worship.

Growing up as a child, as far back as I could remember, was like a labor camp. It certainly was not forced labor, but it appeared to be the first responsibility of a child's living.

Playing was a luxury activity and was frowned upon by many parents. This could label you as a lazy child who had no aim in this world.

The types of labor we performed varied and commenced as soon as we were serviceable. We were part of the household workforce and extra hands of any adult labor activity. The typical workday started at dawn and ended at dusk.

The first chore in the morning was to provide water for the household. We happily did this in style. With the morning routine of a chewing stick in our mouths and spitting around haphazardly, a piece of cloth wrapped around one's body and tied behind our neck, we were each provided with a bucket and a head pad. We made the

half-a-mile trek on the winding and uneven twisting pathway to the only stream in Mabang.

Carrying the water on our heads back to the house could sometimes turn into a race of who got home first. Indeed the whole morning routine turned us into physically fit children who were exercising without knowing.

Sweeping the compound was a chore that was interchanged with the fetching of water. It was an exercise which, when not done thoroughly, could land your parents into trouble with the *Tancas*. We did this with impeccable skill to keep our surroundings clean.

Farming activity was our second nature. We were trained how to use the cutlass at a very young age. The skill came with experience. And the experience was associated with multiple accidents with the cutlass. Laceration to the shin was the most common form of the accident. We patched the wound with crushed herbal preparation and life went on. The healing took days to weeks, and many of us ended up with the telltale shin scars.

We farmed barefooted. Foot injuries were also common from piercing objects. Tetanus was common, and afflicted children did not have a chance.

And this was my reality: a child farmer. I did not know otherwise or, better still, did not have a choice. It was one of the many duties of a Mabang boy. I became good at it because I would be the one my mother called upon to check if the plantains were mature enough to harvest.

We farmed plantain, cocoyam, corn, cassava, pepper, and so on. The tropical soil could grow anything. But without a hands-on father, our scale was minuscule. And, therefore, in the presence of what appeared to be a fertile agricultural land, we were undernourished, severe enough to put us behind in our physical development.

Whatever produce we had from the farm, we sold most of it in exchange for money. It was the only means of having currency—currency that my mother would use in exchange for other services; currency that came in seasonally and touched only when the need to replace our clothes arose.

The toil of carrying the foodstuff on my head from the farm to the market was all worth it when I saw my new *obroniwawu* replacing its older generation.

Considering all the health hazards encountered in the village, we were hardly sick. Any fever condition was considered a blood poisoning from unwanted toxins in the gut. This was a rudimentary medical analysis with broad strokes that covered the pathogenesis of many communicable diseases.

The treatment was always unidirectional and based on that premise. The purgative was the solution to the problem. This was given either orally or rectally.

The oral route was achieved with either castor oil or a mixture called *Mist Alba*. The taste of these two medications was horrible, but our parents assumed that it would not have been called medicine if the taste was otherwise.

Somehow my mum would figure out when to use the rectal route. This was reserved for more serious fevers and upon consultation with the elderly wise men in the village.

The characteristically red enema bottle, with a white pointed spout, was the scary object that took the breath out of the confidence of every child in Mabang. If sickness were intentional, this object alone would drive away all sicknesses.

When I had one of those fevers, various leaves selected from the forest would be crushed, and the concoction produced would be administered through my backside. This would, usually, not go without a fight. The stronger siblings would hold me down during the process. The tears, together with the ensuing torrential all-day diarrhea, would dry me up like a crispy toast.

Playtime, frowned upon by many parents, was allowed when there were no house chores. We did not have much to play with. No one bought us toys of any form. Every object we needed to play with was improvised by our own ingenuity and imagination.

We made cars from clay or the raffia plant. We rolled old car tires along the open areas. We sometimes held racing events where we competed by running and rolling the car tire along.

Absence of television in the village did not bother us. We did not miss anything we did not know of.

In the dark night, under the illumination of a kerosene lamp, we played table games such as Ludo, Snakes and Ladders, and card games.

We roamed the town on the nights when the visibility was permitted by the moonlight. We would do this until we were tired.

Storytelling was very common. The skilled storytellers in the village were well-known. My grandmother was one of them. When she was in a good mood, she would call us to gather in the dark evening. She would sit on a stool whilst we sat on the ground in front of her. A smoky kerosene lamp would be placed at a convenient place to illuminate her and give the desired visual effect of the narrator.

The arrangement was like a movie house for us. Better still, the effect was the same. None of us had been to a movie before. It did not make a difference.

The story was audio, the pictures were in our minds—imaginary—and the narrator was a real and tangible human.

With smiles on our naive faces, we would eagerly await the opening of the first story. There were stories about the spider, antelopes, and the hare. The spider stories were our favorites due to its wisdom and astuteness.

There was usually an interlude where the storyteller would introduce a short song. We would clap for the rhythm as we sang. After about four or five stories, the show would come to an end.

When I was a bit older, I came to a painful realization that the stories were made up and did not actually happen. Whilst congratulating myself for the transition, I realized how naive we were and gullible enough to believe fake information.

At night, we slept on a straw mat on the bare floor. There were no pillows or perhaps we did not need them. We slept in our underwear and covered ourselves with a piece of cloth.

The heat and the lurking mosquitoes were a bad, unforgettably uncomfortable combination. My mother's room was always congested with crying youngsters.

My grandmother offered me a respite to share a room with the big boys. These were her workers who had no home to sleep. One of the storerooms was an improvised bedroom for the night to contain ten or more boys. The odor emanating from ten male night companions, whose preference was to shower only in the morning in order to feel fresh during the day, was an endurance added to the mosquitoes and the heat.

I was aware of the pecuniary difficulties of my mother. It was evident that we did not have enough to eat. Mealtimes were always a race of who could eat faster. Many of us looked skinnier, and the prominence of our collarbones was the telltale sign of undernourishment.

I was conscientious of the predicament. I was willing to do anything to help my mother. I did not refuse when Mom asked me to help in the door-to-door retail of the plantain, as it earned her additional income for our upkeep.

To look decent, my mother covered my tattered shirt and shorts with a piece of clean cloth wrap. This was wrapped around my whole body up to the neck, where it was secured by tying it behind my neck.

With pieces of plantain on a tray, I carried this on my head, moving from door to door with shouts of *the plantain seller is here* in our local dialects to alert prospective customers.

Sales were minuscule, but in the face of looming inadequacy, any drop of a coin produced extensive ripples.

Among many of the errands I ran to help my mother, the most poignant ones were the three-mile treks I used to make to feed my father in Akwasiase. My mother, in an inconvenient distant marriage, took turns cooking for my father.

When it was her turn to service him, she would prepare the food, securely pack it in a plastic basket, and add cutlery and serving plates. An expensive-looking lacy material covering the package gave it a glamour so desired by a dominating husband.

I would carry this trophy on my head, conscientious of the fact that anything going wrong with the package—by spillage or fall—would land me in serious trouble from both sides.

I would arrive at Dad's house after about two hours and lay the table as trained and per protocol. I would place the lukewarm soup or stew and the carbohydrate in the right orientation and wait patiently for Dad to finish his feast.

Dad was always served the best part of the family meal. He had a greater part of the protein, the meat and the fish. I was hoping for a silver lining on my four-hour service trip to serve Dad. This would have been a leftover of a generous portion of the meat and fish. This, for me, would have served as a significant appreciation of the toil of an obedient son, wholeheartedly serving an undeserving father.

I would clear the table after his meals. Except for remnants of partially chewed bones, the bowls would be completely empty.

Each time I walked back to Mabang with great disappointment and vowed never to make the journey again. But it always ended up as a wish under the autocracy of Mom.

This experience greatly soured my sentiments toward my dad. Indeed it was the beginning of the decline of a father-and-son relationship.

In the midst of despair, hope is a virtue that could lighten your spirit and even put smiles on your face. Many Christian religions are adept in making this happen. The Presbyterian church in Mabang was the only Christian faith at the time. It gave hope to many souls.

Many parents gave the children no choice of their religious faith. It was imposed on them. Many of us were automatically baptized as Presbyterian.

I was baptized early as a child. Every child baptized must be assigned a Christian name. This was usually provided by the baptizing priest, who randomly chose a name from the Bible. Sometimes the name would be pre-chosen by the parent.

But this was, usually, not as authentic as when chosen by the priest.

When it was my turn to be baptized, the priest may have run out of ideas from the name pool. But my mother was expecting an authentic name. So she did not prepare.

As the holy water ran down my forehead during the solemn ceremony, the priest, asking for assistance for a Christian name, shouted to the spectators what name should be given to me.

There was a complete momentary silence. Obviously my mother was caught off guard. In order to save the situation, a faithful onlooking congregant randomly shouted to the priest, *Thomas*. The priest continued the ceremony, adopting the suggested name as my official Christian name.

And so I became known as Thomas—a Christian name added to Akwesi, my birth name. But in the village, most still called me by my family name, Baafi. This was probably, by the village standards of appellation, more authentic than any name I would ever acquire in life.

As I grew up and at each stage of my life, the three names have been used in various combinations depending on the norms of each society I had been with.

In my adult life, I am able to decipher, by the appellation of the multiple permutations of my names, which stage of my life the interlocutor knew me. A person calling me Baafi is a contemporary from the village. Thomas Baafi is a contemporary from secondary school. TA is a contemporary of my life in the United States. Mr. Baafi is a business associate, and Mr. B is my current life in Ghana.

When I reached school-going age, I had the instinct that I was ready. My mother also agreed with my instinct. But my entry into the school system—class 1—was not without drama. It was a complication that never should have happened. I had to prove something so simple, yet inaccessible.

Even though I was delivered in the locally prestigious village health post in Akwasiase, they issued no birth certificate to prove my birth. I was not the odd one out. It was a common practice.

Baptismal certificates occasionally appeared to be surrogates for birth certificates. These solemn initiations sometimes happened in early childhood. The certificates issued had a section for birthdates. These dates were completed using memory recall. Therefore, the earlier you were baptized, the more accurate the birth date was.

In my case, the baptismal certificate could not be relied upon. The ceremony was performed in the latter part of my childhood.

My physical structure at the time did not help either. The prolonged struggle for my mom to provide adequate nutrition for her fast-growing boys severely affected our development. I was undernourished. My growth was stunted. I was small for my age. Optically, I could not prove to anyone I was mature enough to start school.

My mother wanted me to start school, and I felt I was ready too. But there was no way I could prove otherwise. As a woman, she stood no chance of convincing the chauvinistic heads of the school that I was of age.

My mother was faced with a conundrum that needed immediate attention. Probably the muscle of a man was needed. A visiting uncle chanced upon the conundrum and offered to help.

I went to the school with him. My uncle and the headmaster appeared to have met before. There was a clear indication that the headmaster optically found me too young to start school. He wanted to prove the point to my uncle. He put out the litmus test. To his satisfaction, I was unable to touch my other ear with my hand.

My heart was literally in my mouth at this point, uncertain whether I could be allowed to start school. A private talk ensued behind the scenes between my uncle and the head of the school.

After a moment, the headmaster came and shook my hand. He said he would give me the chance to compete in class 1. And that was the beginning of my formal education. I may have been six years of age. I was mature in my brain, and even though my physical structure lagged, I did not disappoint my uncle, and the headmaster's consideration was satisfied by my opulent capability in class.

My father's visit to my mother's home in Mabang was scant, if he ever did. I could not recall. But I recalled the visits to the cocoa farm in Gambia number 2 during our school holidays. They were the moments that I would have wished for a small and unique family—us and Dad and no one else forever. But I was in a dreamland. The experience was short-lived, and it passed as quickly as it had started.

My mother was cheered on by the frequent visits of her brothers and sisters. There were quite a number of them. They certainly recog-

nized the predicament of my mother and supported in any way they could. They brought us bread when visiting. They provided financial aid to Mum, which was evidenced by the improvement in the quality and quantity of our food during their visit and shortly after they left.

The visits of my uncles and aunties were brief, but their good deeds to us left lasting memories.

When I was six years old, I had a belief that I was Mom's favorite. I earned it by my selfless diligence at home. I was readily available and willing to help at all times. I was mostly the one she would send to the farm, alone, to fetch *kantomire*, inspect the maturity of the plantains, and harvest cocoyam.

Indeed I did not disappoint Mom. I reciprocated her love until her final day on earth.

PRIMARY EDUCATION

There was no avenue for early childhood education in Mabang. Preschool education was certainly not an opportunity any parent would have dreamed of. Child labor was in full force in the form of additional hands to complete household chores and farming. Any mechanism to make the children attend school too soon would have been an unwelcome distraction by many parents.

Therefore, primary class 1 was the start of formal education in my village. I had the edge to start school early. It was a feeling that I could not resist. I did not know whether I had reached the school-going age, but it did not matter. The feeling of not waiting any longer was much stronger.

My mother, contrary to the norms of the village practice of retarding early education to take advantage of the extra hands at home, did not hesitate to agree with my intuition. But the circumstances that led to the commencement of my early education were shrouded in a bag of confusion. This conundrum needed to be ironed out before I started school.

I could not prove my age, neither did I know I was of school-going age. My mother's proof of my age was gut feeling rather than factual. She did not have the record to back her intuition.

Moreover I was disadvantaged by my unusually small physique, a product of early childhood nutritional imbalance. And I failed the litmus test as I could not touch my other ear with my hand over my head.

But the breakthrough that solved the conundrum was diplomacy by my uncle. Whatever backdoor deal he had with the headteacher, I did not know, but it opened the way for me to start school, which I was ready for mentally but not sure chronologically.

Now that I was accepted to start a formal education, I had no excuses whether I was of a ripe age or not. There were only two people who were in my way of progress: myself as the go-getter and my class 1 teacher as the judge.

I needed to prove to everyone, including my uncle who stuck his neck out, and satisfied my mother's gut feeling, that I had the ability and capability to compete with the big boys in class 1.

My class 1 female teacher was the stopcock that could either retard my progress and make me repeat the class should I not meet the expectations or open up access to my academic pathway.

When I finally got assimilated into the class, it was all smiles every day I walked to school. I could not wait to go to class. I was the envy of many children whose parents did not allow them to commence school early. They were waiting to satisfy all the conditions before making the attempt to start.

The typical routine for every school-going child was regimental, a structure that put an order in my life even as an adult.

On the school days we would wake up at the first light of the day. The sound of the rampant cockcrow would remind us that the day was still young. The air would be fresh and *brisky*, and the dew settling on the leaves provided the added freshness to the tropical morning.

We wrapped our little bodies with a piece of cloth secured at the back of our neck with a knot. This provided a bit of insulation from the chill of the fresh morning.

With an empty bucket in our hands, we would head to the river. Each of us would fetch a bucket full of water, balance it on our head to fill the empty pots and vessels for the household. This would be the day's ration of drinking water and for washing clothes and dishes.

Others, especially the girls, would be tasked to sweep the compound.

On completion of the essential household task, we would make a quick dash to the farm either to weed around the crops, get firewood for cooking, or harvest some farm produce.

These chores needed to be completed before school started at 8:00 a.m. It was like a military camp. But it was a normal activity for everyone, and we did not feel there was anything wrong with it. No child in Mabang could escape the drill.

But in hindsight, it was an unnecessary burden on a child's formative years.

To be ready for school, we would wash our little bodies with some of the water we fetched from the river. The school uniform played a major psychological role in my early years in class. We all walked barefoot and wore the same uniform. Even though I only had one set of uniform at a time, this leveled the playing field by providing a uniformity in our dressing and concealed any hardship that our parents might be facing at home.

Then at the sound of a bell, we all assembled in the park in front of the classrooms. We formed a line, class by class, and stood one after the other in no particular order. There was a line for girls and another one for boys.

A roll call would be conducted to determine who was present. Absenteeism must be accompanied with a good reason, and latecomers received corporal punishment with the cane.

After a short prayer, we would be ordered to sing the national anthem. With my right hand on my upper left chest, I gracefully sang the English patriotic song with no understanding of the lyrics.

We would then be drilled like little soldiers by the headteacher, stomping our little bare feet at the command of attention, and obey the command of left turn, right turn, and froze with the command of stand at ease.

Then as the marching drums commenced, we would be given our marching orders. Line by line and class by class, we would march into our respective classrooms.

The content of the school lessons felt like play to me. We were tasked to memorize the letters of the alphabet and the numbers one

to ten. We colored images with crayon and traced the letters and numbers with chalk on the little chalkboards provided by the school.

The English language was impressed upon us early in childhood education as the only means of communication in class. Any other language spoken in the school was frowned upon. Therefore we were forced to memorize the names of every object around us in English.

For a child who knew his way around the forest and could go to the farm all by himself—and did so even before I attained the school age—these fine intellectual school tasks were performed with my gut, an automatic alacrity that never tasked my brain. I was, surprisingly, not at all challenged by the classwork.

I remember my teacher, the rate-determining step of my progress, began to pay more attention to me. She tasked me more than my peers. She biasedly piled the pressure on me and intensified the school tasks. Each time, my guts spared my brain for the solutions to the problems. I misconstrued the teacher's extra attention as a way to tell me that I was good for nothing.

The typical school day would end at 3:00 p.m. We would rush home and undress into our tattered house clothes. Then we would head to the farm to continue our horticultural duties that yielded tangible benefits, providing food in the pots and money in the safe of my mother.

The school year of primary class 1 ended, and I thought I did well. I did not have any difficulties with the class performance. But this was for the teacher to give her final verdict. She had to report to the head teacher who was cajoled by my uncle to accept me, then a report to my uncle who stuck his neck out for me and was curious to know how I performed. I was also keen not to disappoint my mother who singled me out as her favorite child.

The final school report was presented to my family in a way that I would never have imagined. The school requested a meeting with my family, of which my mother and my uncle were in attendance. We met with the class teacher and the head teacher. At this time, my heart was thumping, and my head appeared completely filled with blood.

It was a brief meeting on my performance. My class 1 teacher spoke first and commented on my exceptional class performance.

The headteacher continued and appeared to be content with his decision to take me into class 1. He commented on my exceptional diligence in class and implored my family present that I should be given the opportunity to study harder. He concluded the meeting with a recommendation that I be promoted.

In the midst of a big relief for my parents assembled, and just as my head was deflating, he continued that I jumped the next class and was promoted to class 3.

This was the moment of another epiphany. My small physique did not matter any longer. But my ability, zeal, and willpower—the essential elements I used in class 1—would be the same ingredients I would need in order to ride the waves of uncertainty that would come my way in the future.

I moved from class 1 to class 3 with pride. I was ahead of my class 1 mates. I no longer had to prove my ability. Class performance was second nature to me. I was capable of competing with anyone.

One thing struck me in my new class. Whatever age I was at the time, I was among the youngest in the class. But this did not matter. My brains always saved the day, and I continued to impress my teachers.

Even though I was performing well in school, poverty still loomed at home. The strain on my mother always abrogated the glow of my academic exuberance. The frequent visits of uncles and aunts helped. And anytime they visited, we welcomed them with our infantile sincerity. We appreciated these visits because they provided tangible reprieve on Mom's stress and improved our diet, albeit short-lived.

During one of these visits by one of my uncles, there was a particular reference to my exceptional academic performance. It unnerved me in the presence of my siblings as my uncle showered me with deserving praises.

Following this, he held an indecipherable discussion in the kitchen with Mom. I guessed I was the main subject. After this, like the usual times, he was gone.

He returned a few weeks later. At the glimpse of him arriving, I ran to him before any of my siblings could. He lifted me in the air and swirled me around like a trophy. My siblings, enviously, looked on. Then he immediately broke the news to me in the presence of everyone that he was going to take me to live with him in Kumasi. This was Uncle Osei Kofi, popularly known as *Gyman*.

A seismic-like wave of shock and confusion, emanating from me, rumbled through my household with mixed feelings of joy and anguish. The decision appeared to be like a two-edged sword. Whilst peeling me off from my family unit like an onion ring, it would also provide some financial relief for my mother. It was the beginning of the split of my family, and my mother felt it was the best decision for us all.

I began to think about the nostalgia of moving away from my village, Mabang. I might not come back in a very long time. I would not see my siblings again for a very long time. The arduous work on the farm before school would now be a story to tell.

I did not have much to pack. After all, my simple life in Mabang, a village child-farmer, was without bells and whistles. Soon I was ready to accompany my uncle—a journey to modernity and to a city many times bigger than my village. A place where living would be luxurious compared to village life.

I was apprehensive about competing with the children in the city school. But I had surprised many doubting Thomases before with my primary class 1 performance. And I believed my willpower and zeal would carry the day again.

Soon after arriving in Kumasi, an unexpected bag of problems unearthed. I was nine years old at the time. I was a direct nephew of my uncle. My uncle at the time had a stable family, a wife, and three girls.

However, per the unchallenged custom of the Ashante tribe, I was the direct next of kin of my uncle, and should he pass, I would be the direct custodian of all his property.

Indeed that was not the thought-through intention of my well-meaning uncle whose primary aim was to give a young loving sister a financial break.

And so this was the underpinning in my new home that fed the friction between myself and my uncle's family. And the friction manifested no sooner than I had arrived.

Firstly my uncle's wife detested that I attended the same privileged private school as her children. Her option was for me to continue my education in the low-end local authority public school. These types of schools were nicknamed *Cyto* and had a reputation of graduating pupils who could not move on to a higher level of education.

But my uncle's wife insisted that it was easier for me to attend the prestigious international school with her three daughters. After all, this was not going to add any more work on transportation if we all attended the same school.

Secondly, just as I knew my childhood labor was over by my relocation, a new one was imposed on me by my uncle's wife. She immediately enrolled me in the household workforce. I helped the maidservants in their household duties. This included cleaning the house, cooking, and serving the food.

My uncle did not have any objection, as if to say that it was, after all, not different from my chores in the village. The household chores were probably an upgrade from the farmwork.

Lastly but not the least, the final task imposed on me defined a path that initiated a business career. Unknowingly, the fallout of what appeared to add a hardship for me, rather prepared me for business.

My uncle's wife enrolled me to join her mainly-women market workforce. She specialized in women's undies. During my spare time, when there were no further chores to perform in the house, she ordered me to be in the market to help. I would carry the merchandise on my head, just as I did with the plantains in Mabang, and roam the market, convincing clients to purchase from me. I attracted the admiration of many women who found it out of place for a boy to be selling women's underwear.

I soon became an expert in sizing women's brassieres. I could tell from a distance the cup size of any woman I met on the streets. A kind of preoccupation with pleasant sentiments but an occupation

that nasty boys in school teased me with during all my schooling in Kumasi.

And so my school life in Kumasi was structured. It paralleled my child labor camp in my village Mabang.

In the morning, unlike my three host cousins, the daughters of my uncle, I would wake up early with the maids, clean the house, and prepare the household breakfast. Then I would get ready to join my cousins to be transported to school.

After school, I would be in the market to sell till it was dusk. My school homework was not a priority to my dominant female boss and was done whenever I could get time within my multiple domestic duties.

And so I was a villager transplanted from Mabang to Kumasi city. The child labor camps, for me, were not dissimilar, but it was, comparatively, luxurious to live in the city.

Even with all the hardships I was enduring in Kumasi, my relocation was an upscale of my life in the village and an eye-opener for me.

For the first time in my life, I did not have to go to the river to fetch water. Water was readily available in the house when we turned on the tap. We called it pipe water. This blew my mind at the time, and the experience could never have been dreamed of for a village boy in Mabang.

In addition, the bright candescent lights I became accustomed to when I flip an electrical switch cannot be compared to the kerosene lamps I depended upon in the village. Indeed studying at night in Kumasi was much easier than using a smoky kerosene lamp.

In addition to the strict regimental domestic structure of my life that my uncle's wife put in place, there were also additional boundaries from my uncle. I called these the three commandments. Disobeying any of these commandments would see my forced repatriation to Mabang.

These rules and boundaries aided me as I made my life's journey from the doldrums of the village life in Mabang to the pinnacle of my adult career. They were the rules that a concerned dad, had I been privileged, would have given to a son in order not to go astray.

I needed guidance and followed the three commandments to the latter.

The first commandment was an order to be among the top 5 percent of the class.

The second commandment was an order not to stay outside the house past 8:00 p.m.

The third commandment was an analogy. I was to take life as walking on the tall wall around a house. Either side of the wall were dangers that would devour me. To keep a good balance on the wall, I needed to look straight. If I failed to look straight, I would lose my balance and fall into the awaiting catastrophe.

The village boy, as the three cousins sarcastically used to call me, became a pupil in Kumasi, at no other place than the prestigious Royal International School. It was a luxury to ride in a car to go to school. In Mabang, I would walk to school.

It was also a luxury to go to school in a decent uniform and a pair of shoes. In Mabang, I wore shoes only on Sundays and only for a few hours to impress in church.

These were my realities for a village boy, estimated to be nine years, who had been given the rare opportunity by a loving uncle to be transplanted from a village school to primary class 4 in a private school in the city.

I was not prepared to retrogress; "ever forward" was my unsounded motto.

In my new class, it appeared I was still younger than my peers but confident. The confidence I had gained from my class leapfrog in Mabang, fueled by the three commandments, were my driving forces that defied any doubt of age and excuses.

Indeed my tenacity to be the best in my new school made me my teacher's favorite. My academic performance was noticeable among my peers. I would be the first to raise my hand in class when the teacher asked questions.

At the end of the first year in my new school, my uncle received my school report. It was a testing moment. But I knew I had no challenges. When my uncle called me to congratulate me, I knew I had met his expectations.

From then on, I developed a spring in my step when I walked within the four corners of the school and wished myself the luck of the unchallenged new kid on the block. I knew at this point, with a bit of a chip on my shoulder, that despite my background, I had the ability to face any challenges that would come my way. Where I came from really did not matter any longer, and I would rather spend my energy on where I was going.

After four years in the Royal International school, I took the common entrance examination. It was the examination that would determine whether to continue my education at a higher level in secondary school or relegate myself to the market to trade in women's undergarments. The latter would have been a failure and I would have let my mother down.

I passed the examination with flying colors at the first attempt. This moment in my life became a stepping stone and a doorway to the open world of opportunities.

SECONDARY EDUCATION

I passed the common entrance examination with flying colors. This was after four years of city life in Kumasi, and four years of education in a prestigious private school.

The village boy had finally arrived and had metamorphosed into a city boy.

This time I no longer had an inferiority complex. Life in the village was becoming a distant memory. I would enter a new school on a level playing field with my peers. I was riding on the confidence of past glory and emboldened by my past records in primary school. And I had the zeal that I could compete with any student and in any school. I was a go-getter who always saw the cup half full rather than half empty.

Opoku Ware Secondary was my first choice of secondary school education. They accepted my application on merit without hesitation. Obviously, my performance measured up to their requirement. And reminiscent of the conundrum surrounding my entry into primary class 1, there was no external influence by any family member.

My uncle accompanied me to the school to register my acceptance and for the prospectus. I was overwhelmed with joy and felt the goose pimples as the hair on my skin stood on end at the glimpse of the ambience of the school campus.

For the first time, I savored my potential severance from the burden of my house chores when I finally became a boarding student in this prestigious institution. This would be a great relief, when I was let off the leash, to enable me to give my all to education.

Furthermore, I needed a life away from the three girls, my cousins, to be among all boys with the hope that it would toughen me up into a hardcore material.

And so, based upon these *premises*, the twelve-year-old city boy, who originally hailed from the village of Mabang, made the transition into a boarding student in the popular Opoku Ware Secondary School, otherwise known as *Owass*.

The transition date of September 1973 was a significant watershed moment in my life, as it marked the beginning of my independence.

The transition was in style and presented in a semblance of a rudimentary independence. My uncle bought me my own trunk. This was a locally manufactured metal box painted black with scattered design of cowries or Ghana flag in yellow to give it an appeal. In the trunk, I packed all the belongings I ever owned—my clothes and school uniform. I did not have any bells and whistles. It was all I had in one piece and in one place that fit into a small box.

Then I had my own chop box. This was a padlocked wooden box. In this I packed the boarding house essentials: Gari, fried pepper sauce called *shitor*, sugar, a footlong bar of soap, the so-called key soap, and Pepsodent-branded toothpaste—the only brand in Ghana at the time.

With the trunk and chop box fully packed, my uncle, pleased and happy for me, literally drove me into my independence, *Owass*.

Before parting, and with tears in his eyes, he shook my hands and hugged me, then whispered in my ears, clearly and unambiguously: Remember the three commandments.

And so I was freed from the shackles of domestic labor. I was on my own in the boarding school—a mini-dreamland that would lay the foundations of my future career and a singular opportunity that would help me to break the glass ceilings. The only person in my way of success was myself.

I was assigned to a dormitory. The house was Saint Mark. My identification number: X43. My class: 1C. It felt like I was conscripted into military service. And it quickly became so when the bullying started.

Bullying in secondary schools was very common. It was perpetuated by the senior students. It was supposed to toughen you up. It was a cruel initiation process that all new students went through. It took many forms and was carried out at the blind side of the school authorities. Many students could not report it for fear of repercussions and being labeled as feeble.

My initial excitement of being on my own in a boarding school was cut short no sooner than I arrived. My small physique made me an easy target. I was subjected to several episodes of bullying, but the most poignant are the following:

The toothbrush bully: A senior student asked me to use my only toothbrush to clean the toilet. If I disobeyed, I would be subjected to a beating. I had no choice but to comply. After finishing the cleaning exercise, I dumped it. I resorted to using the chewing stick to clean my teeth. Four weeks later, I was granted an official permit called *exeat*. This enabled me to leave campus to buy a replacement.

The dining hall bully: Normally at the assigned table of about ten students, the most junior student would serve the food. Seniors were served first. The last to be served was the server.

On several occasions, when it was my turn to serve, the seniors would ask for more and more food. The only option was to comply; otherwise, beating would be a consequence. On many of these occasions, I would serve all the food to them and have nothing left for myself. My savior would be my chop box gari and sugar, the so-called *soaking*.

Opoku Ware Secondary School was renowned for athleticism. It was a local giant in sports and won many sporting laurels. The school maintained this reputation by identifying talents in new recruits and training them to the highest level of their ability. Therefore the school did not miss any opportunity to scan the ability of newcomers.

Many students entering the secondary school system were oblivious to their respective talent and ability until tested. *Owass* had a crude way of screening new recruits. It was very simple.

The sports master, testing for endurance and speed, would simply ask the class to run around the football field several times. At the end of several tries, he would pick up athletes for various events.

I remember going through this process. I gave it my all, not knowing what the sports master was looking for. I had the conviction that the village in me and early childhood farming activity would shine through and raise eyebrows.

But as hard as I tried, the village boy's endurance, despite the childhood labor in the farms in Mabang, could not transform him into a competitive athlete.

Unlike my tenacity with academic work, my sports master considered me a liability in all sporting disciplines. I was not proud of his evaluation report. Neither was I upset. But one thing was very clear: I was relieved of the time and stress to train as a competitive athlete.

My purpose of coming to *Owass* was to fulfill all the three commandments of my uncle. The first commandment was to be among the top 5 percent at all times. I could now do so without distraction.

My academic achievements were noticeable both on campus and at home. I was exemplary and caused no troubles. Year after year, I kept my uncle's promises. I was the apple of his eye and a pride that he would always bring up in conversation with his friends. He took the village out of me and put me on an even keel.

Indeed I was a grateful beneficiary of my uncle's three commandments that shaped me and modeled me into a competitive world that rewarded hard work and education.

My dream career while I was in secondary school education was to become a doctor or a pharmacist. This influenced my subject choice, which skewed toward science. These careers appeared to be in tandem with my academic ability.

The final ordinary level examination summed up the effort I had put in during the initial five years of my secondary education. It was in the year 1978 when I moved up one notch toward my dream career with a high degree of success in the examination in a category of grade 1 with distinction.

My performance in the O-level examination immediately earned me admission in the same school to pursue the sixth form education in science. Science became my passion and my preoccupation. I was ready to explore the depths of biology, physics, and chemistry.

However, for reasons unknown to us, there was a deficit of experienced teachers to take us through the syllabus. As the months of the two years raced toward the advanced level examination, it became evident the paucity of knowledge acquired would show through in the outcome of the examination.

Efforts made by the school authorities to rectify the situation came in too little too late. The results of the examination bore witness when, in 1980, I failed to meet the grades that would have qualified me for any of my preconceived dream careers.

And so my education came to a screeching halt, not only because I could not make the grades but also due to the unfortunate events that ensued in the life of my uncle.

My uncle was a successful spare parts dealer. He was well-known by the major insurance companies in Kumasi. He was the man to call when these companies wanted to write off cars involved in accidents. He would buy, salvage, and resell the vehicles in parts.

But somehow, while conducting this high-income-earning business, he appeared to have shortchanged his creditors. He accumulated a lot of debt in the process. When the chickens eventually came to roost, his entire lucrative business suffered a huge setback.

This had a knock-on effect on the whole family as money became scarcely available. The funding of any educational ambition for me and all of his children was rolled off its track.

To sour an already worse financial situation, my uncle was involved with other women. This was probably a common practice at the time. *Polygamy* was not frowned upon. It was not uncommon for men to officially have multiple wives. But his wife could not stand my uncle's indulgence in *polygamy*. And getting the wind that he had a child out of wedlock infuriated her even more. She initiated a divorce, and the marriage broke down.

These events that plagued my uncle's life became a teaching moment for me. This would become my fourth commandment. A commandment that also obeys Newton's first law of motion: Action and reaction are equal and opposite. You reap what you sow.

The commandment instructed me to be honest in life and be trustworthy at all times.

When the chickens come to roost, any malicious actions you engage in would not only come back to haunt you, but its snowball effect can disrupt the lives of many people downstream.

Indeed, my uncle's predicament severely affected my personal life, my future.

I completed my secondary education with four life-changing commandments from my uncle and a collapse of his business empire. He had been instrumental in my life as he lifted me from a village life into a young city man, nineteen years of age, and armed me with education which enabled me to continue my life's journey.

Indeed, my uncle, who also goes by the name *Gyman* due to his rough edges, imparted in me humility, grace, and made me recognize and appreciate when my bread is buttered.

MY FIRST LOVE

When I met Dorcas Antwi, she was seventeen years old. The unforgettable location for our first encounter was in the home of Uncle Gyman's second wife. The two, Dorcas and the second wife, may have been blood-related. But it did not matter. I did not want to know any details. The attraction was irresistible, and it was a matter of the heart for the nineteen-year-old boy.

She was slim built, like my size in physique. She had cute early generating protuberances on her backside, as was her bosom, which was defined by their small pear-shape appearance and were easily noticeable through her soft white cotton T-shirt. These protuberances were perfectly measured and appeared to be proportional to her physique.

She had big brown eyes, perfectly aligned, surrounded by youthful gyrating eyelashes. Her prominent African lips revealed an almost perfect arrangement of white teeth that glittered anytime she smiled.

The innocent gaze from her perfect face produced a sparkle that froze me in my tracks. I could not resist looking at her one more time. And when she smiled, it was infectious.

She had a light complexion, and the skin on her arms and legs was dusted with silky black hair.

Her whole package, and her gifted majestic chameleon-like walk, produced extreme optical pleasures that generated head turning anytime she passed by.

The confidence of the now-city boy was at its highest. I was a sixth form student. She was a student in Agogo Teachers Training

College. We were both ambitious, and at such an early age, we already had plans for a chosen career. She would be a teacher, and I would be a doctor or a pharmacist. *A perfect match for me*, I thought. It was love at first sight.

There was no room for hesitation at this opportunity. We started talking, and a relationship naturally ensued. She was my first love, and I was hers.

It soon became obvious that we were products of the typical Ghanaian family who received no prior sex education. We were both naive, and every encounter appeared as an experiment. We both contributed to the relationship what we thought was the right way to romance. But the passage of time and multiple practices bonded us even more. Soon we were inseparable and deeply in love. She was all mine, and I was all hers.

The novelty of a new first love sent my head into the clouds. I was riding in the stratosphere, full of pride that I won the soul of the dream girl on the block. I was the talk of the town—the OWASS sixth-form student with the most beautiful girl in town. Many times, I would subconsciously acknowledge it. Then I would stop in my stride and pat myself on the back.

And that was my first love. No one else mattered.

I would travel the two-hour journey from Kumasi to Agogo just to visit her in school. Whilst proudly introducing me to her school-mates, she would judiciously underscore the fact I was no ordinary boy. The mention of my academic level and my institution usually confirmed her analogy.

I made her day when I would part and leave her with chocolates. I purchased these with hard currency from my uncle's magnanimity. But all that mattered to me was it sealed her analogy that I was no ordinary boyfriend.

The inseparable lovebirds started planning their lives way into the future. I dreamt of a life in the United States, which she totally supported. I would be the first to go, and when settled, I would come back for her and we would be together forever. Surely these were dreams but a blueprint that underscored the commitment we had for one another.

After her training, she was posted to Kenyasi Local Authority Primary School to teach. Soon after, I also completed the sixth-form education, but I was jobless.

She became the breadwinner for our novel union. Her starting salary was meager, but her determination to invest in a future life with me was overpowering.

When the results of our advanced level of education were released, my grades fell shy of the cutoff point I needed for both careers—medicine and pharmacy.

For the first time in my life, I felt I had failed myself. But in reality, the paucity of our sixth-form education was mostly to blame. Regardless, I was sad, and my career path was now becoming like a mirage.

When I was in grief for not being able to advance to my next milestone, Dorcas was there for me. My future was bouncing off a hard rock. I was in a limbo. She struggled to keep us afloat with her income.

I felt powerless and caught in a position with no elbow room. I decided to take the bull by the horn and try for the American visa in Accra. All expenses needed to complete this process fell on Dorcas's paycheck. I was denied the visa.

I had the wind that it was easier to obtain an American visa in Liberia. I made the daring trip to the capital, Monrovia, to apply for the visa. This was still at Dorcas's expense. I still did not succeed.

I wanted to be the man that Dorcas dreamt of and start making some money. Ghana was in deep economic crisis at the time, but Nigeria, on the contrary, had a burst of rapid growth that called for migrant workers.

One of my brothers was already established in Nigeria, taking advantage of their economic boom. He lived in Offa, a town in the Kwara State, and worked in a brewery. He had a stable job and a family. When I contacted him to help, he was ready and willing.

Dorcas was in agreement with me going to Nigeria to earn some money whilst hatching the next plan to the United States.

She paid for my transport and gave me some money for the journey. At the lorry station, we hugged and kissed goodbye.

I began my journey to Nigeria in a Peugeot car. This vehicle would take us through the Republic of Togo, Republic of Benin, and arrive in Lagos, the capital city of Nigeria. This would take two days and endure three border crossings.

We were eight passengers crammed together. The discomfort of the vehicle did not bother me. I was mainly preoccupied with the uncertainty of my immediate future and leaving behind my treasured beautiful Dorcas.

The first visit to a foreign land was, somehow, a thrill that urged me on. And the silver lining that awaited me was being able to have my own money even if all my long-term plans failed. At least I would be a man to look after Dorcas.

The first part of the journey from Kumasi to the Ghana–Togo border came rather quick, as my whole preoccupation was pondering over all the psychological ramifications of the change I was going through.

As we arrived at the border town, Aflao, I met my first obstacle. The borders were closed. A vehicle with only a driver was allowed to cross after a thorough security check by the border soldiers to ensure there were no arms on board.

This was the immediate aftermath of the Rawlings coup d'état in 1981. There was a fear of counterinsurgency from neighboring countries. This warranted an indefinite closure of all the borders of the country.

All the eight passengers would have to find their own means of crossing the border and meet up with the driver on the other side in the Republic of Togo.

There were local guides cashing in on this predicament. They knew the way around the back roads that trekked through the forest on the blind side of the soldiers.

We contracted a guide and paid a good sum of money. He coached us on the simple signs he would use should he sense the presence of soldiers. These were simple instructions: Lie flat, motionless on the ground, tiptoe, and get up and let's go.

The journey on foot started at a significant distance from the official crossing. We grouped on someone's cassava farm. In front of

us, across the border, was a forest that spanned across the two countries. It may have been no-man's-land.

It was deep in the night when the soldiers might be sleeping. It was obvious the guide knew his way around the meandering farming footpaths. He did not need a light. But a torchlight emanating with very weak luminescence was in his possession to use in case of any eventualities.

We followed him like scout boys. My heart was in my mouth. My fear was not of the soldiers, who would probably not shoot at random to kill innocent armless boys trying to get a better life in an alien country.

But the crux of the matter was that the forest was full of poisonous snakes and scorpions. You got bitten by any of these creatures and no one would find you ever again. You would be removed by the scavenging vultures in the forest to keep it clean from smelly carcasses.

One of the passengers had a cold, which became unbearable by the time we got to the border. His coughs were irresistible and a great nuisance to our secret mission. Had they been at earshot of any border guards, we would have been in great trouble.

This whole ordeal took approximately three hours to cross to the other side. And what we did not realize immediately was that after the crossing, we had to walk another ten miles to meet up with our driver. It was 3:00 a.m., and we walked the whole way to catch up with our vehicle.

The obstacles during the journey from Togo through Benin to Nigeria were of a different category. It was a predator-and-prey relationship. The gendarmes were the predators, and we were the prey. The feast was on the little cash we had on us.

The gendarmes could identify an alien vehicle from a distance by their registration numbers. All they needed to do was to sound their whistle. This meant the car had to stop.

Then they would come around and count the number of aliens in the car. A proportionate fee would be charged, and each of us would be required to contribute to pay. The car would not move until this fee was fully settled.

This extortion, a daylight robbery in disguise, occurred on approaching or leaving a border town. I did not expect or factor in any such expense. I could feel the original treasure Dorcas gave me deplete at exponential rate as we traveled through Togo, Benin, and into Nigeria.

On arrival in Lagos, I was almost completely depleted of funds. But that was just the first leg of my journey to my final destination.

Arrival in Lagos was a culture shock. There were just too many human beings per square meter. People everywhere. The mere claustrophobia could choke the unprepared.

I had never seen any such thing in the twenty years of my existence. Not only were there many people, it was also so disorderly. The streets were choked with vehicles that were hardly moving; passengers were just jumping on and off the bus right in the middle of the road; and bus stops, if there were any, were redundant.

Among this chaos, I needed to find my way to a station that would take me on my second leg to Ilorin, the capital city of Kwara State. There were an abundance of people to ask for directions, but they were characteristically impatient to stop and give me the help I needed. This enforced the reality that each one was for himself.

During the long trip to Ilorin, I reflected on my life and my small world. I was jobless. I was in love with the most beautiful girl. Together we had a dream. I would work hard to make some money. I would try again for the American visa. If I succeeded, our lives would change forever.

The daydream in the wonderland took the whole of me and appeared to have shortened the six-hour journey. When I got to Ilorin, I was almost completely out of money. The last leg of the journey would take me straight to my brother's town, Offa. And the money I had would just be enough to pay for the ticket.

The journey from Ilorin to Offa was short. The one-and-a-half-hour duration made it the shortest of the three legs. Yet the accumulated physical fatigue of the two-day trip, the mental weariness, and eagerness to see my brother appeared to have made this leg, the home stretch, a never-ending and the longest.

I eventually arrived in Offa, and my brother was at the station to welcome me. We were separated in childhood for economic reasons and reunited in a foreign land, after many years, for the same reasons. This time, our struggle would be a means to an end. Dorcas and I would soon find our feet in the right place.

My brother's place of abode raised my eyebrows. It was not what I had imagined after he had been in Nigeria and working all these years.

He had a wife and a child. Together they shared a tight living space. It was a studio, but one of its walls was completely taken over by bags of personal belongings, packed one on top of the other, almost up to ceiling level. This reduced even further the available living space.

Air circulation in his crammed dwelling was inadequate, secondary to the haphazard layout of the township where he lived. The residual smell left behind by years of heavy cooking with the rich spices of Nigeria had left an everlasting memory of the characteristic scent of his house.

I slept on the floor. My bed was a straw mat with a coverless pillow. It was not dissimilar from our childhood bed, and I quickly adapted.

The nights were just as busy as the day. When not fighting mosquitoes that were attempting to pierce your exposed skin, we were acoustically trying to shield off the noise of the roaring snore from two other adults. We woke up as tired as we went to bed.

My brother did not waste any time to find me a job. He had prepared the ground for me at his workplace before my arrival. He was a true brother who had my interest at heart. He definitely remembered our childhood struggle in Mabang. We were separated early for financial reasons and lived different lives. And here we were again, fighting for a common cause. A cause that we were painfully but helplessly deprived of as children. A cause that eluded us. A better life.

But whilst waiting for an opening for recruitment of new staff in the brewery, I ventured to the town of Offa to explore any job opportunity there was.

I came across a company looking for masons. I verbally applied for the job as a mason. I had never been to a construction site before, never knew how to mix concrete nor handle a trowel. I was hoping to quickly learn on the job.

In desperation, they hired me as a mason. Within a few hours on the job, they quickly discovered that they had hired a quack mason. I did not know the vocabulary of the trade, neither was I able to lay blocks in a straight line. When the supervisor observed the way I handled the trowel, he quickly terminated my position.

Instead of dismissing me outright, he was kind enough to let me join the laborers to carry sand and blocks to the real masons.

I felt very uncomfortable with this harsh manual labor and was eagerly waiting for the opening at the brewery.

Finally the brewery started recruiting new staff. When I got to my brother's workplace, the interview took the form of an introduction to his boss. Before long, I was being processed to start work immediately. I was taken as a factory hand in the brewery.

My days in my new job gradually rolled into weeks. It was work and sleep. Life's pleasures were imaginary luxuries. But I knew one day Dorcas and I would be the beneficiaries of this foundation and we would have a story to tell to our progenies.

After four months of working in Offa, my pocket felt heavier and I felt I had made a bit of wealth. As my financial situation improved, so did my nostalgia for Dorcas. Eventually I was overwhelmed until I could no longer bear it.

I shocked my brother when I told him I was leaving for Ghana to see Dorcas. I knew we needed money, but I explained to him that life was not all about money. The separation was too long. I thought Dorcas might feel the same.

Now with a bit of money, I felt the tables should turn. I needed to reciprocate the kindness and support Dorcas offered when I was in dire need. I wanted to show the undisputed love I had for her.

I bought her mundane items that were difficult to acquire in Ghana but on the wish list of every household. Among the items were a food processor, record player, and an electric fan.

And so I left Offa with my baggage. A baggage that every young woman would dream of. A baggage that I knew would please Dorcas and even bond us more.

The return journey back to Ghana was smooth and full of excitement. The borders were now open, and there was no need for a detour in the bush. Thoughts of the first reunion with Dorcas after such a long unprecedented break generated goose pimples on my skin.

The borders were still full of the extortionist gendarmes and customs officers whose main purpose of work was to amass wealth by preying on naive border crossers. They collected a lot of money from me for my baggage.

When I finally arrived home in Kumasi, it was dark. I needed to see Dorcas immediately, but I had to wait till daybreak. It felt like a never-ending night, a night spent mostly awake than asleep; but I woke with a smile on my face.

The following morning, I left home as quickly as I could. And I went with the items so precisely chosen. I was in front of Dorcas's doorsteps in a flash, with the best of myself: Sneakers, T-shirt, and neatly ironed jeans. The Nigerian barber put the icing on the cake.

I received a half-hearted welcome from Dorcas. Or probably my extreme joy paled hers. We both hugged, and I could not wait to tell her my story.

Before proceeding with any stories of my adventure and achievements, I proudly presented her with the gifts, which she graciously accepted. She clearly needed the items.

But my enthusiasm was cut short. Her thank-you was a clear indication that our relationship was all over. With the impolite gesticulation of the index finger flashing in my face, she warned me never to cross her path again. She further put pepper in my sore by revealing that she had a new boyfriend.

I felt the rush of blood in my head as my heart beat senselessly fast in a manner that had never happened before.

My joy was abruptly replaced by a grief of irreplaceable loss that was painful and pierced the heart. At the age of twenty, I felt I could never find a woman like this again.

The stun turned into suicidal ideation, an infantile solution to a breakup. For days and weeks, I cried and withdrew into myself. I lost the spring in my step of a returning hustler from rich and vibrant Nigeria.

With the complex of a dejected boyfriend, I went into hiding. I did not want to be called a loser, a harsh appellation that would strike at the core.

On the few occasions that I ventured out, I met James, my classmate's senior brother. He was an accountant and more mature than his age. I decided to pour my heart out to him. He was all ears. I gained confidence in him as he imbibed and analyzed my whole story. He was pragmatic.

He looked squarely in my face as I did to his, and as I watched his lips with obedient sincerity, he clearly articulated the first sentence that completely changed my outlook on life: "I must not kill myself because of a woman."

He went further to say that I should rather better myself and I would be *spoilt for choice*.

This generated my fifth commandment in life: *Do not fight over spilt milk*.

From this time onward, I began to heal as I gathered myself together. Soon James took a lucrative job in Nigeria and emigrated.

James became a confidant and a friend for a very long time in my life.

THE JOURNEY TO THE PROMISED LAND

My promised land was the United States of America. It was a country made up of a melting pot of people of all shades and across the length and breadth of the globe. It was the country much talked about in world affairs and accommodating to immigrants who formed the basis of its existence. It was a country of choice for most youngsters seeking the thrill of adventure and opportunities to explore.

Based on these premises, and before I could even think outside the box, going to America became my automatic preoccupation.

In reality, many people immigrated to the United States for many good reasons. These included education, job opportunities, family reunion, escape from political persecution, asylum seeking, or just because it was America.

But as the dawn broke when I began to analyze myself, I believed, naivety and thrill aside, that I was a good fit for such a liberal country.

From a very young age, I categorized myself as a leader rather than a follower—a gifted pathfinder with the ability to think outside the box. I had a creative personality with an inherent driving force that could make things happen. I never despaired. I took the bumps in the road as a challenge rather than a problem. Any tortoise elbow room would not fit my potential characteristics.

I was of the conviction, when I was having the personal epiphany, that my country, Ghana, as much as I loved it, would not have all

the necessary ingredients to make me what I wanted to be. I needed to explore a country that could promise me my full potential.

My need, and not my want, was my driving force. The very existence of America was in tandem with my characteristics.

It was not difficult to decide that it was the land I knew would help me do the things I wanted to achieve in my life.

But to get to America to pursue my dream was not that simple. After all, I was not unique in thinking that it was a land that would realize my dreams. Many people were of similar opinion, and if wishes were horses, all the beggars would ride.

Unfortunately, America could not take everyone who had a dream. There was a selection criteria for us *dreamers*. Some people, based on their circumstances, were able to meet all the criteria with little or no effort.

But there were many more people in my category who fell far short of the selection criteria. To make it happen so they could get to the dreamland, they had to pull tooth and nail. My two visa refusals to go to America, one in Accra and the other in Monrovia, were just a testimony and a preamble of the difficulties of my journey to the promised land.

Going to America had, therefore, become a tactful process. The process had even become a business opportunity for many entrepreneurs who themselves had never stepped a foot in America. They used decoys like education, tourism, and fake marriages as stepping stones to gain access.

The process of going to America, like no other country, had even generated multiple documentaries and movies. A review of the movie *The Green Card* vividly demonstrated one of the many ways exploited to gain access.

Others, with sheer desperation, would use incredible means to go to America. They would walk miles on end, cross dangerous rivers, encase in cargo boxes, or even stow away as airplane cargo.

The so-called *lucky ones* would arrive on planes, cars, and boats and, after a short encounter with the immigration officer, be given admission into the country.

My personal driving forces to leave for America were my inherent zeal to explore outside the periphery of my comfort zone, but strongly modified by the following factors:

Being ditched by my first love, Dorcas, was a significant life-changing moment in my life. Whilst I was a laughingstock to my peers for losing a pretty girl in Kumasi, I met James, the accountant, who gave me eye-opening advice. He told me to better myself and I would be spoilt for choice.

In addition, my aspiration for my dream career fell on hard rocks. I did not meet the selection criteria. I could not become a doctor and not a pharmacist. I was jobless. I would have no future if I did nothing.

Lastly, the prevailing political turmoil in the country at the time put the educational system in a very precarious position. The then ruling military government closed down all the universities. Student leaders were being pursued for prosecution and were on the run. The future of education was in a limbo.

I had tried and failed on two occasions to obtain the American visa. I could not keep doing the same thing and expect a different result. I needed to use another strategy to get there.

Hypothetically, if I became a refugee in a reputable country, I could be granted asylum and become a citizen of that country.

Alternatively, if I could marry a European, I would be granted spousal citizenship.

Should any of these plans be successful, it would be a sure guarantee that I would be admitted into the United States in style in an airplane.

From my current situation in Ghana, it needed four to five years of planning to meet these objectives.

My research preselected West Germany, whose citizenship gave a guaranteed entry to America. It was a country that, despite the racist tendencies, was relatively easier to get a spouse. It was also a country where seeking political asylum was relatively easier.

Therefore my launchpad to America was West Germany. But there were obvious obstacles to get there.

To obtain their visa was just as hard as the United States. Moreover, I had no political relatives, either directly or indirectly, that I could use as subjects of persecution in the prevailing military turmoil in Ghana that could qualify me as a political refugee.

But being the most malleable country among all the countries I researched, I still needed to go to West Germany and try. The worst that could happen was that I would fail and be deported back to Ghana.

The strategy to get to West Germany would be through the back door, by train, through the adjoining Eastern Bloc countries.

These communist countries were sympathetic to Ghana as a consequence of the first president Dr. Kwame Nkrumah's pro-Communist agenda that was music to their ears. It was therefore easy to obtain a visa to any of these communist countries.

I figured out a budget of \$2,000 would be enough to enable me to reach West Germany. This would take care of airline tickets and the nuances of the cost involved in going through the back door.

To commence all these plans, I needed to find the \$2,000 first. Certainly I could not find a job in Ghana that paid well enough to save this amount. But I could do this in Nigeria, which had a booming economy and whose currency was stronger than the US dollar.

I did not fancy working in the brewery with my brother in Offa, and I did not want to add on to their already cramped living space. I felt a change of job and place in Nigeria would give me the best opportunity.

James immediately came to mind. He had taken a lucrative job in Lagos, Nigeria. When I contacted him to help, he was ever willing.

Therefore my trip to America took me from Ghana, through Agege in Nigeria, then the two Eastern Bloc countries of Bulgaria and East Berlin in East Germany, then to West Berlin in West Germany, and finally the Netherlands.

From the Netherlands, I leapfrogged to the United States of America, my promised land. I did this in grand style, in the arms of my second love and in an airplane.

It was a journey of nerves, adventure, uncertainties, and a fight for survival in order to better myself, as advised by my confidant,

James. I would not wish this trip on anybody. But desperation makes you do the unthinkable.

On reflection of my life today, I still do not believe I took all these desperate measures in order to get to my promised land, America. But the end result was all worth the risk.

LIFE IN THE SLUMS OF AGEGE

I went back to Nigeria for the second time. This time I had a different purpose. I needed to fulfill an agenda. And that was to make wealth. A wealth so small yet vital that would take me off the launchpad.

All I needed was \$2,000. And I needed to make this money in a timely manner. A good Samaritan could have given that to me. But that would have been on a silver platter with no sweat. Indeed the process of achieving an aim must be endured and enjoyed. That is the only way I could cherish the result meaningfully.

And so I packed my bag and was on my way to Nigeria. It was a *déjà vu* experience. The familiarity made the journey easier. The Ghanaian borders were open. And the process was enjoyable, yet I was uncertain what lay ahead of me.

I was going to my friend and confidant, James. He would accommodate me in his abode in Yaba, a suburb of Lagos. He offered to do this with open arms, and he was doing it for karma. All he wanted was the good of me to succeed and flourish. He was a true human being with no hidden agenda.

And so with the cumulative effect of all the nuances in my life at the time, the stars were all lined up to embark on my trip. The final destination was my promised land, the United States of America. The stopover was Nigeria. There I would find the money for my second-leg trip to Bulgaria.

Soon, in less than two days, I was in James's town, Yaba. With a little help of direction, I arrived at his house. I suddenly had a culture

shock as soon as I arrived. It was all written on my face. But he may have misconstrued it as a mixed feeling of the uncertainties in my personal life.

I had imagined an accountant of his repute, recruited from Ghana by a reputable company in Nigeria, to be given a decent accommodation as an inducement to relocate. This would not have been out of place, given the fact that the company that recruited him was of Asian origin, who knew the value of employees.

But the summed-up description of his residence was a chicken coop. James's home was like a tiny cubicle almost in the shape of a perfect square. His six-foot-long bed barely made the length of one wall. It was so small that there was no extra floor space for a sleeping mat for me.

He had a makeshift kitchen right beside his bed. And the tiny disproportionate window that faced the kitchen allowed the steam and aroma of his cooking to carry over to the next day. The shower and the toilet were recessed in one wall, and a curtain provided the needed privacy.

Here I was, a beggar with no choice. I had to accept whatever was available with humility and gratitude. My host had good intentions. He just did not have the means. He gave his all to me, a hospitality that no one else could at the time.

And so, in the night, I would put my mat in the common corridor in front of his doorstep. I was a nuisance to his neighbors who had to tiptoe around me to access their rooms.

And I was also momentarily tolerated by his landlord who, putting my sleeping arrangement in his blind spot, empathized with James for his magnanimity.

Each night, I would face a battle. It was a battle to have a good night's sleep—a battle to tackle the multiple predicaments that were against a peaceful sleep. Each of them was unsolvable. The solution was to toughen up and endure them. After all, they were all the frills of the journey to the dreamland.

Firstly, the ambient temperature of a poorly ventilated corridor required the exposure of a large body surface to allow cooling of the core temperature.

But in the morning, my exposed body surfaces and my nostrils would be coated with a good layer of dust generated by the movement of vehicles on the adjacent dusty road.

Furthermore, the daring mosquitoes, armed with their long proboscis that could penetrate any exposed flesh up to the bone, not only bit me but beat out of me the needed sleep that would refresh me for the full day ahead.

All I needed to do was to adapt to the treacherous sleeping arrangement and look forward.

Despite the poor living conditions of James, he had a reputable job. He worked as an accountant for a foreign company called Swenig Furniture Company. They specialized in the manufacture of furniture. It was owned by Asians.

Their work ethics included making humans work nonstop like robots. When you were not working, you were on break.

This was where James graciously put in a word with his superiors for me to be employed. They employed me without any hesitation by rubbing off the reputation of hardworking James as a reference.

I was a factory hand. The shift was and felt like twelve hours. I worked all week, except Sundays. The job was very physical. A labor camp would not have been an excessive hyperbole. On the factory floor, we fed the sawmills with heavy sheets of plywood. My small physique was a disadvantageous asset.

With two boys in front and two boys in the back, we would carry the heavy plywood from a pile and feed it to the sawmill machine.

It was timed repetitive work and under pressure from the floor supervisor, whose reputation was dependent on the throughput of the machines.

At the end of the day, we would have done over a hundred cycles of feeding the machine. Then before we departed to our homes, we would move the finished furniture to the showroom or load them onto a truck.

After work, in order not to bother James, I would have dinner on my own. It was very basic. The idea was to fill up with protein and carbohydrates. I needed to stay alive and strong for the next day.

It would be bread, a can of sardines, and a bottle of Coke. There was not much deviation from this life-sustaining formula.

Then I would join James in his *chicken coop*, weary with little strength left. Then the night battle would commence, and the enemies would be the elements that I had no power over.

And I would be even more exhausted when the night was over. I would then join the factory work, ill-prepared and not fully charged.

And that was the pattern of my new life with James in the suburb of Yaba in Lagos. The cumulative effect of accumulated exhaustion began to take a toll on me. But I needed to stay strong and pretend everything was fine.

On Sundays, when there was no work, I needed a private moment for myself. I would leave James and wander into the city, almost without purpose. I would almost always end up under the giant iroko tree not too far from the house, as if to take solace.

This giant tree appeared to be older than the age of all the generations of the city dwellers put together. An obvious respect was accorded to the ancient tree when the dusty road appeared to meander around it. It was a tree believed by the Yoruba to have its own spirit. And anyone that cut it down would cause a devastating misfortune to himself and all his family. Special prayers of protection were required when the need arose to cut it down.

The evergreen leaves provided a comfortable shade, even to the robins that frequented it. Their happy chirpings provided a background harmony that smothered a hot day's relaxation.

The dirty benches, scattered with bird droppings, appeared to have been purposely abandoned in the shade as sacrifice to the tree. It would be one of these benches that I would hijack for the rest of the day.

With my chin heavily planted in the heel of my palm, I would gaze into the emptiness in misery, a melancholy that appeared to be endless. I observed all kinds of people purposely going about their normal lives. I would occasionally zoom in on the fanciful cars that passed by and hoped that, one day, I would be able to ride in one.

As I pondered over my current situation, I realized I was a non-entity. My past life came to a screeching stop. My education hit a

brick wall. My dream career was in jeopardy. I was dumped by my first love.

My future was all a gamble. It was all based on hope. One hope depended on the antecedent. And each piled on the other like a root-less Lego that depicted the Leaning Tower of Pisa in Italy.

But I had four pillars represented by the four commandments I inherited from Uncle Guyman. These provided the stability and strength to cling to the hopes that formed the basis of my future destiny.

Occasionally I would observe a giant lizard fall from the heights of the giant iroko tree, and out of the stupor of the plunge, it would lift its head and nod it on the floor three times, as if to pat itself on the back to have survived the great plunge. I cried to feel sorry for myself and wondered why I had to go through all these at a tender and formative part of my life.

But the survival of a fallen lizard, even from a height that was unimaginable by the little creature, strengthened my hope that one day I would rise from the ashes.

After the mental exhaustion from the wonderland, I would sleep under the spirited iroko tree hoping for an induction from it with a spirit that would help lift me up from my apparent eternal misery.

It was the same pattern as my days in Yaba rolled into weeks, and the weeks rolled into months. Working all week, I suffered to sleep at night and pondered in misery on Sundays. Despite the encouragement from the fallen lizards, the misery on my face became more and more palpable.

There was no letup from my situation that felt like a hardcore criminal serving a sentence in a labor camp. The night fight was the same as the day's physical labor.

James attempted to rescue the situation. My education up to the advanced level was his trump card. His supervisors accepted his plea for me to be moved to the accounts department.

Indeed the pride on my face, showing relief from physical labor, was serene. The envy from my factory floor coworkers was evident. But like the cliché goes, each one for himself, and God for us all. I was indifferent to their feelings.

The work then became more enjoyable. I was filing documents. I was not dirty, I was not breathing in dirty air, I was relieved from the constant otitic barotrauma caused by the cutting machines.

I was, indeed, working in relative luxury. My salary got increased. I began having a bit more income to put away for the European leg of my journey to the dreamland.

The only labor left was that of the night when I had to sleep in the corridor and fight with the giant malicious mosquitoes and the natural elements. But my suffering from these nightly wars was offset by new income.

About four months into my quasi labor camp at the grace of my confidant, James, my nocturnal war was made even more difficult. It notched up my stress level by several degrees.

And it happened so quickly, just as I was getting a breathing space from my physically demanding day job.

James's landlord, as I moved into his radar, exhausted his tolerance level for me for sleeping in the corridor. He accosted James that he was not supposed to have a squatter for this long. He asked James to immediately terminate my parasitic tenancy and to do so immediately.

This was a huge setback. An uncomfortable convenience was taken away from me. In Lagos, I only knew James, and moving away from him removed my comfort zone. Spending money on rent would decelerate my savings.

But I was familiar with the character of some Nigerians that crossed my path. They could be very crazy, and if you did not heed their demand, they would readily jeopardize your life. In my situation, I could simply have been taken away in my hard-earned sleep and would never see the light of the day any longer.

Without delay and hesitation, I quickly had to find a cheap place to live. For the first time in my life, I would man up and live on my own.

I moved to Agege, a suburb near a Lagos State local government area called Oshodi. It was Agege that put a crust on my core.

It was cheap housing and measured to my budget. The four walls together with the roof of my new home were made of alumi-

num sheets. The flooring was plain earth. It was the same architecture for all the housing units in this locality. And it stretched as far as the eyes could see.

There was a huge gutter separating our aluminum township from the main. This doubled as a dumping ground for refuse and a drain for the area during the heavy downpours. The stagnated water and debris created a stench that constantly swallowed our aluminum township.

Getting used to the stench was one thing, but the welcome from the large aimless flies, the crawlers, and the fearless mosquitoes was another.

In the afternoon, the sound of the expanding metal would remind us that our home was heating up. The ambient heat could sometimes attain a level that could toast a piece of bread. I did not have to endure this inferno in the afternoon because I was only mostly at home in the evenings to sleep.

In the night, when the heated aluminum settled to its natural state, there would be relative coolness. But this was constantly interrupted by the feisty female mosquitoes who wanted a piece of your blood to fertilize their eggs to perpetuate their existence.

And the vociferous nightcrawlers, especially the cockroaches, would scout around, sometimes in your pocket, looking for pieces of leftover crumbs you may have brought home.

The rainstorms in Lagos were fierce. When it rained, it felt like the taps of heaven had opened. The resultant flash floods could quickly overwhelm even the most sophisticated town drainage system.

Our aluminum township was at the mercy of the heavy rains. It flooded very quickly. Not uncommonly, the water would rise to the knee level; gradually it would recede into the nearby gutter.

When this happened in the night, it felt like waking up to continue a nightmare. If you did not wake up quickly, you would get drowned in the dirty flood water.

We would be up on our feet with all our important belongings out of the way. We waited for the water to drain out and cleaned up before lying down to sleep again.

The occupants in the little aluminum village called Agege were all of the same kind. We were hustlers from different geographic areas of poorer Africa. We all had a unique aim. We were all looking for the high-value Nigerian kobo. Many were temporary workers that were just passing through, like myself, and others made it their permanent home.

Our homes were unsecured, and pilfering was very common. We carried our money and important documents on our bodies at all times.

It was very easy to identify an Agege boy. We all had waist bags tightly secured around our beltline. These contained the goods so dear to our hearts. And even in our sleep, it was firmly secured underneath our body so that it was not compromised by intruders.

In Agege, we had monthly raids by the Lagosian mafia. These raids were, predictably, timed at the end of each month. This was the time most of the Agege hustlers got paid with the hard-earned kobo.

The raids usually occurred in the middle of the night. Armed with machetes, guns, or clubs, the mafia would force themselves into our aluminum homes and take whatever items they could lay their hands on. This included stereos, fans, electric stoves, kettles, and so on.

The shout of the code word *scatter* by a neighbor announced their presence. You did not have to think twice. All you needed to do was to run as fast as you could in the opposite direction. You were sure your important documents were already secured on your body. You carried whatever you could in addition with it. Anything you left behind would certainly not be yours when the raid was over.

Unlike many of my neighbors, I was fortunate to have James in the background. My earnings and important documents were with him for safekeeping. I did not need to acquire material things. I was in transit to the promised land, and money was all I wanted.

The raids, the rains, the feisty mosquitoes, the stench from the gutter, the nightcrawlers were always the subject of conversations. How much worse could it be to be called a tough man? I got hardened, core and crust.

I bonded with some of my neighbors in Agege. We had similar aims and aspirations. We shared our dreams, our wants, and our needs.

Agege was a launchpad for our dreams. We pondered how quickly and easily it was for these area boys, who turned themselves into mafia, to acquire all the wealth that we so desired in a single raid.

But one wondered what benefits the area boys derived from these stolen items. They had nothing to show for it. Their vision was not ours. It was no further than their nose.

Envyng them would have been making a pact with the devil.

On Sundays, we would gather in a local chop bar and treat ourselves to the local delicacy, *ebba* and *agoushi* soup. The joint always had the weekly *Newsweek* magazine. The in-depth analysis of international affairs in this magazine was an aspiration to our future plans.

One day, I chanced upon an article in the *Newsweek* magazine. It tickled my palate. It could potentially aid my trip to the promised land.

It was about the morning and evening rush hours when volumes of people preferred to travel between East Berlin and West Berlin. The article detailed the frustration of the immigration officers during these rush hours. It elaborated that between the hours of 4:00 a.m. to 5:00 a.m., and again 4:00 p.m. to 5:00 p.m. respectively, there was no legroom in the trains for them to do their work.

Therefore, during these hours, the officials were paralyzed and were unable to check the travel documents of citizens traveling from communist East Germany to capitalist West Germany.

I detached this article from the magazine and took it to my aluminum house. I read it over and over again. And the more I did, the wider my smile.

Their predicament would be in complete harmonious tandem with my plan to enter West Germany. This would be my Trojan horse to West Berlin.

Simply put, if I were to get on the train in communist East Berlin during the rush hour, there was no way I could be approached by any border agent throughout my journey into West Germany. I shouted this epiphany to myself in jubilation like a schizoid.

I quickly began to hatch the pathways to West Germany. As advised, I must first stop over in Bulgaria to seek assistance and be coached for the crossing from East Germany to West Germany.

The visa process to communist Eastern Europe was not as difficult due to the ties the then Ghana government had with them. And it was particularly easier to get a visa to Bulgaria and East Germany.

I did not know anyone in any of these countries. All I had to back up my plans was my wits. But when successful, I could legalize my stay in West Germany either as a refugee or naturalize by marriage.

As comprehensive as it sounded, it was still a dream plan. And nothing goes according to plan—only luck does.

From the big slumber into the real world, I continued to work in the furniture factory. The job of the accounts clerk was relatively lighter. But in the night, I would return to the slums. In my aluminum house, I would endure the nuances of the night and be happy to wake up the following day above the ground.

But as the months rolled, my savings got bigger. My promotion helped, and my rent was relatively minuscule, but I got what I paid for. By courtesy of James, all my earnings were in a safe place.

One Sunday, I made a special visit to James in his “coop.” It was an opportunity to discuss my carefully hatched plan of the next leg of my adventure. He was full of encouragement, and his blessing was an added catalyst for the adventure.

Approximately a year after I joined Swenig Furniture Company, I was able to acquire the wealth I had aimed for. Certainly it was a hard-earned wealth, and every bit of it would be judiciously used to enable me to settle in West Germany.

But just as I was about to plan for the next leg, the federal government of Nigeria issued an order for all Ghanaians to leave the country immediately. They claimed there were too many Ghanaians crowding the workspace and limiting opportunities for the indigenious people.

This was probably a reciprocation of the forced repatriation from Ghana of all Nigerians that were born and bred in Ghana. This

was about twenty years earlier when that order was issued by the then Busia government of Ghana.

And so “Ghana must go” became a mantra in Nigeria. There was a precipitous exodus of Ghanaians back to their home country in order to meet the deadline.

For me, going back to Ghana would be counterproductive. “Forward ever and backward never” was the soft song that wrangled in my head. There was nothing but despair for me in Ghana.

Indeed the repatriation order was the opportunity for me to embark on my second-leg trip to the promised land. The initial destination was a stopover in communist Bulgaria. And this country was the most important rate-determining step of all the hopes piled up in the stepwise Lego.

Getting to Bulgaria, the rootless base of the Lego, would also serve as a record for being the first village boy from Mabang to set foot on European soil. And even if I was deported back to Ghana, the pride of the achievement would deface any internal remorse I would have had for not achieving my aim.

On reflection, the stopover in Nigeria was a great success albeit the inferno of hardship I endured. I set out to save \$2,000. I did it in record time—one year.

The repatriation order, a blessing in disguise, was an accelerator, edging me to start the next leg of my journey. And so I collected my passport, the most cherished document, from James. It was all intact except for the nibbles at one edge from the stray and hungry mice that frequently visited James at night.

I needed to present myself decently at the embassies of Bulgaria and East Germany respectively in Lagos. I did not have a second chance to make my first impression.

When I collected my hard-earned savings from James, I spent a bit on my external appearance in order to be presentable.

With a timid swag in my steps, one after another, I presented myself to the consulates of Bulgaria and East Germany respectively, with the completed applications, the required documents, and fees. My nervousness was palpable as the final hour of my little jumps had finally arrived.

Even though I was confident to get the visas, refusal would have been an unexpected disaster with great repercussions on my future.

Everything went like clockwork when I exited the premises of these consulates. In my hand were the official documents from the consulates of Bulgaria and Eastern Germany firmly plastered in my partially nibbled passport.

With these, I was allowed to leave the soil of Africa to another continent whose culture was completely alien to mine. There I needed to outwit their system in order for me to be accepted.

With pride but uncertain what awaited me, I bought my first airline ticket on a Balkan airline, en route to East Germany but with a stopover in Bulgaria. I did it with my own money. And, in 1981, I kissed my beloved continent goodbye.

ADVENTURE IN BULGARIA

My journey to Bulgaria was like believing in the dream and living in reality. I pat both cheeks simultaneously with the palm of my two hands as if to wake me up from a deep slumber. But it was a consistent reality that the boy from Mabang was actually going to step on European soil.

It was an adventure from the beginning to the end. I did not know anyone there. I was embarking on this journey with all my life's savings of \$2,000. My support was my wits and my guide was the four commandments I inherited from Uncle Guyman.

I must use my little treasure wisely until I reached West Germany. There I would, hopefully, regularize my stay, either by asylum or otherwise. And somehow the system—whatever it would be—would continue to support me.

All these speculations of hope, strung along in a manner that one depended on the success of the antecedent, produced nothing but a bag of mixed emotions of anxiety and happiness, bouncing off each other.

The first hurdle to clear was coming to terms with the airplane journey. It was my first time on a long-haul international flight. And I had a very important and pressing question, which, in retrospect, portrayed my infantile naivete of international travel.

What would happen if I had to answer nature's call had always been the question on a sticky pad stuck in my brain as I began to prepare my maiden flight to Bulgaria. As naive as it may seem, I

was curious if such large long-haul airplanes were well-equipped with adequate toilet facilities for all the passengers.

Hitherto, the nearest I came closer to a large long-haul aircraft was the sight of it in the sky. I had no concept of its actual size and interior sophistication. It was all beyond my imagination.

My naivete was really exposed at the check-in desk. After the formality, I politely posed my curiosity to the counter clerk. The look on her face said it all. Without words, the answer was affirmative, but my whole package, in her mind, summed me as a covered-up villager.

I did not blame the clerk. She was right to a large extent. My new look created the visual effect I was expecting for me.

Because I did not have a second chance. This was it. But in reality, I was the boy from Mabang and hardened in the slums of Agege.

My anxiety for lack thereof of a place for convenience in an aircraft was annulled with an embarrassment, but it was a positive assurance of how I would be visually perceived as I stepped into my new world—Bulgaria.

I had a culture shock as I stepped on board the plane. I thought to myself, *Was it really me?* I was elated. With a big smile, I proceeded to find my seat.

The seat, comfortable but smaller than I had expected, was a window seat. And even though I was flanked inconveniently on one side by a fat-looking gentleman, it was the perfect seat for me to view my world changing from old to new.

All my senses were elevated to their highest level of alertness as the plane took off from Lagos. The destination was Sofia, the capital city of Bulgaria.

Every bit of the experience of flying to my new world was an enjoyable novelty. I did not want to miss any of it. It was a maiden plane trip to Europe, but it should not be overtly obvious, especially to the fat passenger next to me, whom I engaged in a conversation throughout most of the flight.

Indeed, whilst not making it obvious of the real intention of my travel, I was probing if he could be of help when we arrived in Sofia.

I enjoyed the plane food. It was the first time I had experienced a three-course meal. The portions were small, but the presentation

filled me up as would my usual one-course meal of *ebba* and *egushi* soup.

And when nature called in the middle of my flight, I was curious and pleased to visit the private room. My first impression was how small it was. They only provided a tortoise elbow room to maneuver. I fitted in with just enough room to perform my duty. But my thoughts were about how fat people could manage the space.

I hardly slept throughout the journey. The anxiety of the uncertainty ahead of me engulfed any relaxation that would have been as a result of living the reality of my dream. The real immediate predicaments were where I would sleep and who would assist me to survive in Sofia.

As I began to feel tired from the physical and mental exhaustion, it was announced the beginning of the descent to Sofia. There was a perceivable and uncomfortable chill in the climate in the airplane. It was definitely getting colder. I saw other passengers putting on extra layers of clothing to keep warm.

I did not foresee a weather that was colder than that of Lagos. It did not come as a natural instinct as I prepared to travel to Bulgaria. My life's experience had only been in Africa, where warm weather all year round was always a guarantee. I did not prepare for a cold climate. I did not have warm clothes. I did not have a jacket. This was simply not on my radar.

I disembarked from the airplane feeling very cold. But somehow, before the doors of the airplane would open, I thought it would be warmer outside so I could get some warmth.

But I got colder and colder as I walked toward immigration. In the midst of the discomfort as my core temperature cooled down to an untested level, I had to come up with a story of my purpose and my destination in Sofia.

I had no idea where I was going to stay. My intention was to roam around the city and sleep anywhere that the element of the weather would allow me.

If I spent my little treasure in a hotel, it would finish in no time.

But the immigration officer would need to record my destination since it was a compulsory requirement on the landing card I prefilled before disembarking.

It was my turn to approach the immigration officer. At this time, I was almost frozen. My natural thermal mechanism tried to generate extra internal heat, which was evidenced by the pronounced shivering of all the muscles of my body. I saw the goose pimples on my arm stand hard and my voice shaking.

My anxiety level was at its highest. What would happen if I did not produce an address?

The officer, who was White, bald, but his bushy eyebrows appeared to have pushed away his small spectacles over the bridge of his nose, looked at me squarely, the orifice of his blue eyes projecting over the top of his glasses.

With a deep and unfriendly voice, he asked, "Where are you going, young man?"

As I prepared to search for a nonexistent answer, I read from his face that his focus and attention was on the shakes emanating from the muscles under my one-layered T-shirt.

I fumbled with the answer. It was obvious it did not come automatically. But it felt as if it was a godsent answer when it did. I did not preconceive it with my frozen brain. Its origin was deep down my bowels.

My guts on the spot asked me to tell the officer that my family was picking me up at arrivals. The words came out in spasms as my voice shook from the fibrillation of the articulating muscles.

As the officer pondered whether it was a good answer for the specific question, his attention drifted more and more to the suffering I was enduring from my unprepared dressing for the cold weather.

Instead of him drilling me further for the appropriate answer, my response appeared to have catalyzed his sympathy. He became more interested in me joining my family quickly so I could get warm clothes.

At the sound of the stamp in my passport, I felt my heart's race come to an abrupt halt. And the immediate relief from the anxiety of clearing a major hurdle justified my suffering. I dashed out of his

sight as fast as I could, just in case he had to recall me back to provide the crucial answer. Only God would know the answer he generated to fill the gap I did not provide.

From this point onward, I became the cartoon character *Curious George*. I had to ask questions to survive. But there were two major problems.

There was a language barrier. The main languages in Sofia were Bulgarian, Russian, and Turkish. English was hardly spoken.

In addition, everyone was White, and Black people were a rarity. How could I even ask for the real help I needed, such as a place to sleep and the help I needed to continue my journey to West Berlin?

I could not pour my heart out to a white man. I could be speaking to a law enforcement agent and the next thing I knew I could be on the next airplane back to Africa under escort. I was hoping to meet any Black person who could assist me survive in the short term.

I took the available bus to the beautiful city center of Sofia. I was directed to the right place in the heart of the city to alight. My immediate need was to get some warm clothes and find a shelter.

Sofia was my first experience of any European city. Every bit of it was a culture shock. Compared to where I just came from, Lagos, the city was well-planned and clean. Trains, buses, taxis were all running in an orderly fashion.

To my surprise, the people were not only polite but went out of the way to be helpful. Probably, also, they were just as curious of the Black man as I was of them.

I bought myself a thick yellow fur jacket, and multiple warm T-shirts, hand gloves, and a warm head cap. I piled on layers and layers of clothes on my body in a manner that I could never have imagined the day before when I was in the scorching city of Lagos.

Then when I became hungry, I wanted to find something to eat. And it must not be too expensive. I hopped from one restaurant to another and looked at the menu with particular reference to the price. I finally settled in a fast-food joint.

As I began to get busy with the cheeseburger—the first I had ever had in my entire life—and bought with my hard-earned currency, I saw the first Black man.

I froze momentarily, perhaps out of a pleasant elation. As I chewed the juicy burger, I fixed my gaze on him so that he did not get out of sight.

He had a broom in one hand and a pan in the other. And he started cleaning the mess other people left behind in the vicinity of the restaurant. He was definitely an employee of the restaurant but in the janitorial department.

I asked myself what else he could have done in this White-dominated land. He was probably like me, an economic refugee, attempting to make life better for himself and his family back home.

I felt spiritually connected to him immediately. As he approached my direction, the connection became stronger. I said hello, and he responded with a big smile. In the foreign land, it felt like we were brothers united by a common skin color.

He told me he would join me during his break. I would wait for him as long as it took. I was not in a rush to leave the restaurant, which also doubled up as a warming oven for my almost frozen body.

I was happy to open up to him as he joined me on my table near a huge radiator. He was equally pleased to meet his kind, whom he rarely saw in the restaurant.

His story was similar to mine, in principle. Hustlers seeking a better life for our future. He gave me tips on the strategy to survive under the radar of the law enforcement agencies. He directed me to a safe house where I could spend the night.

The thirty-minute talk with him was the most important level-101 lesson on my education of survival for the journey ahead of me to the promised land. It was informative and added more credence to my hopes.

I headed to the safe house. It was tucked away in a relatively poorer end of the city. It could even be labeled Agee of Sofia, but definitely a higher scale, comparatively. It was set up for the poor and the homeless to help them survive the unforgiving cold winter weather.

It was simply a very large hall, very warm and cozy, with a large fitted kitchen on one side. It had multiple washrooms. A large room

was fitted for community showers. There were many sleeping bags with heavy blankets.

The patrons appeared to be mainly foreigners who had, for one reason or the other, become destitute. Their survival was dependent on the grace and magnanimity of kind people. They served hot soup embedded with chunks of potato and scattered pieces of shredded meat. The purpose was to fill you up and warm you up. The emphasis on the taste was definitely null.

The cook certainly met his objectives as I gobbled the soup down my gullet, one spoon after the other, as fast as I could. At the end of the meal, and after several cycles of the soup gliding down into my stomach, the taste became more apparent. I began to think about how I managed it all through my palate.

But it was free, and the priceless gesture was on point—in time and place.

During the day, the cleaner I had met, who called himself Peter, asked me to keep moving all the time and always look purposeful. You stood a chance of being arrested and repatriated if they felt the alien had no purpose of being in their country. The police patrolled the town in an attempt to sanitize it from thugs and rogues. Peter advised me to keep out of their radar so that I was not misconstrued.

And so I walked the town and rode the buses and trains all day like an aimless dog. When tired, I would hide under the bridges. There I would meet people of my kind to get tips for my onward trip to West Berlin.

The cold weather was certainly my unexpected enemy, as were the extreme heat and vociferous mosquitoes in Agege. I battled it with great difficulty.

During the day, the hot sun that we usually took for granted in the tropical African sky felt like a shadow of its power. Its shine, as it appeared to struggle to penetrate the constant cumulus-overshadowing clouds, would hit the skin with such a feeble energy. And just as its strength began to pick up to the needed intensity, it was time to set again, as the shorter daytimes were overrun by the prolonged winter nights.

And so I became a street boy in Sofia. I fit the definition of a homeless person. My life became regimented. Keep walking. Seek shelter under bridges. Hide from the police. Visit safe houses for warmth, and take advantage of free food when available.

As I discovered the town, I found more safe houses. I varied the sleeping location from one safe house to the other. This was a precaution to evade the suspicion of any law enforcement officer of an alien who had no purpose.

My sleeping arrangements even became more sophisticated when my co-hustlers explained a strategy that made the nightclubs a safe place to spend the night.

I would enter the nightclub as a partygoer. I would buy a small amount of liquor. As I downed it, I moved from one corner of the club to the other to be noticeable by its operators. Then, as if I were drunk, I would crash on the comfortable furniture and have a good night's sleep.

After being rendered tired from walking all day in very cold weather, the sound of the loud music did not tickle my tympanic membrane. I developed a complete sound inattention until I fully paid my sleep debt.

And so Thursday night through Sunday, I spent three nights in different nightclubs.

Personal hygiene was a problem. I could not tolerate the cold showers in the safe houses. I could not wash my clothes. I found the top layers of my skin flake into powder anytime I exposed any part of my body. My toes were mushy as they infrequently saw the light of day. My sneakers I bought from Nigeria were wearing out as I was economizing to stretch my savings.

As I endured life's harshest treatment, be it in my aluminum house in Agege or as a homeless street boy in Sofia, I had one singular agenda in my current situation. I needed to work up a plan into the Trojan Horse from East Berlin to West Berlin. Sofia, my new Agege, would get all the credit. I needed trusted people to help me.

The selection of a confidant was important so that I was not exposed. The people I met—the Blacks—could not be trusted. Most of them had been in the streets of Sofia for a long time. Some of them

tried and failed to get on the Trojan Horse. They lost their steam as their ambition splattered and sublimed into the frigid climate of Sofia.

All their travel documents expired. They were in survival mode. They would prey on any weak targets. They were ready to steal money or documents from the just-arrived. In the era devoid of biometric identification, impersonation was common, as the Caucasians had difficulty distinguishing Black people's faces on a travel document.

Valid travel documents were high-priced objects, and they could be sold for cash to adventurers intending to get on the Trojan Horse. And just as in Lagos, my waist bag became handy. It contained all my treasury, which kept them on my body, even when I was asleep.

In the midst of the multiple nuances prevalent in my way in Sofia, I advised myself not to rush. I needed a great deal of patience to get the right person to help me. I needed to keep warm and stay away from suspicious law enforcement agents.

I kept busy, riding the trains and the buses on end, moving from one shopping center to another. I was superficially busy with a fulfillment that was usually nothing but empty. I was hoping to find that needle in the haystack—the trustworthy good Samaritan that would provide all the cues to get on the Trojan Horse and beyond.

One day, as if the stars were aligned, I met a decent-looking Black man in the mall. His looks could certainly not be confused as Ghanaian. He was a Kumasi man. His first words were in Twi language, and he introduced himself as Kofi Agyeman. My first impression of him gave me a lot of confidence and augmented my hope.

As I explored him further, I learned he had been in Bulgaria much longer. After failing to cross to the West, he managed to legalize his stay in the country and found himself a niche business in Sofia.

With the help of his syndicates in the far west city of Berlin, he coached the brave how to cross the border. On arrival in West Berlin, his partners would rescue the successful arrivals and coach them on how to settle in West Germany.

Clearly, Kofi had all the information I needed. But that did not come cheap. His help would be the key to the Trojan Horse and a

pivotal moment for my purpose in Bulgaria. I was willing to honor any fee that he would propose.

He proposed to collect \$200 for his service. At the time, this was a lot of money. But as I had already prepared for this purpose and was frugal with my spending since my arrival in Sofia, the sum only made a small dent in my treasury.

With the handshake contract already behind us, I became his next pupil for the lessons of the crossing. Indeed he bragged about his past successes using the loophole I had read about in Lagos.

He coached me on how to obtain the ticket for the crossover and the geography of the station in East Berlin, where I should be on the Trojan Horse.

He underscored the fact that nothing would work if I did not board the train during the rush hour. I needed the human shield to protect me from the immigration officers. I must enter the train early and situate my little body in the center of the train. There would be little leg room left as the train rapidly filled up with people commuting from East Berlin to West Berlin.

He warned me I should be prepared to be compressed almost to suffocation for the short trip. With this kind of train load, the immigration officers who usually went from coach to coach to check travel documents became crippled. It was almost a free pass on immigration during this particular rush hour.

He emphasized that I should count the stops as the train rolled from its station from communist East Berlin to capitalist West Berlin. I should be ready to jump off the train at the tenth stop.

He advised that at the sound of the door of the train opening at this stop, I must get out as rapidly as I could and precipitously head to the nearest escalator.

The escalator would take me to the ground level, where there would be immigration officers waiting to check travel documents. To evade them, I needed to run through the checkpoint as fast as I could and across the open field on my right.

He assured me that the immigration officer would not chase an African boy, for the pride of getting ashamed for becoming second best in the race.

At the far end of the field would be another contractor who would identify himself by speaking the Twi language to me. His business was to fish for new arrivals, whom he would house for only one night. He would coach me on my settlement options in West Germany. The following morning, he would release me and advise the direction where I could seek help.

His charge would be another \$200.

And this was the plan. It seemed straightforward. Many had tried and failed. There were no guarantees. If it failed, I would be on the next available airplane and a free flight back to Ghana.

I would be counted as a deportee. In my case, it would have been discreet, and no one would know about it in Ghana. Most of my acquaintances knew I was still in Nigeria.

But I did not want to think about the consequences of not succeeding. For me, this journey to the unknown world was a fight between life and death. My destiny depended on it.

I could only fail by trying. I would attribute it to destiny with no regrets should the plan end up in the dumps.

And so rising from the shadows of Sofia after approximately four months, and my transit plane ticket still valid, I was ready to take the bull by its horn and embark on the adventure of my next leg. It would be one step closer to my promised land. It was only I that could make a difference in my life.

CROSSING FROM EAST BERLIN TO WEST BERLIN

The coaching by Kofi Agyeman was now over. It was time to put this into practice. From this point onward, any little slip would result in a jail time followed by immediate deportation.

There were no guarantees for this adventure. It was all dependent on hopes and wits to cleverly outsmart a system in an alien land. I had planned everything, and I felt I had better odds.

I would first have to fly from Sofia to Communist East Germany and find my way from the airport to the border in East Berlin. It was a relatively short plane ride, which was filled with anxiety and nerves for the daring adventure I was about to embark on.

The chosen day for the journey in the *Trojan Horse* was a Monday. It was a day that I presumed most people would travel after a restful weekend. It was a day the trains usually got full to a maximum capacity. It would be a day that the human shield in the *Trojan Horse* would be so strong that the immigration officer would stand no chance of checking documents. It would be a day that would guarantee no room for error.

I needed to externally look appealing for my trip. New clothes and a new backpack were essential. I packed light so there would be little hindrance to sprint when chased.

The most important property, my passport and my money, were tightly strapped around my waist in the weathered waist bag that accompanied me from Agege.

Indeed I arrived at the train station in East Berlin with all my worldly belongings.

It was just before 4:00 p.m. when I bought my ticket. When I arrived at the train platform, there was already a sea of people. I was about the only Black man as far as my eyes could see.

As instructed, I needed to get on the train in a manner that I would be embedded in the middle of the coach.

In my scanty African-accented German for “excuse me,” I tried to squeeze my little skinny body between the well-fed chubby White people.

After several “*Entschuldigen Sie, bitte*,” the polite Germans made way for me to the front row.

Not long after, it may have been approximately 4:15 p.m., I heard the loud horn of the arriving train. I saw the coaches speed before me in relenting velocity.

Finally all the coaches stood still. My heart pounded hard as the doors flung open. “This is it,” I said to myself.

Momentarily I reflected on the time I reached out to the *Newsweek* magazine in faraway Agege. I remembered the content of the article. This was me actually reliving the story.

I was now on the *Trojan Horse*, well-planted in its belly, protected by the sheer density of humans who, whilst going about their normal duties, were oblivious of the kindness they were also showing for the little African boy who was striving to have a livelihood as themselves.

There was no further legroom as the doors of the coach quickly closed and locked all of us in a static stance. I felt well-protected from any immigration officer.

I was shorter than everyone else around me. I could not see outside through the windows. I felt suffocated by the dense breath containing the aroma of coffee and cigarette from the people around me. I felt claustrophobic and could not wait to get out.

But it was a price worth paying, and I needed to concentrate on my task to accurately count the train stops. As the train started to roll from the station, I felt I was on my way, and each inch of its movement got me closer to the promised land.

From one stop to the other, the doors would slide open to exchange passengers. But as there were many more people jumping on than jumping off, I felt more and more squeezed in the center, an assurance of maximum protection from immigration officers.

One by one, I mentally counted the stations as the doors opened and closed.

And as the count got closer to ten, I felt my throat getting drier as my anxiety level was getting to its peak. I was getting closer to the launch pad that would catapult me to my final destination, the promised land. I was nervous; there was no second chance.

Finally we were at the tenth. It may have been a major station. Everyone wanted to get out. I did not have to ask for my reprieve from the tight squeeze. Within a few minutes, I was out of the belly of the *Trojan Horse*.

I felt naked and very vulnerable. I had no protection. I had no documents to show that I had the right to be where I stood. I was an illegal immigrant. Only I knew that at this moment. And I had to play my cards well to evade the immediate danger.

I followed my cues. I located the escalator to my right. There were a few in that direction. Those may definitely be the exit to ground level. It did not matter which one I chose. As the packed escalator squeaked to the ground level, my heart thumped even harder.

As soon as I surfaced to the ground level, I saw a checkpoint. It was for the immigration formalities. It seemed quick and seamless as the officers were just inspecting a form of identity card from the East Berliners who were brothers by blood but separated by ideology.

What was I going to show to these officers? If I behaved like the East Berliners at this point, it would be like offering myself on a silver platter to the slaughterhouse. I could be put in prison and forcibly removed from the country. That would be the end of my dream.

As these thoughts haunted me, I was getting mentally prepared for the start of my sprint into the open field Kofi advised.

I must have been about fifteen-people-deep in one of the lines. I needed to quickly plan my escape as the line got shorter and shorter. I surveyed around to ensure there were no physical barriers to impede my escape.

I looked out in the direction of the large glass window ahead of me. There were no impediments. There were only commercial vehicles picking up people and merchandise.

On the far side was the empty field Kofi talked about, and I knew my rescue was waiting for me somewhere at its periphery in disguise. It was bitterly cold as the grass was covered with a thin layer of ice. The chill certainly did not permit any idler to hang around this space that appeared to have been set aside for my race.

After physically gauging my immediate surroundings, it was time for me to start my race. At this time, the line was about five people deep. I dashed out of the line like a sprinter to the open door.

The sprint, to my surprise, seemed rather like an excitement to onlookers. I saw nothing but excited eyeballs and heads turning rapidly to follow my progression.

No one, to my surprise, was on my heels. Not even the law enforcement agents. I was sure they felt it was pointless to chase a fast-running little African boy. I had the physique compared to their chubby bodies, and I also had the start advantage. I could outrun any of them physically.

With my little backpack on my back and my waist belt bag tightly secured, I ran across the snowy grass like a hunted cheetah. The direction was aimless but to the other side of the field.

As I was approaching the far end, exhaustion began to take a good hold of me. I was panting. My heart was beating fast, and sweat started oozing out of the pores of my skin that had not been bathed in a long time. The chilling ambient air immediately solidified any warm air that came out from my body, sending my mouth and nose to smoke like chimneys.

Then I heard the word *akwaaba* shouted in the distance. I felt, momentarily, that I was in a trance. Was it real? It was in a perfect Twi accent. And I knew immediately that the welcome message was from my contractor.

I slightly redirected my course to the origin of the voice. As I approached, I saw a wave in the distance. It became stronger as the beckon encouraged me to the finish line.

The contractor dressed for the occasion. He was heavily padded with layers of clothes to prepare him for the outdoor job. His turtle-neck warm undergarment reached the edge of his lower lip, and the fluffy hat covered up to the upper eyebrows.

It was a young man in his late thirties, dressed to combat the bitterly cold weather but exaggerated it to double up as a distortion of the face of an illegal contractor.

He spoke Twi and asked me to follow him. After a few minutes' walk away from the train station, we took a bus and rode for a good thirty minutes to a suburb in West Berlin.

His house was a small apartment. The living room had a huge radiator on one side that was notched up to emanate maximal heat. There was a dirty brown loveseat sofa on one side and an unmatched comfort seat closer to the radiator.

A small television transmitting black-and-white pictures in German was left on whilst he was out. Beside it was a stereo player. The two, mounted on partially defaced wooden furniture together with a paired large freestanding loudspeaker on either side, represented his entertainment center.

The carpet had seen its good old days. The distinctive fluffiness of the feel of a carpet had transformed into a hardened piece of cloth covering the floor.

This was definitely an upscale living for me as I compared it to my aluminum house in Agege. Given that this was the tip of the iceberg of good living, it was enough to convince me of a better life if my hopes crystallized into reality.

He introduced himself as Gemfi. He had been in Germany for five years. He arrived in the country, just as I did, in the *Trojan Horse*. With very little education, his job opportunities were limited in Germany. He joined the gang of the contractors that facilitated the transit from East Berlin to West Berlin.

His job was usually like a one-night stand. He would pick you up from the train station, house you for twenty-four hours, coach you during this period, let you out the following day, pointing you in the direction to seek further help.

I paid the agreed amount of \$200 for the job. At this point, my body was shaking uncontrollably as my frozen core was adapting to his warm ambience.

I removed my sneakers and socks so that my almost frostbitten feet could also see the light of the day and enjoy the ambient heat. To ensure maximum heat, I placed my feet on the radiator.

I was embarrassed when any part of my exposed body, especially my feet, smelt like rotten fish. Indeed my whole body had not touched soap and water in a very long time.

Then he pulled out from the fridge an already prepared meal. It was obvious that he prepared the African meal himself. It lacked savory sophistication and was flat to the tongue and palate. Hunger did not have a choice as I dug in until I could eat no more.

After the meal, we started the survival tutorial. I could feel his urge for me to grasp the lesson quickly so that I would make way for the next client the following morning.

I was a stowaway boy in a human *Trojan Horse*. He did not think this story would stick. He advised me to declare myself as a political refugee.

He came out with the story that my dad, an insider of the Ghanaian ruler, Flt. Lt. Jerry John Rawlings, fell out with his government. He was being sought after for unfair prosecution, following which he could be killed. He advised his children, of which I was one, to flee the country. Otherwise we would be arrested and used as ransom.

He asked me to write this story on a piece of paper. I was to present this letter to any immigration officer who demanded to see my documents.

He further said that seeking asylum in Hamburg, about 160 miles away, would be much quicker than doing the same in West Berlin.

The thought of the journey to Hamburg added another goose pimple to my anxiety. After my nicely shielded train ride across the border, here I was again, trying to take another train to another city, 160 miles away. If confronted by any immigration officer, and the story I had on paper did not stick, it could be the end of my dreams.

The following morning, when it was time for me to leave, my feet were swollen, red, and painful due to the frigid cold weather. They had been on the radiator on and off throughout the night. I was unable to fit them in my sneakers.

I saw the frustration on the face of my host, Gemfi. He would miss a day's salary if I did not leave. As a compromise, he asked me to pay an additional \$200 for the extra night.

I had no choice but to oblige. His shanty apartment had suddenly become a five-star hotel for me. But I thought it was a fair game. I needed to heal before the next trip.

The frustration of Gemfi settled after the money changed hands, but my anxiety continued to augment as the thoughts of my next train ride lingered on my mind.

After spending two nights with Gemfi, my feet were in the shape to carry me on the next *adventure*. This was the last leg to the destination that would grant me a legal stay, upon which I would be able to reach my ultimate dreamland.

As we walked to the train station, I said to myself that among all the odds against me, this was the most important piece. We waved each other goodbye before I turned my back to him and walked toward the train. I was on my own again. My shield was now a letter with a cooked-up story.

JOURNEY TO HAMBURG

At the train station in West Berlin, where I would board the Hamburg-bound train, I felt a *déjà vu* experience. It was the same place I had sprinted out of the queue two days earlier. This time, I arrived at the main hall through a different entrance. There were no cameras installed at the time. My chances of being recognized as the fugitive African sprinter were slim.

I walked confidently to the ticket desk. Within a few minutes, I held the ticket that would send me into the refugee camp in Hamburg. It was a mission accomplished for Gemfi and the beginning of uncertainty for me as I embarked on the last leg of a journey that would determine my future.

The train departed with the coaches sparsely filled. The journey would last for about three hours and cover a distance of approximately 160 miles. The train would stop at a few stations before we arrived at our final destination.

It was an intercity train within West Germany, and even though I was not documented, I felt relatively at ease with immigration issues whilst on this train. The comfort of the fake letter in my passport also gave me an additional buffer. A few stops had passed by, and I was beginning to stretch and enjoy the remainder of the journey.

But within a twinkle of an eye, I caught a glimpse of an immigration officer in the adjoining coach. Their distinctive uniform stood them out in the distance.

This officer was quite chubby and tall. His stern face was unmistakable for someone who took his assigned duty seriously.

One by one, he moved along, checking the identity documents of each suspected alien. I could feel my legs trembling as he made his way into my coach.

I was a few rows from the other end of the coach. I had time to dig out my passport. I made sure my letter was well in place.

When he eventually got to my seat, I was trembling like a leaf. His monotonous deep voice uttered the German words that I did not comprehend, but I guessed he was asking for my identity documents.

The tremor and the cold sweat on my outstretched hand as I presented him my passport with the embedded letter were very obvious. He turned the pages over and over again, obviously looking for a valid visa. I could feel he was getting frustrated that I was slowing down his job. I figured he wanted to complete the inspection before the next station.

At this point, I could have peed in my pants. My feet went jelly, and the despair on my face was almost palpable. I was almost there, halfway to my refugee camp, but this chubby and cantankerous man would ruin it all.

After failing to find what he wanted, he opened the piece of paper in the middle of the passport. I could feel more frustration on his face as he intensified the squeeze to understand written English. It was obvious he did not have any education in English.

His inspection stopped with me. If there was anyone else on the train with issues similar to mine, today was their lucky day. This chubby man was not leaving me. He had no intention to lose sight of me. He stayed with me till the next stop with my documents in his hands.

Shortly before the next station, he pushed an overhead button on the train. As soon as the train stopped, uniformed officers were in my carriage. He handed them my documents. I was escorted out of the train in handcuffs, while one of the officers carried my backpack.

At the gate, they put me in the back of a police car, which made its way with sirens on through a busy street. Within a few minutes, we were in an immigration office.

I was escorted through a side door into a large room at the back of the office. The police officer walked out of the room with my

handcuffs back on his belt. But the loud noise of the door closing in my face and three turns of the lock confirmed my confinement.

I would never have imagined in my life that I would ever be behind bars. I felt completely deflated, and all my hopes of getting to the promised land went flat on the ground, shattered into pieces.

The *Lego* of hopes that tilted like the pyramid of Pisa momentarily crumbled when the very top piece had its center of gravity beyond its base.

All my efforts, from the shanty home in Lagos, through the hustle in the cold streets of Sofia and the escape in the belly of the *Trojan Horse*, had all been shattered by one man, a chubby stern man who was performing his work with all seriousness to rid his country of illegal aliens.

My detention space was a cold room with no windows. The dim illumination, which revealed a bench and a toilet, compounded the doom and gloom of my situation. All I had on me was my money in my waist bag, tightly secured.

I did not know the exact duration I was confined. But what I knew was that I turned my detention room into a holy place before I was let out. Given that, hitherto, I was not a church fanatic, I felt *rebaptized* again with the incessant prayers I offered through Jesus and believed he would reign at the end of the day.

I wanted to straighten the record and change the narrative that any doubt I, Thomas, had for him, Jesus, was a fallacy.

When I was let out for interrogation, it was after the end of the normal working day. I may have been locked up for about six to seven hours.

My interlocutor spoke in clear English. It was obvious he had read and understood the content of my letter. He appeared to rush through his interrogations that would probe into the content of my claim.

He looked at his watch several times as we spoke and did not explore further details of the circumstances. It appeared he had a long day and wanted to finish with me quickly so that he could clock out.

After the interrogations were over, he paused to document my case with a typewriter. I was of the conviction that if anything would

happen to me, it would be based on the recommendation of this man.

He could recommend that I should be deported. He could also be kind enough to believe my plea that qualified me for an asylum.

Should he recommend the former, it would require a lot of paperwork that he had to submit to the court system to justify his decision. But if my prayers were answered, he would make the latter decision that required less paperwork.

In either case, my fate was already sealed. He was documenting his decision, and he would soon let it out of the bag.

Within a few minutes, he walked down to where I sat and handed over his documentation in an official sealed envelope. He told me I could seek asylum in Hamburg. He described where I should present the envelope. He then handed me my passport and showed me my baggage. He inspected the ticket I had bought from West Berlin, and it was still valid.

My praise for the Lord Jesus was at its highest when my prayers were answered. I gathered myself from my seat and had to come to terms with the fact that I would walk out of this place a free man.

I was his last client. He must have had a long and tedious day. He did not want to make the last case so complicated as to extend his hours any longer. The quickest option was the one he had chosen—to set me free and allow me to pursue my asylum that would protect me from the rogues chasing my father.

He locked up the office and gave me a ride to the train station. This was a train station that spoke to my destiny. In retrospect, the station revealed and represented the watershed of my future, when at the time I was oblivious of how it would become.

I was let off this station a fugitive in handcuffs. I returned to the same station on the same day, a few hours apart, a hero and a champion.

I waited for the next train with a rebound of confidence. Even though there were still a lot of uncertainties ahead of me, I needed to celebrate this piece of achievement in my own small way.

I bought myself the largest piece of hamburger from a nearby fast-food joint as I was waiting for the Hamburg-bound train. The

whole ordeal suppressed any appetite I would have had, but it immediately rebounded when I transformed into a *villain*.

It may have been about 10:00 p.m. when the next train arrived. I boarded and looked for a seat where I could be alone and reflect on myself. I was spoilt for choice as the options abounded on a late, probably the last, train.

As the train moved from one station to the next in the complete darkness that surrounded it, I felt the calmness of nature had taken control of my day's calamity. This allowed me to reflect on how lucky I was. I still had to play the game of hope in the remaining encounters that would finally accord me legal status to live in Germany.

If all failed, I would never see the promised land. But as an undocumented person in Hamburg, I could hide within the shadows and perform manual labor. This could give me a much better life compared to that in Africa.

As we approached Hamburg, fresh passengers joined my coach. There was one group that particularly stood out. They were about five young men who were having a good time.

Some appeared completely drunk, whilst the rest would have a 50 percent chance of passing a sobriety test.

They were loud, and their conversation in clear Twi language appeared to portray that they had a good time in a nightclub. One thing for sure was that they could not serve as role models for me in the new country I found myself in.

They appeared at ease and had comfortably mixed up with the society, probably by virtue of a document that protected them from any immigration official.

I needed help for my initial assimilation in the society. My current situation did not call for any discrimination at this time. They could be of help, I said to myself.

At the current moment in the train, I had no clue where I was going to sleep.

I did not think about it until now. I was used to sleeping under the warm bridges in Sofia. I thought I would manage to find somewhere when I got off the train.

But somehow, if I could get these strangers to allow me in their camp, it would allow me a head start in my quest for refugee status in Germany.

With courage, I walked up to them and said hello in Twi.

I received a mixed reception from their response.

Some of them clearly ignored me and expressed their unwillingness to allow a new arrival in their camp. They clearly stated I could be trouble for them.

Others were more open to talk to me. I chatted away with some of these drunkards under the jeering gaze of the others' unfriendly group. I explained my situation without giving too many details to the strangers.

I may have won the sympathy of the whole group after they heard of my ordeal in detention. And when the train came to a final stop, they invited me to come and spend one night with them.

With unmeasured happiness, I joined the bunch of drunks to their house.

It turned out that they were all living in a refugee camp in a suburb of Hamburg called *Knabeweg*.

It may have been close to 3:00 a.m. when we arrived, a day like no other, the longest I had ever been awake in recent memory. A day that I became a detained fugitive and an exonerated *villain*.

I entered the home of the two people that gave me the most attention on the train. They shared the same apartment.

They became more and more friendly as the ice broke. They could relate to my story as they became more and more intrigued.

As late as it was, they wanted to eat. They obviously had a persistent culinary attachment to their homeland, Ghana.

They warmed up a preprepared palm nut soup pulled out from the bottom of the fridge. Whilst this was warming up on an electric stove, they put together a cooked white dough called *fufu*. It was made from potato powder, and it conveniently represented the cassava *fufu*.

I had not eaten this combination of palm nut soup and *fufu* for well over eighteen months, not even in Agege. It was a fresh novelty

that brought memories back from the good old days in Mabang, where this food was eaten almost every day.

Dinner was over. Soon after, it was time to sleep. My bed was the only sofa in the living room, and my short height allowed me to fully stretch my body on the comfortable soft cushion.

I must have owed myself a lot of sleep. I needed to pay this debt. I slept throughout the following day and the following night. From time to time, my hosts would wake me up from my slumber to check if I was all right.

I got them scared as they thought I could die on them. I could not sustain any wakefulness and not even the ability to eat or drink.

It was about noon on the second day that I fully recovered from my sleepiness. They hailed me like a little hero when I found my true self. Secretly they were relieved that I was not going to be a liability if my little body could not sustain life.

I knew I smelled very badly in their home, and I had to apologize for it. In the last five months since I left Agege, there had not been any opportunity for me to have a warm shower and change clothes.

My hosts had made it possible now. All the body dirt I had accumulated in the past five months went down their drain. I felt rejuvenated and revitalized to face the new challenges ahead of me.

My hosts had queued up for the asylum process. They were waiting for the adjudication of their cases. They knew exactly the entry point of my case.

They were helpful in giving me the head start I much needed.

ASYLUM

I was now in Hamburg, the city where I would process my documents as a refugee. I would use my cooked-up story as my alibi: The son of a politician, whose family was on the run from a political persecution in Ghana.

I already had a head start, courtesy of two good people whom I had earlier misconstrued as a bunch of aimless drunkards. They provided a home that enabled me to refresh my whole persona. My rejuvenated body was ready to start the final hurdle that would determine whether I would see the promised land.

Indeed it turned out that my two hosts were in the same boat as me, but we had arrived at different times. They had been in Hamburg about a year earlier as supposed political refugees and had been in the queue for the adjudication of their cases. As a new arrival, they were enthused to welcome me, as *johnny-just-come*, and willing to guide me through the process. They were a rare species of kind humans whom I could have missed the opportunity to meet had I succumbed to my first impression about them.

The first Monday following my arrival, they accompanied me to the city hall. This was called Stadthaus Hamburg. It was a huge impressive monument with multiple layers of departments. A section was designated for processing all the asylum issues.

With their help, they directed me to the right counter where I presented all my credentials, together with the sealed envelope that I was given when I was released from the detention center. Within a few hours, I was out of Stadthaus with a refugee number, iden-

tity card, assigned accommodation, and a set of survival coupons. According to my new friends, this was the quickest initial processing they had ever seen.

The sealed envelope removed many bottlenecks in the bureaucratic process. I was consoled that, at least, my traumatic event on my journey to Hamburg did not go to waste. I must also still be reaping the benefits of my intense prayers in the detention center.

Everything was now working according to plan. I was on an even keel, even though the waters I had just chartered were as turbulent and almost drowning. My assigned apartment, which I shared with another asylum seeker, was in the same compound as that of my two hosts.

My hosts eventually became my mentors and good friends. I carried the guilt, for which I mentally apologized, for misjudging them for a very long time. But I supposed this enriched my bond of friendship to the two selfless people.

My clothing allowance with the coupons from Stadthaus completely metamorphosed my outlook. I looked fresh and felt good about myself. With a great deal of confidence, I started a new life in Hamburg.

I had arrived from Sofia with street clothes that had never seen soap, water, and fresh air in a very long time. When I dressed in those clothes, the embarrassing look from people turning their heads to the direction where the bad aroma was coming from told it all. This was now in the past.

I was now a real Hamburg-er with swag. The kindhearted Germans made sure we did not starve. The monthly stipends, in the form of coupons, were exchanged for food in the supermarkets.

In addition to the basics that we were privileged to, we took a risk to do extra jobs. The patrons hiring us illegally were well aware of our situation and took advantage of us. But it was a win-win for both parties. They paid us well below the minimum wage and under the table. Many of us worked in restaurants, bars, as cleaners, and so on.

Life was good, at least for the moment. I was richer than I ever was. My standard of living was higher than it had ever been. I was a

village boy from Mabang, and if it all had to end here, it would still have been a great achievement.

But there was no room for complacency. I had to look beyond the horizon, where I would find the promised land. My current situation was just a launchpad to make that happen. When I persevered, I would one day be able to get a permit to live in Germany permanently. And this would enable me to arrive in the promised land legally and in style.

This was easier said than done, but a pep talk to myself helped me continue fighting. The adjudication for my refugee application would take about two years. If I failed the adjudication process, my comfort would be abrogated, and I would be deported immediately.

I knew the story I presented to Stadthaus was made up. When the time arrived, I would have to provide the name of my imaginary dad. The honor was for them to disprove my blood relation.

Many of the claims of asylum were similar to mine. They continued to pile up on them. There was a chance that they would falter in their due diligence and overlook the true facts. It was hoped that would be the case and I would get the green light to legalize my stay.

My mentors taught me another backup plan. If that was successful, I did not have to wait for the adjudication process. Indeed it was in pursuit of that safeguard that I miscategorized them as a bunch of drunkards.

The safeguard was to get married to a German girl before the two years was up. Once married, you became a legal resident and the refugee status would be annulled.

The nightclubs were the obvious places to find the girls. At every opportunity, we were in the nightclubs, like *studs*, looking for willing partners.

Indeed there were many girls, but the ones who would break their rank and fall in love with a Black man were a rarity. All we could do was to try.

For the next twelve months, in the company of my two good friends, life settled into a fixed pattern. We were hustlers, living off the government. We worked illegally under the radar of the law

enforcement agencies. We visited every nightclub in Hamburg, chasing women.

In my quiet time, I reminded myself that, should my current lifestyle result in legalizing my stay in Germany, it would have been my third attempt to obtain a United States visa. I had failed two attempts in Accra and Monrovia respectively, and they still remained a sore in my distant memory.

The refugee numbers in Hamburg were rising faster than Stadthaus could cope. The processing of new applications continued to protract. The government decided to open up new centers. The city of Bremerhaven was chosen as a new center.

To our dismay, many of us were selected and relocated to Bremerhaven. In retrospect, this became the watershed moment.

Bremerhaven was a seaport and doubled as a location where the US Army and the German Army met annually to train during the Cold War; it was codenamed *Reforger*. The port was peppered with many military equipment. There was an adjoining fishing harbor where fishing boats transferred tons of fish onto trucks that served the hinterland.

Life in Bremerhaven was, unexpectedly, better than that in Hamburg. The accommodation was of a higher class. The cost of living was much cheaper. Our stipend could go further. It was more relaxed and slow paced. The law enforcement agencies were less venomous. We were freer and worked without too much scrutiny.

We still had a good nightlife. There were many nightclubs. But in this town, there was a favorable mix of girls. The multicolored girls in the US Army turned the nightclubs into a melting pot. Our blend with this mixture raised our chances of making a successful pick. We enjoyed the nightlife with much higher hopes of finding a partner.

The fishing harbor greatly added to our enjoyment. We collected the fallen fishes as they dropped off the conveyor belt from the ships onto the trucks. We fried the unfortunate fishes and, over a bottle of whiskey, we would feast and ruminate on how good life was in our new town.

It had now been six months since I had been in Bremerhaven, still searching but unsuccessful in finding a girl to marry.

What was for sure was that the date for the final adjudication of my case was still fast approaching. If the authorities failed to prove who I claimed to be, my temporary immunity as a free man in Germany would disappear. I would then either retreat into the shadows and join the many underdog illegal immigrants or face deportation proceedings.

One fine night, the stars may have been aligned when we visited a nightclub. Among the well-blended melting pot was a group of ladies having a good time. They were Black, and one of them was of an age that appealed to me.

Their accent gave them away as Americans. Anxiety overwhelmed me as I repeatedly swallowed the last saliva in my mouth amidst fantasies that a successful catch here would be a life-changing moment.

My aim was toward the youngest in the group, and I thought she would be a perfect match for me. This was a chance I did not want to miss. I was a self-declared *stud* and had nothing to lose. I mustered courage and went up to her. I politely said hello.

The stars were indeed aligned.

She said hello back to me with a smile that showed her perfect dental arrangement. The response, so good, unexpected, and encouraging, carried me away into dreamland.

My confidence augmented as we continued to engage each other in conversation. She became equally as interested in me as I was in her.

She was about twenty-three years old, and I was twenty-four. She said she was a soldier from the US Army and based in Rotterdam, Holland. She was in Bremerhaven for a military exercise. She had two more days to return to her base.

She was an African American, originating from Vicksburg, Mississippi. She had a passion for Africa and hoped that one day she would visit the motherland.

We clicked immediately like a key in a perfect lock when her overt aspirations matched my covert needs. We drank and danced together the rest of the night as if to glorify finding each other.

I thought to myself how possible it could be that a boy from Mabang was so lucky to have met a companion so interested in him.

Surely she was oblivious to my thoughts and my spirits and any inferiority complex brewing in me. My external appearance and my words were the tangibles that judged me and affirmed that where I came from really did not matter.

After the night was over, she went back to her hotel whilst I went to my refugee camp. We were physically two worlds apart but connected by a brewing love.

We met the following day after work. It was in her hotel. It was no longer a mirage. Love continued to brew.

She became more comfortable with me and obviously wanted to continue the relationship. Her time of duty in Bremerhaven was coming to an end. She invited me to join her in Rotterdam when she went back.

Unknown to her, this was exactly how I wanted things to pan out. I did not want to utter any overenthusiastic response that would give away my ulterior motive. I needed to suppress my elation. The answer came out in the affirmative in a tone befitting that of truly newfound lovers.

"Thank God," I said to myself.

In order to make it possible for me to visit her, she needed to help me with the visa process. She wholeheartedly obliged.

She accompanied me, uniformed, to the visa section of police headquarters in Bremerhaven. It was all formality. The police officers, instead of asking me questions, were all salutes to the well-respected American soldier. We got to the visa counter, and with a few words to explain that we were going to get married in Rotterdam, a temporary permit to stay in Germany was stamped in my passport.

My status in Germany immediately changed and was elevated from an asylum seeker status to a temporary resident status. For a moment, my head was in the clouds, enjoying the honeymoon period of a newfound love through whom I could be catapulted to my promised land.

She came to say goodbye to me before she went back to Rotterdam. This was the climax of my reality and affirmed the new

me that distinguished me from my prevailing cohort. It was an opportunity for her to know where I lived. I chose the time carefully to create the maximum and lasting impression among my contemporaries. It was a showcase of the ability of the village boy from Mabang.

It was about 3:00 p.m. when the camp was almost full to capacity. Most of the guys, including those who did not like me that much, had returned from their normal routine life of hustling.

Then a young Black female soldier, elegantly dressed in an American military fatigue, entered through the gate of the camp. This was the first of its kind in the camp. Whilst many were mesmerized by her beauty, others were wondering who could have been in trouble with the law.

With many eyeballs following every bit of her movement, she managed to find her way to my apartment. We jumped into each other's arms as soon as my door opened. We were fixed in a tight hug that lasted a good part of one minute.

My roommate looked on with all intensity as his jaws dropped in fascination at the unexpected event that was rolling before his very eyes. I introduced her as my new girlfriend. When she spoke in pure American English, he became even more flabbergasted. He later asked me how I managed to pull this off.

She spent well over half an hour with me before it was time for her to leave. The same eyeballs followed her in reverse until she was out of sight.

For about two hours after she left the camp, it was like jubilee in and around my apartment. My friends and foes alike gathered around me. They patted my shoulders, shook my hands, and some even said it was due to my mother's witchcraft. It was the topic of the day and continued to linger on in many heads for a very long time.

I had a swollen head as my neighbors lifted and paraded me around. I took all in stride as I performed the rare feat of winning the heart of an American soldier. It was at this point that I knew I had achieved what I came for in West Germany. My wings to the promised land began to generate.

After a few days, I made a secret visit to Hamburg. It was to obtain a visa to Rotterdam at the consulate of the Netherlands. It was an easy process.

I kept this development very quiet and secured my passport in a very safe location. Passport theft was a big business, especially if adorned with a visa like mine.

Over the following three to four weeks, on the blind side of all my contemporaries, I prepared to relocate—a relocation like no other—to join my newly found love. I knew I was not coming back. There was no reason to leave any belongings behind.

The day I was leaving, I sat down with my roommate. I gave him all my unused coupons. I broke the news that it was my last day in Bremerhaven. I was going to get married to the American soldier.

This would give me the opportunity to complete the last leg to the promised land. All the hopes that had piled up in the “*Lego of the tilting tower of Pisa*” had crystallized into solid reality.

I waved him goodbye and took to the train station.

It was now a joyride in the trains this time. All the immigration officers would fly past me when I would flag them my visas. With a nod, they signaled me to ride on.

On the trains, I went from Bremerhaven to Bremen. Then I took another train to Hamburg. The international train connection from Hamburg took me to Amsterdam, from where I reconnected to Rotterdam.

When I saw my future wife waiting for me on the platform in Rotterdam, I knew I was on the launchpad of my final leg.

ROMANTIC LINK

When I first met Deidra in the nightclub in Bremerhaven, my instinctive true attraction to her was overshadowed by my desire to find any woman who would just fit the cap. And the cap was any woman agreeing to marry me, which would enable me to change my immigration status to a legal resident.

This was the desperation that turned my cohort into stags. This driving force, born out of desperation, was the initial ulterior motive that railroaded my confidence to approach Deidra.

It was an egoistic motive, and I celebrated its achievement during the brief two days when Deidra and I bonded in Bremerhaven.

But this second encounter with Deidra, when she was expressing her genuine love and made time from her military duties to meet me on the platform at the train station, completely changed my perspective.

This time, my head was no longer in the clouds. The fog had now settled. My true vision for analyzing Deidra had taken center stage.

As soon as I descended from the train, I dropped my baggage and ran into her. The hug was of the same intensity as the first time we did the same in my apartment in Bremerhaven. But the sentiment that accompanied this never-ending hug was of a genuine character for a newfound love.

My selfish motive was the vehicle that first directed me to Deidra, but this had now been completely eroded and replaced by a true love for a person that I wanted to spend my life with.

As we walked hand in hand from the train station, I felt our souls connecting through the nerves in our fingers. We had only met for two days, but the decision we took to see each other again was beginning to have profound consequences. On my part, I was rediscovering love all over again after my last one, four years ago, was shattered into pieces by Dorcas. The dejection from that broken heart was a major factor for leaving Ghana. My friend and mentor, James, counseled me to better myself, and I would be spoiled for choice.

Perhaps this new love, which was in its infancy, would generate into something bigger and better. It was going to be my second love. The first one had already taught me how to love and handle a woman. And Deidra would be the beneficiary of all my acquired romantic experiences.

The more I analyzed Deidra, the more I felt fulfilled in finding her. She was a typical American girl. Her youthful skin was fresh and fluffy and had an admirable lighter chocolate complexion. That made me stand out as a darker and weathered African from the motherland.

I had a slight height advantage. Her physically fit body and proportionate curves were enhanced anytime she appeared in the elegant US Army uniform. Her generous eyelashes blinked over a set of big off-blue eyes. When she smiled, her perfect dental arrangement, complemented by beautiful white teeth, generated a reciprocal smile.

She was an extrovert who loved people. She was warm-spirited and had a bubbly personality. I did not have to look further for a wife—I was truly in love again.

As we made our way from the train station to her house, we felt our love for each other grow stronger and stronger. The subject of getting married came up organically. We felt it was the right thing to do as soon as we could.

Indeed I was going to get married for the right purpose, driven by love and commitment. I want to underscore that at this point, the need to change my immigration status, even though it was important to me, was no longer a driving force and a reason for the union. This had now rather become a by-product.

I was overtaken by emotions after we eventually arrived at her apartment. It had been about four years since I lived in a proper home. That was in Kumasi with my uncle. Since then, I had lived in shantytowns and slums in Nigeria. I embraced a homeless lifestyle and lived under the bridges and shelter homes in Sofia and ended up in refugee camps in Germany.

Deidra's home, which would now become my home by virtue of our union, was going to be the watershed moment of my future lifestyle. It was of a scale and magnitude that was better than anywhere I had ever lived in my entire life.

It was not just an apartment. It was a penthouse. It was beautifully furnished with coordinating furniture. It was very clean. It had a spacious fitted kitchen. Dishwashers and washing machines were all inconspicuously tucked away in the kitchen. I did not have to do the dishes or laundry. The machines did it all.

She introduced me to her friends, some of whom I vaguely recalled in the nightclub during our first encounter. They acknowledged me with indifferent enthusiasm.

I settled in, and soon we were making preparations to get married. Again this was uncoerced and came naturally.

Within two weeks, witnessed by many of her colleagues from the military, we were pronounced husband and wife by a judge in the city hall of Rotterdam.

By virtue of this marriage, Deidra had been the powerhouse and key to my entry into the promised land. The doors she opened had a profound influence on my destiny. She had left an indelible mark in my life, for which I am forever grateful.

As a married couple, my legitimacy was taken over by the due process of the American government. I did not force it.

My documents were sent over to the military base in Rotterdam. I soon became a legal resident of Holland. I was assigned a military civilian identity card to enable me to live among the soldiers.

By the time we were married, we were only about six weeks into knowing each other. The sentiments of newly found lovers and honeymooning were all rolled into one.

Following our wedding, our friendship grew even stronger as we continued to enjoy the things that brought us together in the first place. Having fun, especially in the nightclubs, continued to dominate our leisure activities. We were like true friends who clicked.

Driving a car had never been on my radar until I met Deidra. And, of course, it should not have been as owning a car was then a dream rather than reality. To prepare me for the future, she encouraged me to learn how to drive and indeed taught me how to.

She became the de facto breadwinner of our household. I was a househusband. This did not sit well with her close contacts.

They were distant to me, at best, anytime I met them, and it became increasingly uncomfortable when we met as a group.

They formed their own opinion of our union. Some were of the feeling that I was a gold digger. The narrative almost made sense on the surface, but they were oblivious to my ultimate sentiments for our union.

I was picked up from a refugee camp, quickly got married, and here I was, living off my wife. They erroneously predicted a breakup when I attained my ulterior motives.

I wished they knew who I really was. The true me was a pathfinder of my family who would not settle for the status quo. The circumstances on which they based their opinion were part of my destiny. I had unknowingly been preprogrammed to break the glass ceiling. But I needed to assume this presumptive tag along the way.

I became aware Deidra's posting in Rotterdam would last for another two years. There was no rush. I felt that one foot of my last leg was already in the promised land. It was now just a matter of time.

This was an opportunity for me to make myself useful in order to change the narrative in the minds of Deidra's close contacts.

I took a job in a bakery. This was probably in haste since I wanted to quickly create a new image for myself.

I thought I was hardened after many months of experience of factory work in the heat in Agege. It turned out the tropical heat did not compare with the bakery work environment. The ovens put out a tremendous amount of heat. The humidity generated by the drying dough even doubled the heat intensity.

I was on my feet all day. I worked very long hours. The work was fast-paced. The salary did not match the work I put in.

The brutal work environment, coupled with these factors, created a very high turnover of workers in this industry.

Within a few months, I became one of the statistics that succumbed to a job that had the reputation of a workforce made up of predominantly desperate immigrants.

My next job was in a meat-processing factory. This also had a brutal work environment but opposite that of the bakery. It had a high worker turnover due to the harsh work environment.

I was assigned to the packaging section. I literally worked in arctic conditions all day. It was very cold. I would come home and feel frozen to the core; *frozen meat* would have been an understatement.

Certainly, no matter how I sliced it, working at extremely low temperatures for hours—for an African who had lived all his life in the tropics—would not conjure longevity, especially when the remuneration was not proportionate.

My wife felt sorry for me and asked me to quit after a few weeks.

Finally I found a job that was more appealing to me. It was in synchrony with my characteristics. I was employed as a librarian in the large city library. This job put dignity back on my face. I no longer had to dress like a factory boy. I did not have to look scruffy all day.

I dressed like a scholar. It was my first ever decent job, when I juxtaposed it to that in Agege, and I stayed in it until my wife's posting was over.

This scholarly job paved the way for me to reflect on myself and my future career. It stimulated me to start further education. I immediately enrolled in Rapid Result College. This was a distance learning model of education administered from London.

My field of study was information technology. I graduated with a certificate which, unknowingly at the time, formed the basis of my future business empire.

Deidra became pregnant about one year after our marriage. This was the icing on the cake for our protracted honeymoon and the joy of finding each other.

It not only put the seal on our union, but it also abrogated the suspicion of the doubting Thomases in the camp who felt Thomas Baafi was just a playboy using the marriage as an excuse to pass through.

We were happier than ever, and together with the new development, we nurtured the pregnancy, which progressed without unexpected events till term. We were blessed with Afua Baafi.

At the end of two years, Deidra completed her posting in Rotterdam. She needed to go back home. And, of course, we were all going as a family.

My dreamland, here I come, I sang to my soul. It was the last leg of my journey. I was entering with substance, legally married to a US citizen and a certificate in information technology. It could not have been better than this.

The reflection of my past life with respect to my desire to embark on a journey to a dreamland produced undesirable memories, sometimes to the point of shedding tears.

I had been traveling for six years in order to get to America. I did not have a clue this journey would be of such duration and filled with torture at the magnitude that I experienced.

Armed with the four commandments inducted upon me by Uncle Guyman, I tackled the hardships and the predicaments one after the other. My wits and the grace of God carried me through. I was not a quitter.

I was hardened by those experiences and came through with an iron core that could withstand any situation that may appear insurmountable.

I left the shores of Ghana after I was humiliated with a broken heart from my first love, Dorcas. Six years later, I was arriving in my promised land of America, happily married with a baby girl.

I could now hear and make sense of my confidant James consoling me in Kumasi as I was going through the pains of dejection and naively considering taking my life. His advice was, literally, now bearing fruits.

My last leg was achieved in grand style. I arrived in New York legally in an airplane, with an American wife and a baby girl.

No sooner had we arrived than the military expeditiously commenced the processing of my document for legal habitation in the United States. I was assigned a Social Security number.

My green card application started cooking when we flew to Jackson, Mississippi. From here, we found our way by road to Vicksburg.

This was Deidra's hometown, where I officially commenced the exploration of my long-awaited dreamland.

PROMISED LAND

I was at last in America, my dreamland. It took me about six years to arrive. I was twenty years old when I started the journey from Africa, and I arrived at twenty-six.

I knew I was not the only person to have embarked on a journey that would take a few years to arrive in America. The earlier explorers may have taken a much longer time when their rafts drifted away, senselessly in the ocean, in search of lands to discover. They were not privileged to maps and places.

In modern times, when humanity was much wiser, I must have been among the record holders who had taken such a long duration to arrive.

Juxtaposing my trip to contemporaries who were fortunate to have the right visa, it took them no more than twelve hours for the same trip.

I was declined that crucial entry visa twice in Africa. But, with determination, I was successful at my third attempt.

This attempt, which occurred six years after the first two, was in the faraway European country of the Netherlands. But I arrived there full of drama—by air and by land—and got detention along the line.

My circumstances at the third attempt were completely different, secondary to the years endured in the planning and metamorphosis. The silver lining was a visa that was granted with little effort.

Many people of like minds across the world have tried to get to America using the back door. Their journeys were also long and

treacherous. Many were unable to tell their stories. They died before they could.

For me, I left the shores of Ghana with a small bag. It was my whole world, full of old clothes, together with my *witts*.

The latter, though intangible, was the most powerful driving force at the helm. And I was able to arrive in America in a drama but safe and sound.

When I finally arrived, I had a cargo much larger than I could ever have imagined or expected. The contents were human beings: A wife and baby girl.

Now that I was there, I needed to pause, let the whole ordeal settle in, and celebrate.

I dedicated the following two months as my second honeymoon period. This was not to celebrate my marriage but my arrival. It was achieved with many nuances and life-changing drama. It was a rare feat by my measure. I took it all in as I analyzed my newfound land and planned for my future.

New York was my port of entry. I disembarked from the airplane at JFK Airport. I felt the chill through my bones when my first foot stepped on American soil.

I did a quick reality check, and indeed it was me. With pride and surrounded by my small family, we went through immigration effortlessly.

The stopover in New York was brief, but the optics drove home that I was indeed in America.

My immediate observation was about the police. They were conspicuously armed with guns. It was as if they were on heightened alert to deter or circumvent any potential threats.

I had never seen any such thing in my entire existence, be it Africa or Europe.

I began to think that America was a dangerous country, where threat levels were at the point that called for military-style policing—and perhaps much more dangerous than my experience in Agege, where we were constantly subjected to monthly raids in our aluminum houses.

I came to realize later that gun ownership by its citizens was like no other country in the world. Private individuals were allowed to own guns, and they did so in their numbers.

The consequences were very obvious. Mass shootings and killing of civilians, gang violence, and many gun-related crimes were more rampant than any place I had ever visited.

The city of New York certainly had the character and the sophistication that justified my adventure and curiosity. The density of skyscrapers, the monuments, the sophisticated and yet orderly transport system, the sheer volume of people, and the apparent faster pace of life were all novel and added to my many culture shock moments.

This made my dream to come to America worthwhile. I could not have seen this anywhere else in the world.

During the period of my initial arrival and many weeks after, I had difficulty with the language. I did all my education in the English language. I never had any difficulty engaging with any interlocutor in English.

But now I had difficulty understanding Americans when they spoke, and they also had difficulty understanding me. They spoke faster and pronounced words differently. I spoke slower with an African accent. It was weird.

Finally we arrived in Vicksburg, Deidra's hometown—a town in the southern state of Mississippi. It was much smaller than any of the European cities I had visited. It did not have any special characteristics that gave me goose pimples.

I would spend the next six to eight weeks in this town to get used to America, its culture, and norms. It would be with the parents of my wife. This would help with my assimilation in American society and prepare me to explore the world of my dreamland.

The couple, who had long been expecting me since our marriage in the Netherlands, welcomed me with open arms.

Like many African Americans who automatically had roots in Africa, they had dreams of visiting the motherland one day. However, their dreams never materialized. They kept procrastinating until the opportunity got eroded by their age. Now they had passed

their prime ages and had settled to the idea that their dream journey, unlike mine, would never materialize.

Hitherto, like their contemporaries, they had never had close contact with an African from the motherland. Now their own son-in-law was from their motherland. They were thrilled. This sublimed their dashed hopes and disappointment of their failure.

Feeling accepted and cherished with all sincerity, I felt easily at home living with them.

Whilst living with them, I had the opportunity to see the *melange* of American culture with that of their enslaved forefathers that had been passed on through the generations.

Surely the people in their close community looked like any of my uncles, aunties, sisters, and brothers back home. I came here by choice, and their ancestors came by force.

But anytime they spoke to me, there was a problem—and vice versa. I spoke like an African with a thick accent, and they spoke like Americans with a southern drawl.

Conversations became tiring tasks for either side due to persistent ear straining and rampant repetition of sentences. The English language sounded like another foreign language for either of us.

Living with them exposed me, firsthand, to the culture of the African Americans. I appreciated their doctrines and their frustrations. I noticed the racial inequalities still had deep roots and everlasting ripples.

It was also interesting to familiarize myself with the cooking style of these *adulterated* Africans. It was not like the motherland. Barbecued-style food played a major role in their cuisine. Stews and African soups were alien to them.

Their dwellings usually had no physical hard barriers from one another. There was a higher level of police presence in their communities. In addition, possession of guns by individuals may have helped to provide more security. They did not have to live behind high walls like we did in Africa.

I loved the work ethics of the average American. Each worker gave their full mileage and commitment to their employer.

Observed slack times at work were frowned upon. Laziness and tardiness were eschewed and could lead to your redundancy.

Americans took less annual vacation than most countries. The culture of *work-hard-and-play-well* was very much entrenched. They made time to enjoy their vacations.

During this period of assimilation, I was also perfecting my driving skills. Deidra was already a pro driver. With her help, I gained the necessary skills to pass my driving test.

This would become useful when my wife resumed her busy military duties. I became the main parent taking our daughter back and forth to children's activities.

Soon the honeymoon period was over. And at this point, my green card that stamped my legal residence status was already at hand.

My wife was posted to duty at 101st Airborne Division, Fort Campbell. This was an army installation at the Kentucky–Tennessee border. The town was an arm's reach from Hopkinsville in Kentucky and Clarksville in Tennessee.

In anticipation of this, I had applied and was accepted to pursue a degree in computer science and information technology at Austin Peay State University, in Clarksville.

My advanced level certificate from Ghana and my IT certificate from Rapid Result College in London came in handy. These were the main determinants that qualified me for the placement.

This short period of acclimatization to American life and culture gave me an insight of what was ahead of me. The American dream was not meant for lazy people. Good efforts were satisfactorily rewarded.

TERTIARY EDUCATION

My honeymoon period in Vicksburg was over after two months. During this short period, courtesy of my two in-laws who impacted me with the knowledge and dogma of America, I developed new wings of confidence and curiosity to explore my new world.

My in-laws were also privileged to obtain firsthand knowledge from me about their dreamland whose mysteries would forever elude them.

As we got ready to move on, the sadness on their faces became more evident. They were going to miss their newly found and cherished African son-in-law, their new granddaughter, and a daughter who only appeared in flashes and would be gone like a mirage to serve her country.

I was prepared, thanks to them, to move on with my small family to start a new life and explore my new horizon. Afua was eighteen months old at the time and the already built-in nannies, her grandparents, would soon be nonexistent. We had to take up the mantle again, just as we did in Rotterdam, to take full responsibility for her care.

We finally relocated to Fort Campbell, where my wife resumed her military duties. We were housed in the military base of the 101st Airborne Division.

The military duties were very regimental, and my wife did not have the flexibility for full parenting. I immediately stood firm as a dependent civilian husband to put in my full contribution for our young family.

The military salary would be unable to take care of the family needs. Therefore I took a part-time job in the department store in the military camp in anticipation of the shortfalls.

Even with our combined salaries, we were just about scraping the bottom of the barrel. Our circumstances constrained us in making extra income. I could not do full-time work as a student, and she could not do extra part-time work as a soldier.

The money earned was just enough to cover the expenses but provided no luxury. And so we were not able to afford a nanny. I took on the full responsibility of Afua. Deidra filled in whenever her duties allowed her.

It was joyful and novel in nurturing a baby daughter and seeing her achieve all the milestones of maturity, one after the other. That gave me a great deal of satisfaction.

In order to aid and ease our mobility, we managed to acquire an old Toyota saloon car. This was a car that appeared to have passed through multiple hands. Through the generations, most of its bells and whistles had fallen off.

This Toyota belonged to a class of its own. Its battered and weathered characteristics could easily have passed as a vintage car.

When we got it, it was bare-bone but resilient. And more importantly, it was faithful to us. It served all our purposes with little breakdowns. It transported us from one point to the other without fail.

My driving skills came in handy. I was at its helm and looked after it like my last heritage. We were assured of the flexibility we needed in transportation.

I drove Afua back and forth to day care, children's shows, and multiple playgrounds. Dad and daughter always stood out as curious heads most often turned to follow the trajectory of our car as it rolled by. At our destination, people, out of curiosity, would attempt to identify the passengers of the old jalopy.

Before long, the university reopened. I started my four-year tertiary education at Austin Peay State University in Clarksville, Tennessee. I pursued a degree in computer science and information technology.

This area of study was not on my radar when I was bidding for my dream careers of medicine and pharmacy six years earlier in Ghana. My grades had fallen short and I was not accepted. My mates who were lucky to be enrolled for their dream courses were now doctors and pharmacists.

This new career path was a consolation course for me. Better late than never. Whatever happened in one's life had been predetermined and packaged as destiny. I fully accepted the change in the course of my career.

This means testing during my application process by the university demonstrated that I could not afford the full face value of the tuition. As a result, I received financial assistance from the university. The scholarship they offered me paid half the tuition. The other half was my responsibility, which I had to work and pay myself.

Clarksville was a commuting distance from our military camp in Fort Campbell, Kentucky. My old Toyota could cover the distance of thirteen miles in just thirty minutes. It was a smooth ride and did not strain the ability of the old jalopy.

I now had to adjust to life around all the encumbrances of the reality before me: a quasi-full-time parent, a full-time student, and a part-time worker. I had to pay my fees and contribute toward the household expenses.

This was the reality that I was faced with in my dreamland within four months of my debut. I immediately reminded myself of the four commandments Uncle Guyman gave me.

I also had the *wits* that carried me through my treacherous journey in Europe. I had never failed myself, and this was just a challenge in my quest for success.

School days were very challenging. Outside the schoolwork, there were basic domestic chores that needed to be accomplished. These were *must-do* tasks.

The most daring of these was the care of the eighteen-month-old. It was very unpredictable, especially at night when she would wake up crying for whatever reason. And, in the morning, there was a whole lot of process to get her ready before dropping her off in the

day care. These included bathing, clothing, packing the lunch bag with food, and changing diapers.

There was no room to forget any of the details. My wife would help when her military duties allowed. Otherwise, I got on with it.

After drop-off, it was my turn to look after myself. Whatever had happened the previous night did not count. There was no excuse for fatigue due to baby night calls, nor the morning baby care.

I must still present myself as a devoted full-time student and hope that my old jalopy got me to school without any incident.

I arranged my daily four-hour work schedule to fit in with my lectures. And, soon after school, my reliable jalopy would carry me straight to the military shop to work.

After my shift, it would be time to pick up Afua from day care. When we got home, I fed her, bathed her, and got her into her night clothes ready for bed. Then we would play until she was tired.

Putting children to bed was not an easy task. It was an art that called for careful selection of children's songs. These lullabies must be soothing enough to put her to sleep. That meant I must use my best voice to sing them.

I would sing and sing all the selections. Many times the first few rounds would be unsuccessful. It was, indeed, a tiring effort. But it must be done patiently but expeditiously so that I could attend to my schoolwork.

Many times, after successfully achieving the result I needed, the energy left in me would be insufficient to complete my schoolwork. The fatigue would overwhelm me, and the same lullaby I sang to my daughter would send me to sleep.

I would wake up with a startle at three the following morning. Then I would rush through my homework. There would just be enough time to complete it before the next day's cycle began.

The initial year of school was very challenging. This was not because of the contents of my academic work but the mode of the transfer of the information I needed in order to comprehend the concepts.

The difficult American accent finally caught up with me. I had difficulty following the lectures due to the speed of the presenter and the mode of pronunciation of the words.

Sometimes I would be totally lost. My strained ears set to follow the lectures could not keep up with the pace of the lecture.

In order to catch up, I had to give up all the pleasures of a normal student life. I needed to focus. My passion for sports had sublimed into thin air. I never participated in any sporting events. I even abhorred watching my school team participate in competitions.

My place of comfort was the local library. That was my safe haven, where I would spend the greater part of the day when time allowed me from my parenting duties.

The intensity and seriousness I applied to my studies soon caught the attention of the librarian. She was an elderly mother called Jackie Jones. Her straight face demonstrated the characteristics needed to strictly keep a library in order.

She usually sniffed around to ensure no library user posed any mischief.

Jackie's curiosity usually alerted her to my corner. And soon she became interested in me and called me her son. Indeed, she was amazed how one student would *egotistically* gather all the relevant books of a subject matter to his table.

This was not allowed in a busy library. It deprived other students who wanted to study that subject.

She became aware that I had just arrived from the motherland, Africa, and was new to the country. She realized I was on a tight budget and I could not afford to buy books. And the library was my only savior.

Jackie was White and appeared to be very curious about the African continent. She wanted to take the opportunity to learn about Africa firsthand. Her interest and eagerness strengthened our bond.

Jackie, coming to terms with my plight, felt sorry for me and allowed me to break the rules. She turned a blind eye to my corner. She condoned my behavior.

She even went further to ensure that I did not go hungry. She would bring me cheeseburgers when she returned from lunch.

Indeed, considering all my encumbrances, the first academic year initially appeared insurmountable. But gradually, the language problem eased off, and so did my adaptation to my multiple challenges.

Thanks to Jackie also, whose motherly touch blessed me with the ability to use all the books I needed, I was able to complete level 101 of the academic year with multiple grade *A*'s. The academic year really ended well.

With the first year behind me, I began to take subsequent academic years in my stride. I was comfortable in class. I was able to overcome the language problems and I could ask questions. My academic prowess soon became more noticeable. My confidence in class became more apparent.

I became aware that I could save money if I took more credit hours. If I did eighteen credit hours a year, I would only have to pay for twelve. This not only gave me significant savings but also shortened my graduation time.

It was a challenge to do this extra work in school. There were two main problems that could potentially impede my ability to achieve this.

My parenting responsibilities were quite daunting, especially at night when it was unpredictable with my daughter.

Moreover, I needed to make the time to put in at least four hours of work in the departmental store. This paid my fees and supplemented the living expenses of our household.

But I was determined to succeed. I was exemplary in all areas of my academic study, and feeling that nothing was beyond my ability, I took the challenge.

I managed the eighteen credit hours in the second year and my scores marveled everyone. I was still a solid student on firm grounds.

To the amazement of my tutors, I still excelled with multiple grade *A*'s.

With two years behind me, I was already flying in *blooming* colors in my academic work. I could feel the end was near. I could be done with college in less than two years if I persisted with the same momentum.

Then the news came that would add more strain on the existing stress. My wife was going to be redeployed to Busan in South Korea. She was going to be away for two years.

The regimental orders of the military really hit home with me. They gave the order, and you needed to comply. It was up to you to rearrange your family circumstances. The order was to serve your country and nothing short of that.

As a dependent civilian husband, I could have accompanied her during the transfer to her new post. But it was not possible with our existing circumstances. I was still in school and flying high. We had a three-and-a-half-year-old bubbly daughter who had just settled in preschool.

We decided she would go alone, and I would stay. It would be all work and no play. My stress level notched up even further.

I would now take full parenting responsibility for our daughter. I would also continue to work and pay for my school fees and the household expenses. I had to continue the eighteen-credit hours of study in school in order to save money. The silver lining was that if all these worked out as planned, I would graduate at least six months earlier and save a significant amount of money. It would also end my student time sooner, which would allow me to start earning extra money we so needed to support us.

This was easier said than done. There was no room to do extra work. The bills would still keep coming, and I had to take full responsibility. But I had my *wits*. I had the courage. I needed to find ways of cutting down expenses. That was the only way I could stretch out my current fixed income.

Among the corners I needed to cut in order to make ends meet was to take full responsibility for styling my daughter's hair. They charged a lot of money to plait hair, and taking that cost out of the equation would save me quite a lot.

And so I went for a basic hair-plaiting lesson for about one week. I graduated myself early and used Afua's hair to perfect my skills.

And before long, I became an expert in plaiting my daughter's hair myself. There were no hair fashion competition parades to judge

my skill, but I knew the job was good when her contemporaries did not make fun of her hair.

During the period of my wife's deployment, I spent more time with the army support system during my off days. This was a club of the army and their dependent civilian families.

My situation appeared to be unique. I was a dependent civilian husband.

Some of them would sympathize with me as a man taking total care of a young daughter. But others, especially the men, looked down upon me with disdain.

"A dependent civilian husband is not considered manly," they would lament. This was a reverse role from what they were used to.

On multiple occasions, they would bring up the subject of why I was not in the army and my wife was. I felt uncomfortable continuing such lines of conversation, and I would sometimes walk away.

Obviously they were not privileged to all the circumstances that brought me to America. The details were not for the consumption of everyone.

Indeed circumstances beyond my control created my reverse role. Moreover, I did not have the slightest interest in becoming a soldier. It was not a career that I had ever contemplated.

It would be a long talk if I tried to explain. I was tolerant of their tunnel-vision concerns. I stomached all the uneasiness and urged myself to continue my education. One day, some would understand.

Despite all the challenges and hardships, I was able to graduate after three and a half years of college education. I earned, with pride, a BSc degree in computer science and information technology. And I did so with honors.

THE JOBS THAT DEFINED MY FUTURE, PART 1

I was financially handicapped by the time I completed college. Even a church mouse would have been prouder. There was no elbow room to make extra money.

It was with great gratitude that my graduation, ironically, felt like a release from a pressure cooker. I was ready to join the workforce to start earning a decent salary.

Diedra would soon complete her foreign mission and return home. Afua was about five years old, and I was still fully in charge.

I frantically looked for a job soon after graduation. At this point, I was willing to accept any job offer that presented itself to me. It would not have mattered. I would still earn more than I was paid during my part-time job in the army department store.

The Department of Human Services in Nashville was recruiting college graduates with skills in computer science and information technology. This was the early days of the Internet, and graduates with the skill were not as many.

I applied for the position and was instantly accepted. Within a few days of formalities, I was well on my way to start a new job. This was my debut in the workplace. My enthusiasm and excitement were apparent the first day I showed up to work.

The job offered a salary of \$1,000 per month and involved commuting one hour each way from Fort Campbell.

I still had my old jalopy handy. The commute at first did not seem to be a problem.

My days started early. I must first perform my parenting duties and send Afua to school in the morning. This was easier than during my student days. She was a bit older, and the intensity of caring for her was much less.

Then I would start my one-hour trip in the old jalopy. Each day of my trip, I prayed that it did not disappoint. My schedule was like clockwork, and any breakdown would cause a significant knock-on effect in my new job and the care of my daughter.

But the vehicle was very faithful and would bring me back in the evening just in time to pick up Afua from school. My parenting duties would continue until she went to bed.

Within a few weeks of enjoying my new role as a working pseudo-single father, the initial excitement for my new job started to fade.

The two hours of driving in a day, combined with the parenting duties, caused so much fatigue. The weekend break was not enough to recharge.

In addition, my jalopy, as faithful as it was, was burning a lot of fuel. This put significant strain on my monthly salary.

Being naive and fresh from college, I did not take these nuances into consideration before accepting my new position. I was already neck high in it before the problems presented themselves.

As a system analyst, I was certainly underpaid. My employers felt I had no experience and could not afford to give me more money. I was still broke at the end of the month.

But I came to terms that I was not working for money at this time. I was working to gain experience. It would prepare me for the next big opportunity.

And so I persevered. Day in and day out, I would go through the motions in order to sustain the family. It was a routine that needed to be fulfilled.

I needed to make ends meet. I needed to find ways to cut down costs. I continued being the hairstylist for my daughter. At this time, I had already gained a significant skill in hair-plaiting.

I also found an alternate means of going to work that was cheaper and less tiring than using my car. I discovered a shuttle bus

service between Fort Campbell and Nashville. The fare was fixed and affordable. The savings was significant.

Indeed the dreamland was not all roses. Money did not come easy. I wished I had a foreknowledge about the reality of life here before I arrived.

There were many mindsets the daredevils who wanted to make a trip to greener pastures were not privileged to before they embarked on such a journey. One of which was the fact that not everyone would succeed in this competitive world of the dreamland.

The stories of the many people who were unable to make it in the dreamland failed to make the headlines. Only those who have successfully converted the little openings and made it to the skies took the center stage.

Perseverance in the dreamland was the key to success. The only way I could break the glass ceiling was to look ahead and take the misfortunes as little bumps in the road to success. I should be an optimist and always look at the glass as half full.

I had a story to tell in my small village of Mabang. I was chosen, perhaps, by its deities. And even though I had chalked a record of being the first person to have gone this far, I still had to make the distance to make it unbeatable.

I was keen to improve my current financial situation. I cast my nest wide to look for better job opportunities. Then electronic data systems recruited me and told me I would be sent to faraway Dayton, Ohio.

It was with great excitement when I was given an offer for the job. The salary was a whopping \$28,000 per year. It was more than double what I had been making in Nashville. They paid extra money for relocation. It was an opportunity that I did not want to miss.

By this time, my wife had arrived from her service in South Korea. Afua was about six years old. My wife's military duties and the dedicated service to her nation had significantly affected her ability to take the center stage of the family. She missed out on the fun of raising a beautiful daughter.

The return from this duty brought her to the crossroads of either having a dedicated family life or continuation of service to her

nation. If she continued in the service to her nation for an additional five years, she would qualify for a lifetime pension from the military.

After considering all the options, Deidra chose family over service to her nation. This was a difficult choice, but she felt it was the right thing to do.

Her intention to have more kids and play a central role in their upbringing was overpowering. If she decided to continue with her military career, it would be another instability in her family life.

Moreover she felt she had a good and reliable husband who had now become the pillar in the house; a husband with good education who was capable of taking care of the family; a husband whose future was so bright that she needed to support him to rise even higher.

The family was now ready and poised to explore the new horizon. Dayton, Ohio, was now the little promised land for the young family. I decided to move first, and the rest of the family would follow after one month.

My employer was Electronic Data Systems Corporation (EDS). This was a multinational information technology equipment and services company. Its headquarters was in Plano, Texas. It was founded in 1962 by Ross Perot. It was later acquired by General Motors in 1984 and by Hewlett-Packard in 2008.

It was a solid company that gave value to its employees. The salary, which was relatively above average for my qualification, provided extra money for luxury.

I could immediately feel the release from the bondage of pecuniary insufficiency when I started working. Our lifestyle immediately transformed from low income to middle income overnight.

When Deidra eventually joined me after one month, I was in full financial control. I was at ease and comfortably placed as the man of the house. I was able to provide all the needs of the house with little constraint.

The days of “dependent civilian husbands: were now history. I got my ego back on track.

As we progressed to a better life in Dayton, there were moments when the family had flashes of unavoidable nostalgia. Our old vintage jalopy did not come with us. It did serve us well. But after six to

eight months of additional use after college, its better days were over. There was not much life left in it. It was appropriate that we parted ways.

No one in our new world of Dayton needed to know about the stigma that plagued my family when it was associated with an old battered car. I wanted this to remain and be buried in Fort Campbell.

Indeed, within a few months in Dayton, we could afford relatively new cars. We became a two-car household—one for me to work, and the other one for Deidra for the domestic errands.

The American dream was well-alive. As long as you had a good job and good credit, you could afford life's basic needs. This was the added comfort of living in a civilized world that did not require you to have all the fortunes before you could afford basic necessities.

But this comfort can blur the distinction of needs and wants. If you let the latter rule the day, it could put you into bankruptcy and homelessness should you suddenly lose your job.

EDS hired me as a systems engineer. I did not have any experience for the position before joining the company. But I humbly subjected myself as an apprentice to be trained in all aspects of systems engineering.

My training involved the design, integration, and optimization of complex systems and processes. This encompassed the use of hardware, software, networks, and other components to ensure all parts worked together and efficiently to meet specified objectives.

I joined this company in the rudimentary years of the Internet. I saw how it fashioned itself into a unique position using this new technology. It became the pioneer in facilities management.

By virtue of its capabilities—the first of its kind at the time—it placed itself as an information technology giant. Many companies did not have this capability. Therefore they preferentially shifted that department to EDS. This was the first concept of outsourcing.

This concept allowed the company to exponentially grow locally and internationally. General Motors used them to link all their dealerships.

EDS revolutionized the financial markets with the arrival of the automated teller machine, electronic funds transfer, and real-time point-of-sale terminals.

These were few of the many applications that placed EDS as a market leader. I was in the center stage of this company as a systems engineer and also placed in a unique position of exposure to the business dealings that grew the company.

Outsourcing was certainly an eye-opener for me, and I learned this principle firsthand.

The company was very busy and ran twelve-hour shifts covering the day and night. It was joyful working any of the shifts.

Each one came with its own experience. I was just like a sponge, imbibing it all.

I enjoyed a good family life after work. My wife was a full-time mother. Soon she would give birth to a new addition. He would be a bouncy boy whose excitement made him come a few days before he was due. And Thomas Junior, TJ, would not stop crying with excitement when he was finally extruded into the world.

I was now a proud daddy of two children with a very comfortable job. I was a sponge, imbibing all the knowledge needed to enrich myself in my new career—a great learning experience that had the potential of giving me the ability to run my own business in the future. A business that would have the potential of shaping the fortunes of my family.

Among the many things I learned, the most poignant were:

- a) how resources are put together to optimize the efficiency of a company; and
- b) how to use electronic data and internet to support companies.

EDS prided itself in continually upgrading the skills of its workers. Annually employees were posted to its headquarters in Plano, Texas, for further training. After the skills enhancement, one was posted to other branches to head their operations.

After one year in Dayton, the company decided to transfer me for further training. There I would acquire further knowledge that would not only be beneficial to me personally but would also place me at a more senior position in the company.

The new skill I was going to learn would enable me to design, develop, test, and maintain software applications. I would gain the knowledge of a software engineer and could practically be able to write software after this training.

It was an honor for me to be given the opportunity to acquire this knowledge. It would be a knowledge that would shape my future. It was exciting news for my career and a win for my family.

My family decided that I would go first, get settled in, and they would follow after one month. I arrived in Plano with high hopes to learn and contribute to the growth of this company.

It was with pride when I stepped in the office in Plano for the first time. As per protocol, I reported to my manager. He received me with an indifferent effect.

My manager was a White man whose accent gave him away as a typical Southerner. Like Jackie Jones, the librarian in my school, he was stern and appeared to approach his work with all seriousness.

He appeared to be difficult to please, and his demeanor made me uneasy around him. But my eagerness to learn to write software superseded all egos. I was pleased with myself to be here, and that was all that mattered.

As planned, I was alone for the first month without my family. I used this opportunity to give my all to my work. It was my priority to learn and to do so quickly. It was going well, and I was making good progress.

Before long, one month came by very quickly. My family finally relocated to Plano.

We were housed in the company apartments. Even though our household items were yet to arrive, the furnishing was enough to meet our needs.

I was a young engineer with two kids and a beautiful wife who was a full-time mother. We had two cars, and I was earning a comfortable salary.

Life outside work was even more fun. We explored our new town when I was off. We took advantage of the parks and the kids' playgrounds. My household was beaming with joy. Our trajectory into the horizon seemed to be on course for even better days, and the American dream was in the making.

However, whilst my family life appeared to be charting a good course, my interactions with my boss appeared to become hostile. It was becoming increasingly difficult to please him.

He appeared to actively look for faults with my work and accused me of incompetency. Unlike Jackie, who was keen and eager to learn about Africa, it appeared my origin was repugnant to him.

I did not see him reprimanding other trainees as much. The effort I was putting into my work had not changed. I felt I was being singled out.

I immediately concluded that his behavior was nothing other than Southern racism, typical of white people who enjoyed seeing Black people remain in the bottom echelon of their career. This, I felt, was a tendency to perpetuate the old-fashioned White supremacy.

I felt increasingly uncomfortable in his space. At the end of my second month, his hatred for me appeared to be at its brink.

He tried and did not find any tangible reason to lay me off; he felt labeling me with incompetency would be a good subjective reason. And so within the twinkle of an eye, I became jobless.

THE TEACHING MOMENT

The journey to the top of my career suddenly came to a screeching halt. This was the time when my career path was becoming more defined and predictable. I was becoming more and more knowledgeable, and so was the incline of my confidence.

I was full of enthusiasm, and I applied every bit of it to my training. I wanted to be the best in my career. My manager, who had all the intents of stopping my progress, blackmailed and labeled me as incompetent.

It was an irony that the reason for my dismissal was the very creed I made to myself to uphold in order to succeed.

Indeed competence and integrity formed the integral part of the four commandments Uncle Guyman inducted in me.

Overnight and barely two months in my new town, Plano, and enjoying my career advancement training as a software engineer, I became jobless.

This was for no reason other than racism. I felt I was unfairly victimized.

But these were the realities of a Black man living in the Southern states of America. Racism was well-entrenched, and a little displeasure or locking horns with your boss could be used against you.

My sudden unemployed status posed a significant financial burden on my family. My wife was a full-time mother and did not work. We had two young children, a three-month-old and a seven-year-old. We had two cars bought on hire purchase with notes due at the end of each month.

Moreover, losing the job with the EDS meant the end of the subsidized accommodation provided by the company. We had to move out immediately.

These were the realities I was faced with whilst living in the capitalist world. The sky was the limit in the upswing. And you could break multiple glass ceilings when things were going well.

But the capitalist countries are devoid of the social support that exist in the socialist world. Should you lose your job for even one month, you could become bankrupt and homeless by the twinkle of an eye.

This was where I found myself after barely fourteen months of working for EDS. My savings could only last for one month. I had to act fast and do so furiously in order to keep food on the table for my young family.

Our immediate priority was to find accommodation. We needed to move out of the company's apartment before the set ultimatum.

It turned out that finding accommodation in my circumstances was not as simple. My whole definition was a red flag in this White-dominated township of Plano.

I was a Black man with a family and had no job. This *mélange* was an unpleasant savor to any prospective landlord. It was, indeed, a nonstarter in any negotiation for rental accommodation in a town that had extreme, unwavering prejudice against the Black man.

As I searched for accommodation, it was obvious that I would not get anywhere. The landlords did not want to deal with any protracted ejection court case should I default on my rent.

And so the refusals came, one after the other, as the deadline to move out of the company's apartment approached. Each of the refusals came with the same story: I posed a real danger of defaulting on my rent.

After the multiple refusals, I needed to change the narrative in order to make our case more palatable to prospective landlords.

I would now present myself as a Black man with a family but pretend I was still working for EDS. This was an act of desperation in order to find a place to live. There was nothing to lose for pretending

to be who I was not. If I got caught, I would still get the same result as before.

We were lucky this time when the new narrative opened the way. One landlord gave us a consideration with the new narrative. I filled in the application form and cited EDS as my employer.

Their due process required them to verify with my employer the authenticity of my claim and my ability to pay the rent.

During their due process, it turned out EDS did not immediately update their record after they fired me. The interlocutor at the Department of Human Resources of EDS confirmed that I was still an employee.

It was a very close call. It was with great pleasure that my application passed their due process. I was, consequently, approved for an apartment.

We moved into our new home. It came with the basic standard fixtures of a typical rented apartment in America—a cooker and a fridge.

At this time, our household belongings from Dayton had still not arrived. Our next immediate priority was a bed and chairs.

My little savings came in handy to meet these basic needs. We bought a mattress and two sets of garden chairs. We still had enough funds left for food and any eventualities.

Soon after, we both started looking for jobs. For me, I was circumspect in what I was considering as my next job opportunity. It should be an opportunity that would advance my already commenced trajectory. I was a computer scientist, and I did not have to deviate to unrelated fields.

Therefore, trying to work in a fast-food joint just for the money was not an option. It would be a distraction to my career course and affect my ability to secure future jobs. My wife, however, was prepared to take any job that came her way. But being a nursing mother, the right fit was also important. This limitation also affected her ability to find the right job.

After many weeks of job search, our finances started to dwindle. It was getting harder and harder to maintain our household. We needed to limit our spending. Basic needs, such as food and rent,

took center stage. Our repayment on the luxury items, such as car notes, fell off the curb and lagged.

The processing of my redundancy money to plug the holes was still in the pipeline. I cashed out my 401(k) out of desperation and paid the penalties for the early cash-out. This money also took forever to arrive.

We were now financially broke. We started having calls from debt collectors on the car notes. The more we ignored these calls, the more frequent they came.

My wife reached out to her parents to extend us an olive branch. It was a tough decision and an embarrassment for me. Within a few days, my mother-in-law sent us some money. It was a much-needed help. It kept our heads above water for a while. It was very much appreciated.

But a disaster suddenly struck our family that sent us all reeling on our heels. It was at the time that we were performing magic to make ends meet.

Our little boy, about four months old at the time, became very ill. He was running high fevers, unable to eat, had nasal congestion, and became listless.

This was the worst nightmare for any parent who had no medical insurance.

We had little to no money and were faced head-on with a situation that could not be ignored.

Our only hope was the Presbyterian Children Hospital in town. We were of the opinion that, being a Christian hospital, it would be welcoming to indigent patients at little or no cost.

Bathed in our naivete, we rushed our sick child to the emergency room. We saw doctors busily taking care of patients behind the curtains. We were salivating to get TJ quickly to them for help.

The admitting clerk stopped us in our tract. The first thing she asked was our insurance card. Failing that, a credit card to take care of the bills.

Deidra and I looked at each other whilst we fumbled and asked for consideration.

The clerk, a White girl with a corky nose, mercilessly looked into our eyes with all sarcasm. She asked us to seek help elsewhere where they provided free health care. We walked away with utmost dismay.

At this point, we were both devastated. We took the child home. We played doctor and asked God to help us.

We went to the pharmacy and purchased over-the-counter remedies. We attempted to reduce his temperature by tepid sponging. We prayed for God's healing hands to reign over him.

After many days, by the power of our actions, TJ's health began to turn around. He got better and progressively completely recovered.

TJ may have caught a self-limiting viral infection, and his immune system was able to fight it off. We were fortunate it was not a bacterial infection, which would have required strong prescribed medication.

The huge responsibilities and no job were creating unbearable stress. Living was becoming very difficult to manage. I had helpless ruminations of how I could get out of the current situation.

My spirit was becoming dampened. My previous vibrant happiness was replaced with sleepless nights and looming depression.

I was now at the crossroads where my two minds were tasked to make critical decisions into my very existence. One half was deciding if it was worth continuing the status quo and hoped there would be light at the end of the tunnel. The other half was deciding if I should end my life and all the troubles would disappear.

As the two minds bounced off each other, each additional day of being jobless created augmentation of my negative mind to commit suicide.

One day, this *suicidal ideation* was so strong that it almost carried the day.

I was driving, and when I came to a bridge, I slowed down and gradually stopped. I got out of the car. I gazed at the calm running water flowing under the bridge.

If I jumped in, I would struggle for a few minutes; but the consequent perpetual quietness would be in tandem with the spirit of the calm water.

As I was getting overpowered by these strong negative thoughts, I pictured my lovely wife, Deidra, taking on my mantle of stress and responsibility. I felt it was unfair to shift all of it to the person who was riding with me in the same boat—a boat of pecuniary deprivation that required tact from two heads to resolve.

I felt it was cowardice to take the easy option and complete the *suicide* but manly to take the bull by the horns and deal with the situation.

I got back into the car and drove off. When I got home, the joyous welcome from my wife and innocent, starving children, whose hope was for me to remain strong and persevere, created a strong guilt in me to have even considered taking my life.

I took encouragement from my wife, who always reminded me that no situation was forever. She was oblivious to what I almost succumbed to but was sympathetic to the depression written all over my face.

A few days later, there was a small breakthrough that lightened up the mood of the whole household. After multiple trials of job hunting, Deidra was successful. She was offered a job with EDS, the same company that laid me off.

She would work in a different department under a different manager. She was hired as a data center operator. The department was responsible for backing up data on tapes. Their job was after normal working hours.

Even though Deidra was still breastfeeding, she took the night job without hesitation. We needed to manage the situation to make this work.

Money was tight, and we could not afford baby food. During the day, she would express the breast milk and store it in the fridge for the night feeding.

I also continued to pursue my job hunt. I was going round in circles. One day, a friend invited me to a job fair. Whilst there, I explored multiple stands for the right fit. I stumbled upon one that caught my attention. My qualifications appeared to match their requirements.

Upon further interrogation, the recruiter asked if I did not mind relocating to Aiken, South Carolina. I said not at all. He took my résumé and said he would get back to me. I felt this was hopeful.

The following days, I waited for that phone call that could potentially give me the breakthrough I needed. It would give me sanity. It would give my family dignity and financial relief. It would end the persistent *suicidal ideation* ruminating in my weak brain.

Finally the phone rang. Even though it was the same ringing tone, intuitively, I felt this particular call was special.

The call came from Westinghouse Company, a division called Savannah River Site. They received my résumé from the job fair. They were located in Aiken, South Carolina, and managed nuclear waste.

The interlocutor asked if I would be interested in coming for an interview. I did not mince my words. The answer was an emphatic yes. The interview day was quickly set and agreed upon.

Then I looked at the map to ascertain the location and distance of Aiken from where I was. It would involve a plane ride, car rental, and one-night hotel stay.

Our savings were almost completely depleted. We scraped the bottom of the barrel to raise the money for the trip—a trip that could potentially change our fortunes and put us back on track.

I flew from Dallas Airport to Atlanta and then connected to Augusta. It was a late flight. I spent the night in a budget hotel in Augusta. The following morning, I took a rented car and drove about twenty miles to Aiken, South Carolina.

I arrived at the company's premises, fully prepared with answers to the imaginary possible questions they would ask me. I was escorted to meet the manager who would interview me. He was a White guy.

My experience with Jackie, the librarian, and my last boss at EDS created mixed feelings about White folks. I did not know how this one, in front of me, whom I was meeting for the first time, would turn out to be.

He appeared more friendly, and his smile was reassuring. This put a sparkle to my enthusiasm and set the tone for the ensuing interview.

This would be the interview of my life. If successful, it would be the truce of my eight months of battle against poverty. This was the period when I had been out of work and lost all my dignity.

My previous job experience with EDS greatly intrigued him. He felt I was a rising star in my career. He recognized that my eagerness to succeed in my personal life would be a potential value to their company.

Halfway through the interview, I had the feeling that things would go my way. I felt my heart beginning to pound harder and prayed for the interview to come to an end quickly. I did not want to say anything silly for the remainder of the time.

His last question was to make sure I was interested in relocating to Aiken. When my answer was an emphatic affirmative, he hired me immediately.

This man turned out to be one of the best managers that I ever served. He was instrumental in the shaping of my future career.

THE JOBS THAT DEFINED MY FUTURE, PART 2

With an uncontrollably exaggerated smile, I made the final handshake with the interviewer who would be my new manager. He was equally elated, not only at my contentment upon receiving the news of my job offer but also at the value I would bring to this new position.

As I turned my back to him and walked toward the exit door of his office, I felt very light in my stride, as though the sensation under my feet had been lost. It felt like I was treading on cotton. My head was in the clouds with utmost joy.

I left the company premises with goose pimples sticking out all over my arms. I frantically looked for a payphone booth to call my wife. I was practically speechless when I got her on the line. I stumbled to find my first words, which quavered as my joyous voice extruded them out.

I felt electricity running through my house as she suddenly dropped the receiver and wailed with joy and sounded praises to the Lord.

We both shared the joy that this was the moment we had been waiting for during the last eight months. It was the moment that would rekindle our journey to achieve the American dream—a journey that was abruptly decapitated by a racist White man. His only intention was to put an impediment in my path so I did not succeed.

My new manager this time seemed to take the characteristics of Jackie, the librarian, during my college years. He was a White man

whose attitude toward a Black man was at variance with my recent boss. He appeared to be a well-meaning man who would create the space I needed to grow in my career.

It was evident that even though there was blatant racism in certain quarters in America, the value of an individual to society would always break through this barrier. And you would be unstoppable when the opportunity to rise to the top opened up.

Engulfed in overwhelming joy, my journey back home appeared to be prolonged, as I could not get there quickly enough to celebrate with the family. I wanted to see my wife and the two kids so badly.

The kids were blunted in our joy, as they had been oblivious to our plight to provide for them during the past eight months. We shielded them from the brunt of poverty by sacrificing all we had to provide their basic needs.

Now that I felt the approach of good tidings for them and a rebound of relative wealth with my new job, I could only imagine the additional comfort that was coming their way. I felt happy that I would now be capable of making their life even better.

The offer letter for my appointment arrived after a few days. I was hired as a systems administrator with a whopping salary of \$55,000 per annum.

It was a significant increment from my previous job with EDS.

There were additional perks that made the offer even juicier. The signing bonus of \$3,000 plugged the poverty hole instantly. As if that were not enough, each member of the family would have a one-way air ticket to Aiken. Finally, the company paid for all the costs incurred in the relocation.

I did not read any further details of the offer letter. I immediately tendered my acceptance letter, agreeing with all the contents as was. It did not matter at this point if there were any unfavorable hidden clauses. All that mattered was I got a job that paid a good salary.

Indeed, all our financial troubles would soon be history with my new job. Our cars would no longer be in danger of repossession. The bonus would allow us to catch up with our debts. We would see the return of excess income that would pay for a little luxury.

These were the reflections ruminating in my head as I thanked my friend who lured me to the job fair. It was a real breakthrough and a pivot of my life. I pondered the outcome if I had declined to honor his invitation.

I was at post within two weeks of my interview. The company provided interim accommodation in a hotel. My wife and children remained behind to complete the packing and to ensure that all our belongings were loaded on the moving truck.

The first few days of work were mainly orientation pertaining to working with radioactive waste. The rules were regimental and reminiscent of my wife's service in the military. Any deviation from the strict protocol could pose a potentially serious health hazard.

My family joined me a few days later. We spent some time in the hotel accommodation. Our belongings were in temporary storage.

Savannah River Site, my new employer, assigned my wife a real estate agent to assist in finding us an apartment. Within a few days, she found suitable accommodation.

For the first time, the choosing of an apartment did not become an act of desperation as it did the last time in Plano. We were free to choose where we wanted to live.

We felt good to be able to choose a spacious apartment that accommodated our needs. It was in a neighborhood befitting our status. It had amenities that also met the needs of our young children.

Our two cars came in handy. They were free of debt. It soon became apparent the relief of riding a car that had no threat of repossession. When your car was marked for repossession, you were apprehensive to park in a public space. It could be towed away by the time you got back.

Afua was about seven years old and got into a good school. TJ was about one year old and began to babble. Deidra remained a full-time mom and did not have to work. And so was the commencement of my new life, reset to continue the journey to achieve the American dream. It all happened in the southern town of Aiken, South Carolina.

We were now notched into a typical middle-income American lifestyle. We had disposable income. We could afford a bit of luxury.

We had the ability to taste the amenities in our local community and explore beyond.

Our weekends were packed with activities centered toward the children. Many times, we traveled to other neighboring major cities to shop and enjoy.

Greenville, South Carolina, and Atlanta, Georgia, were the get-away cities within driving distance that we most frequented. They had some of the finest restaurants that appealed to our gastronomy and shops that provided unlimited bargains.

Soon we were able to save a significant amount of money for the down payment of a house. We worked our way out of debt. We became incredibly creditworthy. And our credit score hit the roof.

The mortgage companies were salivating for our business. And within a few days, we completed the purchase of our first house with relative ease and satisfaction.

We moved into our own house. It was a spacious three-bedroom house. The neighborhood was serene. We felt secure and glad.

Racism was well-alive in Aiken. We could sniff it around us in the neighborhood of our new home. Should we go on our knees, begging for favor from the society around us, we knew it would show itself in full wrath.

We were protected by my good earnings that allowed us to dictate the way we lived and how we were perceived. We were untouchable because we did not need help from anyone. And the racist remarks bounced off our bodies without a dent.

But it came as no surprise that we were experiencing racism here. After all, Aiken was a town in the southern state of America. A Black man climbing to the top echelon of society sounded repugnant to many White folks in this society. My recent experience with the EDS boss in Plano told it all.

Racism played no impedance in my new job. Even if it did, it was imperceptible. My new boss did not appear to encourage it. And I was an indispensable player in my current position.

I was the systems administrator for the company. I was in charge of optimizing the efficiency of the company. Oracle Database was the

software in place for their data management. My mastery of this software helped me to enhance the efficiency of their operations.

I was acknowledged for my invaluable contributions to the operations of Savannah River Site. I gave them my all and exceeded their expectations. They were fulfilled to have me. And I felt the same for the company that turned my life around.

As the years flew by, my experience and maturity augmented. I was a master in my department. My complete knowledge of Oracle technology made my work even easier.

After five years with Savannah River Site, I felt there was nothing more I could offer. If I continued to work with them, I would no longer be challenged. The monotony would generate boredom.

It was time to move on. I needed to explore other opportunities that would continue to task my brain and appease my curiosity.

With my full knowledge of the Oracle Database software, I wanted to explore any job opportunities there would be in their company. Their branch was in Atlanta, Georgia—a driving distance from Aiken.

I waited for the opening and quickly sent in my résumé. To my surprise, I was selected for an interview.

This was probably the most relaxed interview I was ever subjected to. The stakes were not as high this time round. Whatever the outcome of the interview, I would still remain financially sound.

My experience as an Oracle Database Administrator gave me a competitive advantage. They did not hesitate to offer me the job as senior principal consultant. They proposed a salary of \$85,000 per annum.

I did not have to think about the offer. The position was a huge jump from my current position, and the salary was an unbelievably *icing on the cake*.

The job was to start immediately. They offered me a temporary stay in a hotel while I looked for permanent accommodation.

Moving to Atlanta was music to the ears of my family. This was a city that we had been to so many times. We loved and enjoyed its ambience and restaurants. It would be more exciting to actually live there.

I served Savannah River Site my resignation letter. It was a difficult thing for me to do. But the time had come to move on.

As expected my boss and other staff members were very sad about the news of my leaving. They were about to lose a good man and a gem of their company. They organized a mini leaving party in my honor and wished me the best in my new position. They made me feel that the shoes I was leaving behind would be difficult to fill.

Within two weeks, I was at my new job, camped in a hotel. My family was still in Aiken. We put our house on the market. My wife was commuting back and forth to Atlanta to look for a house.

A suburb of Atlanta, called Conyers, would be our next home. It was upscale compared to our current residence in Aiken.

The luxurious homes here attracted only wealthy dwellers.

The suburb caught our eyes when, hitherto during our joy treks from Aiken, we would ride through the neighborhood out of curiosity to savor and admire its ambience. We never thought that, one day, we would join the band of the upper-class citizens that could afford to live in that community.

Approval for the mortgage to buy our new home in this community was a mere formality. We had an impeccable credit score by virtue of our good finances that allowed us to religiously service all our debts on time.

Soon we signed the contract for our new home and moved in. We were further financially empowered when our home in Aiken was also sold with a good profit.

Living in Atlanta was the pinnacle of my entire existence in my dreamland. I had a good-paying job, a model family of four, a good home, the kids were attending the best schools, and I could afford anything I wanted.

My job as Oracle Database Administrator opened the way for me to fulfill my dreams. The position as a consultant was the best any employee would dream of.

With my deep knowledge of a product that was in a league of its own, I was a valuable member of the team that helped to expand its territory. I was involved in the technical training, implementation, and support for companies that switched to this software.

The job involved traveling to the premises of the companies that bought Oracle applications. By the time my four years in my new position were over, I was exposed to different states in America.

The job allowed me to explore almost every corner of my dreamland. The land that took years of toil, hardship, escape, and even jail time to arrive at had now become a familiar playground for me.

As I looked back, I could not believe that twenty years ago I was a mere dreamer to come here. I was declined the visa two times and dumped by my first love, Dorcas. The dejection pushed me to the brink of taking my life. I was encouraged by James to pick myself up and better my life.

And James's advice spearheaded my courage to take the almost impossible path to a land that gave me the empowerment to be whoever I wanted.

And James was right when he said that, if I made myself better, I could have all I wanted in life.

Here I was, riding in the prophecy of James.

RETURN TO THE MOTHERLAND

In Atlanta, I was at the pinnacle of my career with a software company that was the market leader at the time. I was an expert in Oracle Applications. As a consultant, I was part of the team that expanded Oracle Applications in the southeast of America, including Alabama, Georgia, and South Carolina.

Provisions Consultant Company was a reputable company in Ghana that lobbied for contracts with the government of Ghana. They had just landed a huge contract to provide Oracle Human Resource and Payroll for the government of Ghana to strengthen their human capital and financial resources.

Provisions Consultant Company did not have the technical team in place capable to perform this service. They approached Oracle in Atlanta for help.

Oracle was tasked to select the best team for the job. This team would install, implement, and train end users on the Oracle Applications.

Indeed these were the same functions I was hired for as a technical consultant. I would perform the same role but this time across international borders.

Oracle searched for volunteers, preferably Ghanaians or Africans from the subregion, to recruit for the project. I expressed interest and was instantly included in the ten-member team to send to Ghana.

The team would be away for one year. We would work with the Ministry of Finance under a project code-named PUFMARP.

I was excited to work as an expatriate in my own country. We arrived in Accra in 1998. We were accommodated in La Palm Royal Beach Hotel. We were assigned an office space in the premises of the Ministry of Finance.

Our task was to implement Oracle Applications for the Ministry of Finance that would enhance their operations. Oracle, a market leader at the time, had all the capability to make this happen.

When completed, the software would manage the human resource data, government employee payroll, all government financials, including accounts receivables and accounts payables.

As we hit the ground running, we were confronted with Ghanaian work ethics that were at complete variance from the work experience of our team.

I had been away for about twenty years, during which I acquired an American adult education and work culture that was alien to my home country.

It came as a culture shock to me and my team how different my countrymen and countrywomen approached their work.

This behavior cut across all the echelon of the ministry's employees. The extreme lack of motivation and the lackadaisical attitude toward work was very disturbing. Our work depended on the cooperation of a willing staff to transfer the knowledge and skill that we were tasked to deliver.

But we were confronted with staff at the ministry that had a lot of chips on their shoulders. They put their ego above civic responsibility. Their extreme inertia for change was evident in their tardiness to work. Some would show up late for the meetings, and others would not show up at all.

With all these predicaments, it was painstaking to carry through our assigned task. In the end, we managed to train every member of the financial team and completely transitioned to the new software.

Whilst we were dealing with all the encumbrances in the Ghanaian workplace, I had an epiphany that would be another turning point in my career. This may have slipped through as I queried some of the workers about the experience in other sectors of the Ghanaian economy.

It turned out that, like the Ministry of Finance, almost all the banks were using a system that was outmoded at the time to run their banking financial system.

Microsoft software was the one in place, as was the Ministry of Finance. It was laborious to work with its multiple spreadsheets. Its usage had seen better days. Oracle Applications included all the modules that could be used to improve efficiency.

Being an Oracle database administrator, I immediately took the opportunity to test the receptiveness of the banks to relational database management systems. It would be a software that would replace their current databases and not only make workflow easier but also improve the efficiency of their operations.

The positive feedback I got was very encouraging. This paved the way for an opportunity for me to establish a software company in Ghana. This company would have the potential to be a market leader in providing database management services to the financial institutions of the country.

At this point, I had enough experience by virtue of all my previous jobs to venture out on my own.

At Electronic Data Systems (EDS), I had a good knowledge of:

- a) how resources are put together to optimize the efficiency of a company; and
- b) how to use electronic data database management services and the Internet to support companies.

At Savannah River Site, I was a database administrator with tremendous knowledge of systems administration and operating systems of different platforms, which included IBM, HP, and Microsoft systems.

At Oracle Corporation, I was a consultant that was tasked with implementation of the Oracle Applications to new companies. I helped to extend the reach of the company.

I had a good product. I knew the process. I had the people who would need it and the team to make it happen. These were the three legs any new company would stand on to hit the stratosphere. I was

at the right place at the right time. The stars were aligned when all the ingredients needed to set me apart were glaring in my face.

With the mindset that I had the qualities that would set me apart from any competitor, I felt the need to go alone and establish my own company.

This was the time I decided to quit Oracle in the USA. I would set up my own database management company in Ghana.

But this would not be a competition with my parent company. It would be a win for Oracle USA to further enhance their horizon and an opportunity for me to be my own boss.

Based on this premise, I applied to be an Oracle Partner in Ghana. I was instantly granted the permission and the license to proceed.

But this was the easier part. I now had to convince my American wife, Deidra, that we had to relocate to Ghana. Indeed, despite all her curiosity about the African continent, the idea of actually living there and making the place her home was not on her radar.

After making a convincing argument that it would be the right thing for the family, I managed to persuade her to overcome her skepticism. She agreed to come with me so I could achieve my dream.

With the blessing of my family, I established *Bsystems* in Ghana. It would be a consulting firm that would use Oracle Technologies to help companies achieve their maximum growth.

My niche would be in the financial institutions, such as the banks. It would be a transition from their usage of the Microsoft Access database to a modern relational database management system. Capitalizing on the deficiency in the country, my company quickly gained traction.

But *Bsystems* encountered a competition in the country that turned out to be no match for it. It was a software company from Nigeria with a branch in Ghana attempting to capture the same market space.

It was called *the Tara systems*. Even though they promoted the use of the Oracle system, it was not exclusive. They were also promoting other software that they adapted to the local market.

Their problem was their lack of a good technical team on the ground for implementation. They relied on temporary consultants hired from India to do their jobs.

Bsystems had the competitive advantage. The company had all the supporting staff in place to implement and train. And within a few years, we became market leaders and dwarfed the operations of *Tara systems*.

And so I returned to Ghana, by my own volition, to my home country that I was so determined to escape from, as a completely changed man, with firing power that could make a mountain out of an anthill in the sphere of the software business.

I was ready to explore the horizons, with Ghana as my home office, to make *Bsystems* as big as I could.

MY BUSINESS EMPIRE, PART 1

In the year 1999, twenty years after I conceived the dire determination to leave my own country, Ghana, I made up my mind to return home and resettle.

Twenty years ago, I was young and naive and had no capability for further education, had I remained in Ghana. My future was bleak at the time, and I could predict the consequences of being a non-skilled manual laborer.

I fantasized a greener pasture elsewhere, where I could acquire further education and a distinctive personal skill—a virtue that would be a personal value that no one could take away from me. It could have the potential to determine the course of my life's journey.

The greener pasture—my dreamland—was the United States of America. This was where I wanted to be, and nothing could stop me from getting there.

Indeed my entire ordeal to get to my dreamland had been successfully rewarded. I was now metamorphosed into a business dynamo that could only see opportunities anywhere I stepped.

As a new man, I could now see Ghana, a country that I so detested and was so determined to escape from, as a new greener pasture and land of opportunity. It was now my dreamland, and the new me could only spot opportunities all around.

Only a few privileged individuals in my shoes could see the glaring, untapped, and rich prevalent opportunities that existed. I earned this by my determination for not settling with the status quo.

And so I returned to my *neo-dreamland*, Ghana, with my entire family, to explore and take advantage of its untapped opportunities. I was so sure that the boy from Mabang would again break another glass ceiling on his home turf. I would chalk another milestone that no one hailing from my village could ever achieve.

I settled my family in a suburb of Accra called Sakumono. It was a rented three-bedroom house, which I carefully selected to mimic the comfort and style we were used to in the United States.

But despite the assumed comfort in a relatively upscale community of Sakumono, the relocation was still a culture shock to my entire family.

The open gutters, mostly choked with silt and garbage, and roads full of potholes were some of the obvious eyesores they needed to contend with.

Also, during the day, the rampant flies roamed freely, contaminating uncovered food; and in the night, the merciless and fearless mosquitoes were ready to bite deep and suck your blood. These were additional nuisances that dampened the enthusiasm of my excited family.

I enrolled the kids in a prestigious primary school in another upscale community called Labone. The Morning Star School located there was, at the time, a magnet for the kids from rich families. I wanted my kids to continue to have the best of education. I felt this was where they deserved to be.

Ghana was a cash-and-carry economy, and I did not want the cost of a car to dent the meager budget I brought with me. Credit purchases were not the norm at the time, and a low-budget car would equally be good. Therefore I settled for an Opel Kadett as my first car.

The car was basic and did not have any bells and whistles such as air conditioning. Air-conditioned cars were uncommon at the time despite the hot climate. Therefore, riding in an air-conditioned car was considered *luxury*. Rich folks showed off by fully rolling up the glasses to make the point that the internal climate of their car was cooler than the ambient temperature.

My Opel Kadett—a jalopy, reminiscent of my first car in America—was the knock-around car I drove all day for my start-up business. It was very uncomfortable to conduct business in this car in a hot climate. I would arrive home in the evening very exhausted just from driving.

I needed to select a name for my new business. I chose a name that would have a good sound bite that would resonate with the nature of my new business. *Business Systems* appeared to be a good fit. I registered the business with its shortened version: Bsystems.

December 1999 was a memorable period when the new business was put in the books at the registrar general in Accra. I was issued the certificate to commence business the following year, January 2000.

January 2000 was the time the rubber met the road. My entire budget for my relocation to Ghana was \$12,000. It was my entire savings and working capital that I put aside for the business start-up. And this fortune was estimated to cover my entire family's living expenses, school fees for the kids, and business expenses, including staff salaries. I needed to massage this money until business took off.

As an Oracle partner, selling Oracle products was my entire business model at the time. It was on a commission basis where Bsystems would keep 30 percent of business brought in. The rest went to Oracle Corporation.

The epiphany that clinched my decision for an opportunity in Ghana was based on the premise that Oracle would be accepted as the *new age* of relational database management software by prospective clients.

Unexpectedly, Oracle software turned out to be too pricey for the local Ghanaian market. This was a setback for my new venture and a major impediment that dampened the enthusiasm for many clients. The delayed traction significantly affected the growth of the new business.

The resultant slow growth of the new business significantly affected my earnings. Even though I was judicious in spending, my financial commitments began to outpace the income.

The stepwise decline of my savings was evident. I began to struggle a bit. I could predict the doom and financial crippling of my family should the status quo continue.

I needed to rescue the situation. An interim job with a predictable income, however small, would significantly buffer the decline of my little fortune. This would certainly give me time to pitch my software to prospective companies.

I noticed that many companies, including the banks, were comfortable using Microsoft Office. With my extensive knowledge of this software also, I found a side opportunity to install this software for companies and train their staff how to use it. The small earnings from this side job came in handy and extended the inevitable looming doom.

Indeed my Opel Kadett, even though it was basic, was still an asset when I was struggling to make ends meet. It served as my office and reliably carried me to my mini jobs. In between these mini jobs, I would ride from one company to the other, seeking their interest to transition to the *new-age* Oracle database software.

In the scorching and humid tropical heat, spending all day in my non-air-conditioned Opel Kadett, which also doubled up as my office, was extremely uncomfortable. It was exhausting and drained my energy. I would sweat all day.

Conscious that I did not have a second chance to make a first impression, I would feel inadequate when I stepped out of the car to pitch my product to new clients. I was unrefreshed and sweaty when I stepped out of the hot car. I would feel I did not put my best foot forward.

The state of my car was even noticed by my kids, who became increasingly apprehensive when I pulled up at the school to pick them up.

School drop-offs and pickups were like an exhibition of cars of luxury. Kids showed off when they rode to school in luxury. They talked among themselves about the bells and whistles of their ride to and from school.

My kids were certainly uneasy about the subject and felt deprived when they could not participate. They did not have that pride when my jalopy pulled up at their school.

They had a little shame when I pulled up with the glasses fully rolled down to allow air in the car—an obvious sign that it did not belong to the league of luxury cars.

In order to curtail this constant infantile embarrassment, my kids decided I would park my car outside the school compound, and they would walk to it at my signal.

As if this was not enough, the income from my side job was still not enough to sustain us. My little fortune was withering fast. The relative luxury the kids had at home began to dwindle exponentially.

My kids were at their wits' end. They could no longer compete with their peers for superficial material things. Their infantile minds were locked in a race of who had what the best. The obvious struggle to settle their school fees in time did not help either.

They soon began to agitate that we return to the United States.

With the help of my wife—who was as antsy and had a repressed wish as the kids—we were able to quench their shenanigans and dissuade them from materialistic ideology. We encouraged them to focus on their studies and promised them better days ahead.

Whilst struggling for a breakthrough with the banks, I came across a company called Compu-Data Services Ltd. They had a banking software called Flexcube. They were also pitching to the banks to adopt it. Their product required a database software to run on. Oracle, the state-of-the-art database software, became a perfect complement to their product.

Our two companies, having products that complemented each other, formed a perfect collaborating partnership. We decided to work together as a team to pitch for contracts.

Even with a team of two and with products that surpassed any other prevailing on the market, we still struggled to make a breakthrough.

I did not want to give up at this point. But my wife did. She started rationalizing the children's demand for a better life in the United States.

Soon her itchy feet and the uncertainty about being in Ghana had gathered enough momentum. They were all ready to jump off the sinking boat. The kids' excitement for returning to America was palpable.

Then suddenly, we had a breakthrough, much to our excitement. One of the major banks expressed interest in our product.

The Ghana Commercial Bank had been laboriously keeping records manually on multiple ledgers with their Microsoft Access applications. This cumbersome process began to demand more man-hours to execute. And as the bank expanded, the sheer manpower needed to keep and update the records created diminishing returns on the bottom line.

The bank decided to upgrade to a more efficient and easy-to-use software system. They contacted Compu-Data Services to bring a proposal. Alongside, they asked Bsystems to add our proposal.

Our initial meeting with the bank was fruitful. When they were convinced we were a solution to their problem, they did not hesitate to instantly award us the contract.

Our two respective companies would now work jointly to implement and train the banking staff.

Bsystems hit the ground running as soon as the contract was awarded. We were solid on the ground with in-house expertise and the manpower to carry out the job.

But our complement, Compu-Data, lacked the ability to deploy their staff at a moment's notice. They used expatriate staff from India whenever there was such an opportunity.

Their part of the implementation and training lagged due to this hesitancy. This protracted the proposed stated duration of the conversion. But in the end, the bank had an efficient product—second to none—in place.

The testimony of the bank, expressing their utmost satisfaction after a few weeks of adoption of the software, sent ripples across the industry. They hummed its reliability, the ease of operations, and the reduction in man-hours. The reflected beefing up of the bottom line was the catalyst that removed any element of hesitation by any prospective company.

The completion of this contract was another turning point in the life of my family, where looming financial doom was rescued by fate and destiny. Our fortunes immediately became a pivot that turned things around.

It was a reliable income that came in as long as the bank was using our product. This breakthrough gave me the financial stability I needed to advance.

For the first time in Ghana, my income exceeded our expenses. I knew we had arrived when I could palpate the rejuvenated excitement of my entire family.

The tangible element that convincingly erased any agitation from my entire family to return to the United States was when I rolled my new BMW up our driveway.

I handed the car keys to my wife and said: "It belongs to you."

She broke down into tears and hugged me in a manner that reflected a regret for the element of doubt she reserved for the relocation venture.

"Morning Star School, here we come!" was the unsounded mantra that reverberated in the heads of my two kids the next school day.

The drop-offs and pickups from their school became a pleasurable event for them. This time, on the school grounds, they would get out of the car and dash toward the classrooms, beaming with smiles, confidence, and pride.

At the end of the school session, they would walk with their chests sticking out to join the BMW whose windows were rolled up to preserve its internal climate. This time, they were happy to wave to their friends as the BMW rolled off the school compound.

Not long after this, I rolled another new car into the driveway. It was a Mercedes. This car would be my workhorse and double up as my office. It would appease myself for the hard work. I was now reminded that I had arrived.

The Opel Kadett must now go into the history books as the car that had served us during our hard times. It was reminiscent of the old jalopy during my first job in Nashville.

It now had a new owner. The buyer, who may also be at the beginning of life's struggle, was full of smiles as we handed him its keys and the baton to the race of perseverance.

Ghana Commercial Bank, the icon bank of the country, started spreading the news of the revolutionary software they had acquired. This became a catalyst that scattered the news very quickly. The remaining banks, who were still using their laborious ledgers for accounting, began to salivate for this software.

Now that the bar of hesitancy had been lowered, all the existing eight banks, one after the other, toed the line of their icon bank. The Oracle database software and the Flexcube banking software would now become the *software of the day*, saving a lot of money in manpower.

Bsystems was now a household name in the financial services sector. This directly translated into a financial fortune for the company and had a knock-on effect on my family. I became financially solid on the ground, and my family enjoyed a standard of living at a level they had never seen before.

Bsystems did not sit down and pride itself on the glory of its achieved laurels. It now positioned itself as a software developer. It identified problems in the operations of existing companies and developed applications to resolve them.

Indeed, Ghana—now a niche market for this highly specialized product—had become a greener pasture for my new company. The abundant opportunities that existed were beyond any imagination.

Among the many software applications we developed, our HR payroll software and insurance brokerage software became a hit in the industry.

After ten years of unrivaled achievement in the industry, Bsystems aimed for the horizons beyond the borders of Ghana.

MY BUSINESS EMPIRE, PART 2

After ten years of solid, unrivaled business in Ghana, Bsystems became a household name in the banking sector. It set itself apart from any other competitor by its reliability, expertise in problem-solving, and unmatched customer service.

My previous experience with EDS and Oracle, respectively, were the priceless assets I inherited that set me apart from the rest. This allowed me to think outside the box and to have the ability to be creative in finding solutions to existing problems. Our customers found our work innovative and a breath of fresh air as they signed on to our products.

Bsystems had now set itself apart as a company that solved problems. This became the driving force that spearheaded our exploration for apparent and inapparent problems that existed in many companies during the early years.

We were blessed with the valor and the audacity to explore untapped opportunities both within Ghana and outside its borders. And either by destiny or pure serendipity, the opportunities became bare, one after the other, before our very glaring eyes.

It was in this mode that I stumbled upon an egregious and inconvenient predicament that existed in Ghana. This was in regard to opening a bank account by a client in the country. It was a cumbersome tripartite process involving the client, the bank, and the electoral commission.

During the era, the only means of identifying the client as a Ghanaian was the voter's ID. However, in order to be sure the ID

was legitimate, the bank wanted the card to be authenticated by the electoral commission. This requirement not only generated a huge inconvenience to the client but also an unnecessary burden on the electoral commission.

The authentication process was laborious and time-consuming for the electoral commission. Every day huge volumes of people lined up at the commission to get the voter's ID verified. Its authenticity was confirmed by a seal of the commission. The process required additional manpower and its associated cost. This certainly negatively impacted the budget of the commission.

I was on my usual rounds to sell our popular HR software at the electoral commission. I became amazed but curious about the density of the crowd that lined up at the commission. I was informed that it was a habitual phenomenon, and they were used to it.

After pitching my HR software to the commissioner, I expressed my curiosity and concern about the long line outside the premises of his office.

The commissioner did not miss his words about the frustration he could not find a solution to. He was concerned about the strain on the commission's resources. He had asked multiple software companies to come up with a solution. Unfortunately, none of these companies took on the challenge.

I told him I was willing to help resolve the problem. He was extremely pleased and asked me to proceed. He hoped it would not be a mirage like the previous companies.

This set the stage for the development of Ghana Government Voter's Identification System, GVIVE. It was the first of its kind in the country. When completed, any organization in the country that wanted to verify a voter's ID card could do so at the point of service.

Therefore the software would create the convenience that would not require the client to travel to the electoral commission for ID verification. It would also free up manpower dedicated for the process and translate into a tremendous savings on the bottom line.

Upon securing this deal, I quickly put a team together for the project. I bought a new laptop that I dedicated to this job.

Before proceeding, I consulted all other stakeholders that would potentially benefit from the software. This included the passport office, the banks, DVLA, and Social Security and National Insurance Trust (SSNIT). Each of them highlighted the focus areas of their predicament and were all very excited about the revolutionary software that was envisaged to make their work easier.

The development of the new software did not go smoothly as expected. During the process, an employee exhibited a character that was at variance with the terms of his contract. He had the hint that the software in development was going to be a big hit when completed and fully deployed. This generated a jealousy that allowed him to make an irrational bold demand to become a shareholder to the company.

Obviously he did not comprehend the concept of shares acquisition in a company that was already solid on the ground. And even if I wanted him to have shares, he would not have been able to put in the needed capital investment.

I did not feel the need for a partner at this point in the history of Bsystems, even if he had the means. I declined the offer. He was up in arms and angry. He wanted to sabotage the whole project.

The only power he had was the laptop, dedicated for the project, I entrusted in his care. He went home with it, and I never saw him again.

It was a huge setback for the company as the laptop was a very expensive commodity at the time. But he would not have gone far even if he wanted to complete the project and take all the credit. The contract was awarded to Bsystems and not an individual.

I took this in stride as a lesson learned. I had to be cautious of people I thought I could trust. This was just a bump in the road and no need to cry over *spilled milk*.

I replaced the laptop with a new one and restarted the project again from scratch. Obviously this protracted the duration of time we assigned to the project. But, eventually, it was successfully accomplished.

Indeed the advent of the Internet provided the backdrop that facilitated easier connectivity between agencies. It was the mecha-

nism that made the system work seamlessly. The new software was wholeheartedly accepted and adopted by the electoral commission as a game changer in their operations.

However, this sentiment was not shared by other stakeholders, such as the banks. These stakeholders needed to quickly adopt the software in order to enhance their point-of-service verification process of their clients. It was disappointing when they exhibited hesitancy in adopting a software that would be a game changer in their operations.

We were not perturbed by the lack of enthusiasm by these stakeholders. We plodded on to look for other clients to adopt the verification software.

In the process, we came across a huge loophole fraudsters had been using during the money transfer process by Western Union. Western Union operated by transferring remittances from clients from abroad to their families in Ghana. Their family in Ghana would cash this money either in the banks or through its authorized agent called Global Access.

Fraudsters found a flaw in the identification process before the money was cashed out. In collaboration with the cashiers, fraudsters would use someone's control number to cash out their money.

Global Access, conscious of this problem, were in the market looking for means to stop the theft. When we presented our verification software to them, it was love at first sight, a perfect solution to their problem.

The year 2007 was a year the fraudsters could remember. Their nefarious activities were busted. Global Access adopted our new software.

At the point of service, Global Access could now verify the control number and capture the facial image of the client cashing out the money at the same time.

The theft of other people's money at Global Access immediately stopped. This elevated the credibility of the company when their clients felt their transactions were safe and secure. This raised the confidence of those who continued to patronize their service.

Ironically, the banks who hitherto had cold feet in adopting the software became a new haven for the fraudsters. They shifted their operations there due to the unresolved defect in the verification process and continued to take other people's money.

It was not long before they swallowed their pride and made a turnaround. They learned a hard lesson from people who were looking for cracks in the wall to extract money that did not belong to them. They also happily adopted the homegrown software developed by Bsystems to forever put to sleep a problem that had been haunting them for many years.

It also came to be known that the defect in properly identifying a client was widespread across many establishments in the country at the time. Some foreign banks, who were severely affected, were losing lots of money through their offer for a quick car loan with a twenty-four-hour turnaround time. Fraudsters took advantage of the flaw in the verification process and presented fake identification documents. These banks literally dished out free money to unknown individuals.

Bsystems solved their problem overnight with their verification software.

At this point in the history of Bsystems, we continued to soar to the stratosphere, basking in the spirit of a market leader in the software industry. We had a successful HR software and now a verification software. We could not ask for more when our bottom line continued to swell exponentially.

While basking in the success of Bsystems, the World Bank was working with the government to create a legislation that was passed through Parliament for the Lenders and Borrowers Act.

The act, while focusing on registration of charges and collaterals related to credit to facilities, established a legal framework for credit and promoted a consistent enforcement for credit-related matters. The implementation of this act by central banks made it easier for foreign companies to transact business in a country.

The Ghana government passed this law in 2008, following which the Bank of Ghana issued a tender to prospective software companies. The successful company would develop a software that

would address all components of the act, including keeping a registry of all collaterals presented for loans.

Bsystems, already confident as a problem solver of the era, presented itself for the tender and won the tender to develop the Collateral Registry Systems. The World Bank, through its International Finance Corporation (IFC), awarded Bsystems a contract that would catapult it into the international domain.

Bsystems, upon securing this contract, worked in close consultation with the Bank of Ghana in order to address all the requirements entailed in the Lenders and Borrowers Act. Bsystems then designed the software to the specification and was approved by the IFC as meeting all the requirements.

Bank of Ghana adopted the software in the year 2008. This was another significant milestone for Bsystems.

Bsystems, now on the shortlisted companies of the IFC, was metamorphosed into a homegrown African software dynamo. It had now become an emerging African software company with no boundaries.

As the collateral registry was a component of the ease of doing business, other countries were obliged to follow the World Bank directives. They opened tenders. Bidders were required to have their software implemented in at least one country.

There were no challengers who equaled or exceeded our qualification. Bsystems won each of these contracts because we were the only company who had done it in Africa.

So far, ten countries have implemented the collateral registry system. These are: Nigeria, Malawi, Liberia, Sierra Leone, Zimbabwe, Zambia, Uganda, Mozambique, Ghana, and Ethiopia.

Indeed the longstanding amicable rivalry that existed between Nigeria and Ghana bred true on this occasion. The Nigerians were unhappy for a Ghanaian company winning. This became a stitch in their ego and did not go well with them.

For Bsystems, the stars were already aligned and our trajectory to the stratosphere was unstoppable. The Nigerians could grunt their discontentment, but nothing could bend the course of the emerging African software company—the Bsystems factor.

MY FAMILY

First wife: Deidra

Deidra was the catalyst that facilitated my final leap to the land of my dream. I salute her with all my honor and give her all the credit for making it possible for me to reach my dreamland.

We met in the nightclub in Bremerhaven, West Germany. It was love at first sight. For her, it was an authentic attraction to a boy from Africa, the motherland that, like many Black Americans, she and her parents had forever been dreaming of exploring one day.

For me, my attraction to Deidra was in part due to the rare elegance of a distinguished American patriot defending her country and also a quasi-selfish motive that she could be a vessel for me to complete my journey to my dreamland.

Above all the nuances, however, our union transformed into a genuine relationship and a marriage that spanned well over two decades.

Deidra would go down in my annals as a true right-winger or a quarterback who set the stage for me to deliver the goals of my dream. Her unwavering support, through which I achieved the heights of my dreams, was tenacious and priceless.

She saw me when I was poor and desperate. She was there when I was going through my formative years in America. And under her very nose, she saw me transformed into a successful and prosperous businessman.

Through thick and thin, Deidra and I raised two beautiful kids, Afua and TJ. We pat each other's backs for being able to do this with bare minimum resources at the onset.

With all her heart and absolute love, Deidra agreed to relocate to Africa. This was to enable me to pursue my dreams.

On the other hand, she was also excited to be one step ahead of the dreamers of the Black community in America, who had wished to visit the land of their unknown ancestry.

When I formed my company, Bsystems, in Ghana, Deidra became the administrator of the new business. She assumed a supervisory role and ensured prompt invoicing and collection of receivables.

However, this was the moment that appeared to be the watershed period of our hitherto solid relationship. A fault line was created when her background as a soldier set her up for failure in her new post.

The cultural differences and her military principles made her incongruent for the position of an administrator. As a trained soldier, she was used to the order-obey-and-ask-questions-after culture. This military-style drill does not always yield the desired result in the corporate world, especially in Africa, where sweet talk, most times, supersedes orders.

Consequently, her presence in the office became a demoralizing nightmare that dampened staff productivity. The business was going to suffer if she continued as an administrator.

I set up a clothing business for her, and I asked her to step aside as my administrator so that she could independently run her own business. Her company, the Corporate Woman, Ltd., was a pioneer in those days, specializing in dressing women for the corporate world. She obtained her high-end merchandise from China and the United States.

With the kids much grown up and not requiring close supervision, it was an opportunity for her to rise and shine in her own small way with a business that was niche in the era.

But whilst I was beating the bushes to advance my own business, Deidra was lackadaisical about hers. She was complacent. She lacked the drive and motivation to run her own business.

We both had great potential in our unique marketplaces. But we were polar opposites in our enthusiasm and drive for business. Whilst I sailed to achieve the heights in my career, she flopped and collapsed hers.

Certainly my energy in business was at odds with hers. She was comfortable staying at home and doing nothing and would caution my appetite to reach the heights. The strain transcending on our relationship began to wither the love and unity we nurtured all the years.

Our ambitions were moving in opposite directions, and so was the love we had for each other. We eventually had enough of each other.

The chapter on our fairy-tale love that began so sweetly in Bremerhaven, Germany, was now about to close. Soon we were in a divorce court. It was feisty and a great setback in my journey.

In the marriage settlement agreement, she insisted on having the only home we had in East Legon. She demanded to have the best two cars of the household: The BMW and the Lexus.

I moved out into a rented apartment with my aging Mercedes. I picked up the pieces shattered by this bump. And life continued.

Deidra did not return to her home in Mississippi after the divorce. She chose to remain in Ghana. With all the divorce arrangements and apparent gains, she had a good head start. She engaged herself in a new business to enable her to continue to live in comfort.

Unfortunately, Deidra's approach to her health was reflective of her approach to business. She was overwhelmed by the complications of hypertension. She succumbed and passed away about two years after the divorce.

Indeed Deidra's parents were unhappy with the relatively premature demise of their daughter. They blamed it all on the divorce. In order to appease themselves and come to terms with the loss, they requested her remains be repatriated to Mississippi.

This was the last honor I was pleased to offer the body of a woman who had made all the difference in my personal life. Even though the repatriation of a corpse was a daunting process, I managed to present her to her unhappy parents in a casket.

It was a tragedy and a sad end to the good sentiments her parents initially accorded to the boy from the motherland. This was an unpleasant experience that should never repeat itself again.

Second wife: Afua Adomah

Afua and I first met at a gas station in Accra. The moment of her desperation transformed into a love affair. For her, “every misfortune is a blessing” would forever be a cliché that she would reminisce on till eternity.

On that faithful day, I was traveling to Kumasi to work on my house that was under construction. I stopped at a gas station to fill up my tank. My curiosity led me to a broken-down car a mechanic was trying to put together for two beautiful girls.

As I approached, one of the girls shouted my name in utmost surprise. I instantly recognized her as an acquaintance on a project we had performed together a few years earlier. We had since lost touch with each other.

She introduced her sister to me as Afua and voiced their frustration about the length of time it had been since the mechanic had been working on the car. They were also going to Kumasi for an important family funeral. But it was beginning to look like the trip would have to be annulled.

In my kindness, spiced by the sight of the beautiful sister Afua, I immediately offered to be a good Samaritan. I asked them to leave their car in the care of the mechanic and join me.

The pride of two beautifully dressed girls entering my car and the sweet aroma they carried along with them created goose bumps on my skin, erecting my body hair to stand on end.

The goose pimples lasted for a good part of the trip. It was a drive of a lifetime that I did not want to end. Afua was in the back seat and was oblivious of my frequent gazes at her facial features through the rearview mirror.

The sentiments sent me down the fantasy lane. The more I savored, the more the attraction became overwhelming.

I did not want it to appear that I was rushing to fixate my total attention to her at the beginning of our trip. But halfway to Kumasi, the ice broke.

Engaging Afua in a conversation immediately demonstrated her intelligence. It was a natural, free-flowing two-way affair. It exposed in her some of the qualities I yearned for in a prospective companion. This further consolidating my fantasies, I felt the sparkle of a love affair was at its infancy.

To my dismay, we arrived in Kumasi too soon. It was three hours of joy and fantasy that would soon come to an end. But I did not want the gem I just chanced upon to leave my sight so quickly. I needed to cook up a means of artificially prolonging the duration of my enjoyment.

They accepted my offer to see my partially completed house during the weekend. Afua immediately became interested in the new house and offered to help with the interior design. I gladly obliged.

She was, knowingly or unknowingly, singing to my tune. I had no reason for coercion at this time but to encourage the path for a potential matrimonial union.

It turned out that Afua was no ordinary woman. She was a repository of enviable characteristics. She held a master's degree in arts from a Canadian university. She had a natural flair for business. She had the spirit of a philanthropist. She was a member of a noble philanthropist group in Ghana, the Rotary Club. And the list went on the more I became acquainted with her.

Complementing the characteristics that defined her internal beauty were the savory optics of her external appearance. Her body habitus and the distinctive and proportionate facial features would not resist heads turning, especially when she was dressed like the first day we met.

I was carried away when all these good attributes were crowned with the way she spoke and the intelligence behind her speech. She checked all the boxes of the characteristics I was looking for in a lifetime partner.

Meeting Afua at this period of my life was an upliftment from my unhappiness that characterized the tail end of my first marriage.

I did not have to hesitate at all about the gem I stumbled upon. As soon as my divorce from Deidra was finalized, the Mabang boy was ready to tie the knot again.

Afua came into the marriage with a potential wealth. It was a piece of land she had acquired in Nyanyano five years prior.

During the time members of the Rotary Club volunteered to vaccinate children against the paralyzing disease of poliomyelitis, the chiefs, appreciative of the effort, offered her the land for a small fee.

I was moved by her intuitiveness and initiative to possess a piece of land at such an advantageous place on the beach. She was pleasantly surprised and also elated when I offered to put the land into good use.

No sooner than three years, we built a beach house on the property. The ocean, the sea breeze, and the calmness gave this property a serene ambience. It automatically became our getaway location during the weekends.

Friends and family that we occasionally invited for weekends adored the ambience and serenity. Some requested to use the property for private events and family reunions.

Encouraged by the positive response, we decided to expand the property into an official commercial beach resort.

Over the following three to four years, the property was transformed into a lovely, cozy fourteen-bed beach resort. It had a restaurant, a spa, a lounge, and a bar.

By virtue of the ambience, the sea breeze, and the exceptional interior décor put together by Afua, the property boasted as a destination for tourists who discerned quality and attention to detail.

Afua runs this business solely. Her exceptional administrative skills have seen the patronage soar in a predictable manner to become an impressive market leader in the area. The place runs efficiently and, most importantly, profitably.

Afua has taken her skills to another level. She is an estate developer. She formed a company called ADS Designs. It is made up of a team of architects, planners, draftsmen, masons, and carpenters. This company has developed quality homes for many families.

Afua is also a repository of abundant kindness. She has made our home an open door and unintimidating for my friends and family. I feel at ease to receive people from all walks of life.

Afua and I have been blessed with one child, a son called Kwame Jr. Her exceptional motherly skills were demonstrable when she nurtured the only son into a model of a well-cultured child. Calling Afua a supermom would be an understatement.

Lastly I summed Afua up as a perfectionist. Her skill of attention to detail renders anything she touches into an immaculate masterpiece. This was evident with the interior decoration of my home in Kumasi, in Accra, the beach resort, and all the properties she developed. The “wow” effect is the usual sentiment for first-time exposure to her work.

Indeed Afua’s enviable characteristics rounded her up to a perfection that set her apart from any other women I deemed suitable as my lifetime partner.

My first child, Afua

Afua is my firstborn and a product of my first marriage. She was born in Rotterdam, Holland. Her birth was a symbol and the seal of my true love for Deidra.

My marriage to her mother had been misconstrued by her peers as a marriage of convenience due to my socioeconomic circumstances at the time. When she was conceived and born, all doubting Thomases who had thought I was a gold digger were silenced.

Her infancy was totally entrusted to my hands as the main parent. Her mother’s military duties did not allow her to be present. She became a daddy’s girl whom I nurtured entirely.

Her formative years were split between the United States and Ghana, but she spent most of her teenage years in the latter.

A true beneficiary of top primary education, she was an accomplice with her brother at the Morning Star School, who plotted to be picked up outside the school gates rather than being seen picked up in an old Opel jalopy in the presence of their friends.

We wanted her to continue receiving the best of education and obliged to allow her to attend college in the United States. Our good intentions fell on rocks when she was carried away by a slack in parental supervision.

Afua became pregnant halfway through college and was unable to make it through graduation. She went on to have a second child.

Now an unmarried mother of two, she works as a banker with US bank. We maintain an open line of communication, and she was pleased to attend my sixtieth birthday bash.

My second child, TJ

Thomas Junior, TJ, is the second born of *Deidra*. He is now thirty-two years old and four years younger than his sister, Afua. Like his sister, he spent part of his childhood both in the United States and Ghana.

His boisterousness and boyish ego at school were marred by the old Opel Kadett that dropped and picked them up from school. He was the lead architect behind the order to park my old jalopy outside the school compound so the boys did not see it.

But he grew up with traits of a well-cultured Ghanaian. Blending this with his excellent primary educational foundation offered by the highest standard of private education, he became an astute scholar ready to compete at any international institution.

Indeed he had a head start when he was accepted into a Canadian university. He graduated with a degree in business administration.

After graduation, he relocated to the United States to take up a job with Wells Fargo Bank. He worked with them for a few years, after which he was accepted into a lucrative position with IBM.

My third child, Matthew

Kwame Panin is the child of neither of my respective wives. He is sixteen years old. He is a sweet boy who always reminded me of

the strain and stress I endured at the tail end of my first marriage. I met his mother during those challenging times. Unfortunately, the relationship did not gain traction.

Being an icon of my troubled times, I take full responsibility for his upkeep and education. He is currently a student at the Presbyterian Boys' Junior Secondary School.

Kwame Panin is my blood and is wholeheartedly assimilated into my family.

My fourth child, Kwame Jr.

Kwame Jr. is thirteen years old and the only child of my second wife, Afua. Like his other sibling who was born in Ghana, he only knows me as a wealthy man.

When old enough, by virtue of the narration in this book, he will be able to keep abreast with the events in my journey to prosperity.

He has acquired a great humility that has been nurtured by Afua, the supermom. This has rendered him the characteristics of a level-headed teenager.

As a junior secondary school student at the Soul Clinic in Labone, he stands out among his peers and takes his studies very seriously. We are fully supportive of him as he pursues his own ambitions to reach new heights.

ACHIEVEMENTS

My career as a software engineer had never been my dream. Indeed it was far from my radar of the professions I had ever conceived.

I preprogrammed myself to be a pharmacist. I was very disappointed when I did not meet the needed grades after my advanced level examination. And even if I did, financial constraints at the time would have prevented me from pursuing the pharmacy course at the university level.

But destiny had already decided for me the way it did, and I did not have a clue. I was not meant to be a pharmacist.

This disappointment opened the way for me to explore in the open field what career path I was supposed to take. This made the need to find my way to my dreamland more dire. Perhaps educating myself when I arrived there would open a career opportunity.

In Rotterdam, when I was sure I had one foot in my dreamland after my marriage to the American soldier, I had an epiphany. It came in the form of the instinct of the stay-home husband to fill his time by educating himself. London's Rapid Results College was the perfect answer that offered distance learning. The course I chose was computer programming.

At the time, this was a novel area of study. It was fanciful but not popular. I selected it out of curiosity to occupy my time.

Little did I know that this instinct was a call. It was this divine destiny that probably made me stumble in my path to a pharmacy career. And the stumbling was a pivot.

I received a certificate from Rapid Results College after completion. When I finally arrived in my dreamland, pursuing the same course in college for a degree became automatic.

But my college education was not a smooth ride. The zeal I had acquired smothered the many bumps I encountered. And it was also the calling of destiny that the nuances in my path were meant to prepare me for the real world ahead of me.

The stars were aligning as I pursued the career of a software engineer in my dreamland. As I steadily progressed, the path was bumpy, but the successes I chalked notched me up one echelon after the other.

Today I am a proud boy from Mabang, who has achieved so much, both tangible and intangible, and whose very existence in this world will leave an indelible mark, especially in the information technology industry.

The crown of my achievement was the establishment of Bsystems Limited. It has made huge investments in software solutions and became Ghana's leading systems consulting and software development company. It has over forty employees supporting over forty-five companies, including more than twenty-five banking institutions.

Bsystems has developed many software applications that have made a significant improvement in the way business is run. These applications, developed in Ghana, have sent ripples across the business world.

Since its inception twenty-five years ago, Bsystems Limited has made the difference with several software applications under its wings. These are as follows:

- *Smart HR/Payroll System*

This is an integrated human resource management and payroll software solution for small, medium, and large businesses. The software enhances efficiency in the management of the human resource and renders payroll processing easier and more reliable.

- *GVIVE, Identity Verification System*

This is an online identity verification system that enables true and real-time verification of people's identity. With the built-in biometric identification, it is used to authenticate ID cards customers present before agreeing to transact business with the bearer at the point of service.

Many stakeholders adopting this software have been able to curb identity theft and fraudulent activities.

The enablers of the application include the following organizations in Ghana: Electoral Commission, Passport Office, Driver and Licensing Authority, Social Security, and National Insurance Trust.

- *Collateral Registry Systems (CRS)*

This is a web-based collateral registry software designed by Bsystems in collaboration with the World Bank. It registers the security interest over debtor's movable and immovable collaterals to meet legal and operational requirements of the client.

- *Financial Management Reporting System (FMRS)*

This software enables financial institutions to generate business intelligence reports of other companies to help them make informed decisions.

- *Bvirtual, Virtual Debit Card System*

This is an interface designed to complement internationally accepted prepaid cards such as MasterCard or Visa card. It satisfies all KYC and industry security requirements and is accepted globally by online merchants. It can be accessed via mobile application on personal phones.

The funds are loaded onto the virtual cards ahead of any purchase and can be transferred for transactions. It insulates the cardholder from risks during transactions.

- *National Digital Tax System (Digitax)*

This system serves as an efficient and reliable tax collection platform. It monitors online trade transactions between merchants and customers in a country. The sys-

tem, through its complexity, eliminates tax evasion and default in relation to tax collection.

Stakeholders interfacing with the system can identify, deduct, and remit on a real-time basis applicable taxes in full from all online transactions.

- *PeoplesPay, Online Payment System*

This is a mobile app software developed for the purpose of digitizing online payment for services. Among the many features provided by the app, it:

- a) facilitates interoperability between mobile money and bank accounts;
- b) supports the execution of GHIPSS QR code payment at merchant locations equipped to accept the same; and
- c) supports the in-app payment and collection on behalf of preregistered merchants such as DSTV, Go-TV, Ghana Water, ECG prepaid, airline tickets, and so on.

- *Collateral Registry Systems*

Bsystems, working in collaboration with the International Finance Corporation (IFC), a member of the World Bank Group, has successfully implemented our masterpiece software, Collateral Registry Systems (CRS), in multiple countries across Africa.

These include: Bank of Ghana (BOG), Central Bank of Liberia (CBL), Department of Registrar General (DRG) of Malawi, Central Bank of Nigeria (CBN), Bank of Sierra Leone, Patents and Companies Registration Agency of Zambia (PACRA), and many more.

The Ghanaian company, Bsystems, with headquarters in Accra, Ghana, has offices in Dubai, Canada, Kenya, Sierra Leone, Malawi, Nigeria, Uganda, and Liberia.

My company has been recognized as a powerhouse in the ICT industry in Africa and earned multiple awards by many organizations for the outstanding achievement.

Some of these recognitions have been presented in grand style as depicted below.

September 2012

Barely three years after its inception, Bsystems was adjudged the software company of the year and received the recognition from the Ghana Telecoms Awards. They awarded recognized players who had demonstrated excellence in the telecommunication and ICT industries.

March 2014

The Ghana Investment Promotion Council (GIPC) awarded Bsystems for being a Ghana Club 100 Awards leader in the information communication technology (ICT) sector in Ghana.

November 2014

Bsystems Limited was adjudged the best West African ICT company of the year. It received the award at the 2014 Business and Leadership Awards held in Brussels in Belgium. This was in recognition of the company's immense contribution for business in the subregion.

The awards took into consideration the cutting-edge solution offered by Smart HR/Payroll System used by the Internal Revenue Service (IRS), National Lottery Authority (NLA), National Health Insurance Agency (NHIA), and others for efficiency in the management of human capital and ease of payroll processing.

It also recognized the immense contribution in the financial sector of the identity verification system (GVIVE) that put an end to fraudulent transactions in the sector.

And, finally, it took note of the Collateral Registry System (CRS) adopted by the Bank of Ghana and the Central Bank of Liberia.

February 2016

Bsystems Limited, together with IFC (World Bank Group), implemented its flagship application in Malawi. It was the Collateral Registry System (CRS), which was a reform that enabled businesses and individuals to access loans using movable assets as collateral. The project was launched by the country's vice president, Dr. Saulos Chilima, in Lilongwe, Malawi, in February 2016.

September 2020

Ugandan President Yoweri Kabuta Museveni hailed and applauded the Bsystems Collateral Registry System when he personally launched it in the State House in Entebbe. It was adopted under the name Security Interest in Movable Property Registry System (SIMPO).

He was impressed by how a software developed by a *Mabang boy*, Thomas Baafi, would change the business landscape in Uganda. He noted that the software, by allowing movable assets to be used as collateral to borrow money, would boost the ease of doing business and stimulate innovation and creativity in his country.

The *Mabang boy* was at the launch and took it all in with a great feeling of fulfillment.

November 2023

I was awarded for my outstanding contribution that made Ghana a Pan-African leader in the financial services software.

Above all these achievements, I am also a proud father of four who has ensured financial security for his children by equipping

them with the best of education so that they and their progeny would never become a burden on society.

Finally, I do not deem it appropriate to self-gratify about the personal properties I have acquired in multiple countries. But I would like to be remembered for the establishment of Cliff Haven Beach Resort in Ghana.

This resort, put together by Afua and I, unified our marriage and set it in stone. It is our legacy to the world after we are long gone and would be immortalized as the best relaxing destination for many generations that will come after us.

THE CHECK

Life is like a roller coaster. The ups are the heights of achievements and excitement. The downs are the dark moments of our lives. Our personality was defined by the way we were perceived when we went through these peaks and troughs.

Many successful people took these peaks and troughs in stride in such a way as to appear as if life was always even and smooth. They did not exhibit any chip on their shoulders when all was going well. Neither did they appear to be in the doldrums when life went south.

I lived with the principle that as long as one was above the surface of the earth, life would always be like a roller-coaster ride. And no situation in which I found myself, however good or however bad, would ever remain the same.

I had my fair share of ups and downs. I enumerated my ups in the achievements I chalked that made me the first and only person in my village to break the glass ceiling.

But it was not all glory and singing to the bank. There had been sad moments in my life when these achievements became interspersed with many unexpected bumps.

But, emboldened by the coping skills I acquired earlier on through nurturing by Uncle Guyman and his three commandments, I had been able to keep an even keel during the face of the rapid descent of the roller coaster. Elaborating on some of the bumps would make me feel human.

My near-death experience

I had just got my head above water after I had almost been drowned in debt when I was laid off from my second job. The Savannah River site offered me that job, which saved the day.

Life was beginning to feel good, and the feeling that the sky was the limit was beginning to feel real. I was blessed with the ideal family. I had a beautiful wife, two beautiful kids, 2twocars, and a beautiful house. What more could I ask for?

Then one fine morning, whilst leaving for work, I kissed my family the usual goodbye and said to them I would see them in the evening. Little did we all know that it was in the hospital intensive care unit that we would see each other.

Soon after I started work, it seemed *the witchcraft* from my village came to town. They may have played their tricks that sent me slumped on my desk. My colleagues found me unconscious.

They sounded the alarm and began cardiopulmonary resuscitation. Within minutes, as I was told, the ambulance arrived. I regained consciousness in the emergency room.

I ended up in the operating theater almost immediately for a cardiac procedure called radiofrequency ablation. It took an excess of two hours before they were finally done.

I had no knowledge that I was born with a rare heart condition called Wolff-Parkinson-White syndrome (WPW). It was an abnormal electrical conduction pathway in my heart that bypassed the usual electrical conduction route.

This abnormality would occasionally set up an autonomous rapid conduction which would reset the rhythm of the heart into an abnormal fast pace. This fast pace led to inadequate blood flow to the brain and resulted in total loss of consciousness.

It could lead to death if not promptly treated. The principle of treatment was the use of radio waves to destroy the abnormal conduction pathway.

In my case, being in my dreamland saved my life. This specialized procedure was not available in my country, Ghana. And to this

day, the promptness of response to medical care in Ghana still had a long way to go to meet international standards.

I resumed my normal life after a few days off work. On my way to work, I ruminated on the events, and like the lizard that had just fallen off the tree, I nodded my head and said to myself life was not all roses after all.

Tragic death of Uncle Guyman

I intended to reward Uncle Guyman when I was financially capable and ready. He pulled me from the hopelessness in Mabang and showed me the light of the world.

His demise came suddenly and tragically in 1996, just as I was about to make a breakthrough. This stopped me in my tracks.

He died in an accident on a railway track. That should never have happened, considering the rarity of train traffic at the time.

On that day, Uncle Guy was driving from Kumasi to Accra. At the only railway crossing en route, the guard was not at post to lower the bars for an approaching train.

Uncle Guyman's car was caught up in a little traffic as he arrived at the railway crossing. His car was sandwiched between two cars. It was the only car stationary on the railway track at the same time the train approached.

The train, unable to stop, swept his car off the railway line. His body was pancaked in the mangled car.

Following his demise, my head became shrouded in dark clouds for a very long time. It gave me a reality check about my own personal life, considering my own near-death experience.

Life is not always what you want it to be. Mishaps happen when you least expect them. Whilst not letting the possibilities of these occurrences preoccupy my whole existence, I became open and ready when they occurred.

A stab in my back

The business landscape in Ghana was full of dishonest people. What a surprise; I was singing to the choir by this testament. It was a cliché that had been and would always be.

It was indeed a paradox to think that, with the apparent high percentage of religiosity in Ghana compared to the advanced world where I had just returned, the prevalence of honesty was a rarity.

One day, I was competing for interest in a contract with other companies. We were all required to present a proposal and a business plan.

The company that won the contract used my business plan. I was informed after the fact by a good friend who was privileged about the plot.

The secretary of the contracting company photocopied my business plan and all my proposals onto the letterhead of another competing company. Indeed, whether she was in a rush not to be caught, she forgot the last four pages which still bore the logo of Bsystems.

I lost the contract, but it was a teaching moment for me. It raised my alertness for the reality of the business in my new world.

GhanaCard decoupled my business

The Bsystems software, the GVIVE, was our cash cow in Ghana. It was the game changer at the point of care of identifications of clients for business transactions in the country that stopped fraudsters in their tracks.

Business was going well until the ruling National Patriotic Party decided to have a national identification system. This led to the introduction of the GhanaCard, which basically performed the same function as our GVIVE.

Following its implementation, all the users at the points of service, including the banks, Passport Office, etc., switched to

GhanaCard. This wiped away about 65 percent of our annual income in Ghana.

It was a big setback personally and also to the staff whose livelihood depended on it. We had no choice other than to reduce our workforce.

GIVING BACK

I had my fair share of struggles in life. Today it would almost appear as if it never happened. Documentation of my struggles in this chronicle would always remind me of my past and serve as a reference to those who were on the fence about making sacrifices that would make life better for them.

Indeed I came across many people whose struggles mirrored mine. Whilst some of them did not have the audacity to invest in a pathway that could change their circumstance, others, by virtue of circumstances beyond their control, were unable to change the course of their predicament.

I had been of assistance to those who had been boxed in by these financial predicaments. Some of them were left with nothing but a tortoise elbow room to maneuver. I never wanted them to endure my treacherous journey that sent me out of the *ashes*.

My joy was to see the people I touched rise from the *ashes* to attain heights they could never have imagined without my help.

My assistance knew no boundaries. Family members and total strangers equally benefited. Many of them had been very grateful, and their gratitude opened doors for me.

Among the many I assisted, it was worth documenting, in this chronicle, the few whose lives had been catapulted to the next level.

The story of Milicent

It was a hot sunny day in Accra, and iced water was a perfect solution to the extreme heat whilst caught up in heavy traffic. Milicent was a street hawker whose circumstances made her defy the heat. She approached me in traffic with her merchandise. It was iced water. She convinced me to buy, and I did with little hesitation.

But one thing was peculiar during our exchange. She spoke perfect English.

As the traffic was still going slow, we engaged in a little chat. Within that speck of time, I was able to ascertain that she was selling water to raise money for her tertiary education.

Moved by the story, we exchanged numbers. I asked her to contact me. When she did, I invited her to my office for further discussion. It turned out that she had completed her senior high school with exceptional grades. Her dream was to become a nurse. By merit, she was accepted by the University of Ghana.

Since she could not afford the fees and her upkeep for a university education, she turned down the offer. She wanted to raise money and reapply the following year.

When I offered to help pay her fees and upkeep in the university, she broke down in tears in disbelief. Milicent reapplied and was accepted the following year. She did not disappoint. She graduated with honors after four years.

She did not stop there. She wanted to take the career to another level. With my financial assistance and contacts, Milicent was accepted into a university in the United States for a master's degree in nursing. The story even became more interesting when the street hawker—the iced water seller—eventually gained a doctorate degree in nursing.

Milicent was a pedigree of her own that excelled above and beyond expectation. All the iced water street hawker needed was a stepping stone and a little boost from the launching pad.

The story of Bambila

One morning, before the day's work, my driver, in stammering hesitation, requested to have a private talk with me. The request that had been haunting him appeared to have been bottled up for a long while.

As he could no longer contain it, he mustered the courage to talk to me about it.

After jittering and a bit of beating about the bush around the subject, he mentioned a colleague had asked him to approach me with a special request.

His colleague was of a tribe from the northern part of Ghana and worked as a driver for a different company. He managed his meager salary to push his first son, Bambila, through high school.

Bambila, a disciplined student with academic excellence, was able to graduate from high school with impeccable results. He applied to Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology in Kumasi to read medicine and was accepted without hesitation.

But this appeared to be the easy part. The hard part was the money to put him through six years of medical education.

It was at this point that his dad went through an emissary to make the sacred request, the outcome of which was like a life-and-death situation for the family.

After hearing the story, I was heartbroken. I was filled up with overwhelming compassion. The only answer to the request was in the affirmative. I did not want talent to go to waste. My action would create a doctor that could have a snowball effect on society. My inaction would result in an immediate disappointment and a family disaster.

I took over the care of Bambila through his six years of medical education. Bambila is now a full-fledged doctor practicing in his hometown hospital in Tamale.

Asennua Children's Clinic

Asennua is a locality in Kwabre District in the Ashanti Region. It is a village with sentiments close to my heart. It is the village where my mother was born and spent her earlier years of childhood. She eventually migrated to Mabang with her parents.

Infants and children in this village had been disproportionately afflicted with many preventable diseases. Due to lack of accessibility to urgent health care, many of them could not make it to adulthood. Early deaths were so common they no longer became news.

Indeed many of these early departures could have become responsible adults and contributed to society building. Unknowingly and indirectly, this village produced a gem that had broken many glass ceilings. In appreciation for their gift to the world, I decided to give back to this village a tangible contribution.

I constructed a medical clinic in this village and dedicated it to children's health. It would soon be commissioned as the only children's clinic in the community, and the reach would spill over to the surrounding communities.

When fully operational, it would impact the lives of many children and, hopefully, produce many avatars of me.

The story of KFM Limited and Talent Microfinance

I received a call for assistance to set up a business for the distribution of musical instruments with disdain and skepticism. But it was an SOS call from my younger brother, who was in the wilderness of unemployment. He had been trying every business opportunity to see which one would stick.

I was willing and ever ready to help any member of my family in any business opportunity that had the potential of growth and expansion.

Certainly, selling musical instruments was not what I envisaged would be a scalable business worth investing in. I, surely, had a myo-

pic view of the business around selling musical instruments at the time. This was in sharp contradistinction to my brother's view.

With the attitude of sitting on the fence, I gave him the benefit of the doubt and yielded to his demand. Time would be the measure that would determine the outcome of his venture.

With my input, he started importing instruments such as the piano, the drums, and the guitar from the United States of America.

As business progressed, he switched his supply source to China. He was able to get the instruments manufactured there according to the United States specification.

He saw his profits burgeoning as his customer base grew rapidly. The relatively minuscule cost of merchandise from China was an added advantage.

His niche market was the result of the feverish evangelism infesting the West African subregion. This saw an ever-growing number of churches in the subregion. Each of them needed the assistance of a well-equipped orchestra to compete for believers.

And so my brother positioned himself in the market at the right time. He had cheap products from China, voracious consumers, and a conducive distribution process.

And this was the genesis of a multimillion-dollar company, KFM Limited. Operating from a warehouse in Accra, it became the distributor of all kinds of musical instruments in the country.

Indeed business grew beyond the borders of Ghana. His Accra warehouse became the hub for distribution to other West African countries such as Nigeria and Burkina Faso.

My brother did not stop there. The success of KFM Limited allowed him to venture into the lending business. He set up Talent Microfinance Limited.

Even though I did not finance this directly, it was the result of the knock-on effect from my original assistance.

My grandchild company took advantage of the rapidly growing Ghanaian economy and the bottlenecks in accessing working capital. It was able to assist companies with short-term loans.

Talent Microfinance Limited has, to date, eleven offices dotted throughout Ghana.

Assistance to other siblings

Indeed I had been the bedrock of my entire family. It was probably by design of destiny that I was handpicked by Uncle Guyman to give me the right head start in life.

I was emboldened by his action to rewrite the history of my family. I wanted to raise them above the cloud of poverty that hovered over the people of Mabang.

I was blessed in the process with wealth—a wealth that made me a key player among my siblings.

My family was lucky to have me as a custodian of this ability. I had been selfless, to say the least. Through my kind heart, the remainder of my siblings had been elevated one way or the other by the wealth that found its seat in the right heart.

The assistance I offered to my fifth brother to set up a successful real estate business and to my sister to relocate to the United States were some of the *perks* my siblings enjoyed from my magnanimity.

Thank God they all rose above the dark cloud that reigned over Mabang.

Board member, Wisconsin University

I took it as an honor to be admitted to the advisory board of this prestigious university. It was an extension of my willingness to give back to society the gift of my blessing and an opportunity that allowed me to influence many people at the same time.

The management of the university held my advice in high esteem and applied it to run a successful university education.

The student body was encouraged by the story of my ability to build a mountain out of an anthill. They resonated with the fact that the ability to excel must be guided not by where you came from but rather where you were going.

At any given opportunity, I sensitized them with the four commandments I inherited from Uncle Guyman that made me stay focused.

As long as I have the health and ability, I will always give back the little that will make a difference in someone's life.

PEOPLE WHO INFLUENCED MY LIFE

Uncle Guyman, the catalyst

I give credit to Uncle Guyman for making it possible for me to be accepted to commence formal education when I could not prove my readiness by my age.

During this period, there was no immediate documentation of birth, and age was determined by guessing or by physical appearance.

This became a problem for me. My lagged physical development was considered not at par with my readiness to commence primary class 1.

My mother had a gut feeling that I was ready. But her guts were not backed by a birth certificate that I had attained at age six, the school-going age.

The only option left for me was to pass the litmus test. This was to prove that I could touch the opposite ear with my hand crossed over my head.

But my physical developmental delay posed a challenge, and I did not have the reach to touch my other ear.

By all the criteria available to start school, I was not ready, much to the disappointment of my convinced mother.

This was the time that Uncle Guyman came in. By using his inferior tactics and backroom wrangling with the headmaster, I was accepted for trial in primary class 1.

And so the candle was lit for my formal education. It never got extinguished as my *stellar* academic performance dwarfed and compensated for my physical structure.

Again, during my early primary education, Uncle Guyman made another remarkable uplift in my life. This was necessitated by his concern about my mother, who was struggling financially to feed her many children.

In order to help ease the strain on my mother, he offered to take one of her children away for education in the city of Kumasi.

I became his obvious choice. He was encouraged by my good behavior in school and excellent report from my schoolteachers.

Indeed relocation to Kumasi at an earlier age opened my eyes. By the time I completed my secondary education, he inculcated in me the four commandments which guided me all my adult life.

James the motivator

James, an accountant, was the architect of my fifth commandment.

I met him when I was vulnerable and contemplating committing suicide. I was eighteen years old, and the only woman I had ever fallen in love with had just ditched me.

I was ashamed. I was being called names by my peers. I went into hiding. Thoughts of suicide were strong and *imminent*.

The only few times I ventured out, I met James. I poured my heart out to him. I wanted him to rationalize why I wanted to end my life.

James's response was, rather, at variance with my thought process. It hit me hard in my chest. His exact words became my mantra. Until this day, those words still reverberate in my head.

"Do not kill yourself because of a woman. When you better yourself, you will be spoiled for choice."

This formed the basis of my fifth commandment. I learned that in life, there will be setbacks. But these should be considered bumps in the road.

There will always be better things to come your way, and that bump will just be history. There should be no need to lose sleep over them. It is better to get up, brush your behind, and move on.

James went on further to assist me in my preparation to migrate to my dreamland, the United States. He facilitated my trip to my launchpad. This was the slums of Agege, Nigeria. He settled me and found me a job. I was able to build the initial capital for my adventure.

James, at the time, became a pillar in my life. His advice always emboldened me. Anytime I fell, he reminded me to quickly lick my wounds and move on.

Today I am a living testimony of James's prophecy. I have made myself better, and my choices have no limits.

James eventually migrated with his family to Canada. He has been living there since. We have always kept in touch and continue to talk when the opportunities arise.

Professor Johnson, the sympathizer

Professor Johnson was the economics lecturer at Austin Peay University during my four-year tertiary education in Clarksville, Tennessee.

This was the time in my life when I felt the four walls of the world were cramming in on me. I was a full-time student with little money. My wife was a soldier with a meager salary and always away for military duties. I was a pseudo-single parent and could not afford a nanny. I was solely responsible for all the needs of our young daughter.

In order to graduate college, I needed to do an elective course in economics. This course was offered after hours when the day cares were closed.

The only option for me was to take our daughter to the class. At the time, she was about four years old. My hope was for her to sit quietly while I attended the lectures. But the most important thing was that the lecturer would understand and accept her in the classroom.

On the first day of the economics course, I entered the classroom when most of the students were already seated. Judging from the body language of the students, they had never seen that before. It was certainly an eyebrow-raiser for every one of them.

But there was hardly any comment, even though the surprise on each and everyone's face was palpable. Everyone held their breath in anticipation of Professor Johnson's take when he walked in.

Finally he arrived and immediately noticed the quietly sat youngest student in class. I guessed his initial impression would have been that a genius had just become his student. But I did not allow him to contemplate for too long when I raised my hand to interrupt his gaze and curiosity.

I immediately stood up and walked timidly to get to his ear-shot for an explanation. With empathy and without words, Professor Johnson listened and nodded repeatedly to punctuate my loaded and jagged explanation.

The double big nod at the end of my discourse signaled that he had no objection to my child being with me in the classroom.

Professor Johnson's humanity shone through when he took it upon himself to explain to the class that he had just met the first Black single parent from Africa who had shown the determination to educate himself at all costs.

He used my determination to exemplify courage and zeal. He used it as a showcase for other students not to let predicaments prevent them from acquiring education.

From then on, I became comfortable attending class with my daughter. Sometimes she would play in the corridor of the classroom. Her childish play noises were tolerated and accepted as a reminder of courage and determination of a die-hard student.

I am thankful to Professor Johnson that he made it possible and easier for me to graduate college, despite all my challenges.

Mr. Mensah, the enabler

Mr. Mensah was a visionary businessman who was operating out of his comfort zone at the turn of this century. He knew there was a need for a change in the software used by the financial institutions if they wanted to keep abreast of the changing times.

In the early years of 2000, companies were moving away from Microsoft Access to more efficient software to run their businesses.

Mr. Mensah was smart to position his new company, Compu-Data Services Ltd., in the center field to promote his new banking software called the Flexcube. This software ran on Oracle database software.

But he was faced with the usual inertia of certain Africans who were happy with the status quo and would resist change. Moreover, he was not a technical person to add the necessary spice to the need for change to a new software.

I came in at the time that Mr. Mensah, who already had contacts in the institutions, was struggling to win clients. I was the technical man and an expert in Oracle. Since his software ran on Oracle, it was like a marriage made in heaven when we met.

Our two companies complemented each other. I would get credit for any software he sold.

He paved the way for me to get into the financial business circle, and it became the nidus upon which I built my own business empire.

This came at a crucial time to avert the implosion of my family, who at the time had enough hardship during the settlement in Ghana and were preparing to jump ship and return to the United States.

Mr. Mensah's solo effort facilitated my integration into the Ghanaian community and made my return to my *neo-greener* pasture more manageable.

THE DREAM LIVES ON

Even though family-owned businesses are a center of growth in developing countries, Ghana had a very volatile business environment. Many new businesses succumbed after a few years. Indeed the five-year survival rate of new family-owned businesses was estimated to be 20 percent.

The harsh business environment even made survival of new family-owned businesses impossible beyond the initial founder. Transgenerational businesses were a rare occurrence in Ghana and, with the odds of 5 to 10 percent, it was not a stretch of imagination to name the *good-old-days* of many icon companies that had faced complete extinction.

It was against this backdrop of the abysmal odds that faced new businesses in my home country that I dared and relocated my family from a comfortably paid employee status in the United States to start a new business in Ghana twenty-five years ago.

As I approached the golden age of blessed sixty-five years and contemplated retirement, I had my fair share of the peaks and troughs of doing business in Ghana.

The prevailing political environment became unfavorable to the survival of my business at its tail end, let alone at succession. My cash cow business of identity verification system had been usurped by the introduction of the Ghana Card.

As my business spun its wheels with diminishing returns, I became locked up in survival mode. I was only keeping the business afloat and strategizing for a gracious and dream exit where I could

take a back seat and let it roll into another baton. I did not want to add to the statistics where the very ground under my feet would become our collective roof.

Whilst I was still basking in survival mode, a general election came in December 2024. The ruling NPP government was heavily defeated by the NDC party.

Even though I assumed the position of neutrality in politics, I was among the majority of struggling citizens who felt this change in the political landscape would bring a change that would be beneficial to our current situations.

The new government, taking over in January 2025, did not waste any time to act upon discovering the inefficiency in the financial sector. They felt the need for a fintech company that would be capable of innovating the current system and providing the needed efficiency.

Their scouts went to the United Kingdom, the center of reference of excellence in financial administration, to source any fintech company with the needed efficiency.

Even though Bsystems did not have any presence in the United Kingdom, the company came to their radar of shortlisted companies that had boisterous and versatile applications in the financial sector. Then a phone call came from the scouts.

Little did I know that this single call was about to change the odds. My almost impossible task of making my company survive me was on the line—and so were my fortunes.

I was informed that Bsystems met the criteria of the fintech company they needed, and a meeting was immediately set up to discuss further details.

The revelation of the identity of the mogul behind the deal at the initial meeting raised the stakes by several notches and, likewise, increased my anxiety to make this takeover happen.

The initial rendezvous was a success. They proposed KPMG to perform the due diligence, and their favorable recommendation would result in a proposal to take over.

KPMG is a giant multinational company that provides audit, tax, and advisory services. They help their clients mitigate risks and

advise them accordingly. When there is an opportunity during their due diligence, they do not hesitate to advise their client to grasp it immediately.

The ensuing two months saw my company under intense scrutiny. Even though there was no guarantee that this microscopic review of my company would result in a takeover, I needed to divulge all trade secrets that set my company apart.

Among the many things that became privy to them were Bsystems' intellectual property documents, patent and copyright documents for all the software developed, company structure, shareholders' agreements, and the possibility of conflicts by the shareholders.

Since a company's strength is dependent on the quality and integrity of the staff, the latter was also scrutinized individually for their honest opinion of the company and to gauge their commitment.

Indeed the following properties of the company became the bedrock upon which KPMG gave their strong recommendations:

- a. a partnership with IBM and Oracle;
- b. a solid, homegrown collateral registry system approved by the World Bank and adopted by multiple countries;
- c. multiple financial software with varied applications;
- d. multinational company status with eleven branches; and
- e. priceless goodwill.

At the end of the process, KPMG did not hesitate to make a recommendation for the buyer to make an offer. At this point, my extreme anxiety finally dissipated, knowing that my company was about to be given a wing to transition to another generation. I would be among the few privileged companies to have done so.

The discussion of the takeover was based on two major premises: I would keep a small percentage of the company in order for my family to continue enjoying dividends into the foreseeable future, and I would keep all the eleven branches afloat to make market accessibility easier for the new owners.

After the final meeting with the potential buyer, we agreed on a good sum for 90 percent of my quarter-of-a-century-old company.

This was good retirement money for myself and also for my wife, who was the second shareholder.

It was hard to tell the staff what had just happened. I was set for the rest of my life financially. But what about those who gave their all—commitment and loyalty—to take me this far?

It was a revelation that I needed to make with mixed feelings. I eventually called a general meeting to let the cat out of the bag.

In order to create a soft landing, I needed to inform them that there was a change in leadership and I was just taking a back seat. This would ensure continued loyalty and commitment to the new management. The new owners have reflected wisely to operate under the same name, at least for now.

In appreciation to my staff, and to celebrate the change of hands and the continuity of a company that I nurtured for twenty-five years, I organized a farewell party to say thank you and goodbye to all my staff.

The testimonies from employees, written and verbal, along the hierarchy of the company made me realize the value this company offered to each and every one of them.

I could not hold back my tears to feel that I had, unknowingly, contributed to the wealth and stability of their respective homes.

As I walked away on my final day, I turned my back to see my office and the conference room—once a powerhouse and heartbeat of Bsystems—now empty and seemingly lifeless.

It was an eerie feeling, but I knew that within a few hours, the new owners would assume stewardship that would rekindle the company into a better and perpetual future.

TESTIMONIALS

MY FAVORITE LEADER, THOMAS BAAFI

It is with immense pleasure and gratitude that I offer this reflection on my time working with Thomas Baafi, the former owner and CEO of Bsystems. My journey with him spanned nearly two decades, from 2007 until he transitioned the company to new ownership in 2025, and during that period, I witnessed firsthand the qualities that made him an exceptional leader and human being.

If I were to pinpoint a standout quality in Thomas's leadership, it would be his profound ability to listen. He was remarkably approachable, creating an atmosphere where one never felt uneasy. He had this unique way of being both a guiding, father-like figure and a supportive, brotherly presence, all wrapped in genuine humility. Beyond that, he was flexible, bold in his convictions, and possessed an innate talent for inspiring those around him.

I recall a particularly challenging period when banks across the country were under immense pressure to implement a new reporting solution mandated by the central bank. Many were struggling. Thomas, placing immense trust in me, approached me with this significant challenge. Recognizing the complexity, I suggested I needed to work from my "safe spot" to devise a solution. Without hesitation, he agreed. That trust was incredibly empowering, and I was able to return with a viable solution. This faith he showed extended beyond just this instance; he consistently allowed me to work from environments outside the traditional office, including his beach house and

an apartment in Tema during the critical Collateral Registry System project. This flexibility wasn't just a perk; it demonstrably boosted our team's productivity and success. His belief in my capabilities led him to entrust me with projects far beyond my initial role as a software developer, significantly impacting my knowledge across various IT fields and fueling my professional growth.

On a personal level, Thomas's support was unwavering. I vividly remember a grueling week spent resolving an Oracle ERP installation issue. He was there, bringing food and even spending time in the office on weekends just to offer company and moral support. Another cherished memory is a business trip to Germany for a meeting with SAP. The moments we shared walking the streets of Berlin and driving to Hamburg, engaging in deep conversations, felt less like a work trip and more like an enriching experience with a mentor and friend. His generosity also shone through during personal milestones; he graciously provided his Lexus and driver for my wedding, a gesture that spoke volumes about his care for his team. He often expressed a desire for me to travel with him more, to see the world, though my demanding schedule often prevented it. It was this desire to broaden our horizons that truly set him apart.

Thomas consistently embodied values of humility, hard work, and an insatiable curiosity. This was evident in his famous open-door policy. Whenever I visited the office, he would always make time. We'd discuss everything from cutting-edge technology like AI and virtual reality to various innovative ideas and personal inspirations, often sharing jokes like old friends. Those conversations, filled with mutual respect and intellectual curiosity, are something I will deeply miss.

The legacy Thomas Baafi leaves at Bsystems is monumental. He skillfully navigated the company's evolution from an Oracle Database Partner to a comprehensive software development leader, spearheading its expansion into several African countries. Under his tenure, Bsystems garnered numerous accolades, including the prestigious title of Best Software Company in West Africa. But perhaps his most significant legacy is the strong, family-like team he cultivated,

where he was a respected and beloved father figure. He didn't just build a company; he built a community.

It was an honor and a privilege to work under the leadership of Thomas Baafi. His influence on my professional development and the enduring culture he fostered at Bsystems are testaments to his exceptional character and vision.

Kwaku Aboraa, Solution Architect

FAREWELL TO A GREAT LEADER, THOMAS AKWASI BAAFI

I vividly remember a night in April 2017 during my early days at Bsystems, staying at the company premises, Annex. That night, I nearly passed out, and my Solution Architect, Kwaku Aboraa, rushed me to North Ridge Hospital. During my admission, every morning without fail, you personally brought me breakfast, packed in the back of your Range Rover, until I was discharged. I still recall the nurses wondering if I was the son of an MP or a president, but I knew only a father could care like that, not just a CEO.

I could always walk into your office, sit down, and have a conversation not just as an employee but as a son. I remember the day I admired your outfit and told you I liked your shoes. Not long after, you called me and handed me shirts and the exact same pair of shoes I had admired. To this day, I still have those shoes, and whenever anyone tries to touch them, I smile and say, "Do you know where these are from? My boss personally gave them to me."

There is so much more to say, but time would not permit me. Whenever I needed help—be it medication, renewing my documents, or even rent—it only took a simple call, and you would always come to my aid.

Over the past years, I have grown into a professional software engineer capable of handling not just development but also leading high-level meetings in Ghana, Nigeria, Zimbabwe, and Sierra Leone.

I owe it all to you. The opportunities you entrusted me with were priceless, shaping me into who I am today.

You deserve time to revitalize yourself—travel to the world's best beaches, visit your favorite city, Dubai, or explore the beauty of Bali. Drink their finest wine, indulge in their cuisine, and savor the moment. And whenever you decide to bounce back, if you ever need me, just call, and I will gladly answer. "Dear Thomas Akwasi Baafi, are you ready for the next challenge?"

Great men like you deserve to be celebrated. If the wind carries you far, your legacy will still echo in my heart. If the sun sets on this chapter, I know it will rise again with new opportunities for you. Your name will forever remain in my heart, a story I will proudly tell others about the good man you are.

May God richly bless you with a long life, good health, and endless joy.

Thank you.

Yours truly,
Patrick Ofori Agyemang

TESTIMONIAL FOR MR. BAAFI'S BIOGRAPHY

Mr. Baafi's biography is a testament to his extraordinary journey as the former CEO of our company. His unwavering passion for innovation and his relentless drive to create solutions, particularly in the IT sector, have been a constant source of inspiration. Mr. Baafi is not only a visionary leader but also a compassionate individual who genuinely cares about the aspirations and efforts of those around him. He serves as a father figure to many of his employees, who continually draw inspiration from his leadership. Having known him for three years, I am consistently inspired by his remarkable achievements and his steadfast pursuit of excellence. This biography beautifully encapsulates his essence and serves as a profound source of motivation for all who read it.

Angela Eli Degbor, HR for Bsystems Limited

**A FOND TRIBUTE TO AN EXCEPTIONAL
LEADER, THOMAS A. BAAFI**

Seventeen years ago, I walked through the doors of Bsystems, thinking I would stay no longer than two years—to gain experience and move on. But here I am, seventeen years later, not just as an employee, but as a proud beneficiary of your remarkable leadership, mentorship, and vision.

It all began with a phone call from my friend Karen Coffie in the UK, who mentioned you were looking for an IT manager. I submitted my CV, and you—despite being in the US at the time—called me personally and asked me to come in the following week. Within five minutes of chatting in your office, you told me to start work the following Monday but emphasized I had to study and catch up quickly in order to lead the IT team. At the time, I was a fresh graduate with a master's degree in finance and business management and a first degree in Agricultural Science—completely new to the world of enterprise IT.

I vividly remember my very first assignment—representing Bsystems in a bid for the e-Ghana project involving Oracle Database and E-Business Suite. I had never even heard of Oracle. But you looked at me and said, “Dennis, go to the Oracle website and read. The team you’re working with isn’t smarter than you.” I spent the whole night in the office preparing, and the next day, I was ready. That moment planted the seeds of confidence in me and marked the beginning of my professional transformation.

Your door was always open—literally and figuratively. Whether through email, WhatsApp, or a late-night call, you were always available. I could text you at 1:00 a.m. and receive an immediate response. Our conversations were honest and heartfelt—more like a senior and junior brother than a CEO and staff member. You have never once turned me down when I reached out for financial support, and yes, I’ll never forget borrowing your car from time to time when needed.

Even my children know that their father has only one boss in the world—Mr. Baafi. My second-born, Julian, is already dreaming of joining Bsystems one day because of you.

Then came the journey of the Collateral Registry. I remember our very first meeting with the Bank of Ghana procurement team, when our proposal was selected as the best-evaluated bid. After the meeting, you looked at me and asked, “Dennis, are you sure we can do this?” I said yes—but only if I could bring in Kwaku.

MY TAKE ON LIFE

I am thankful to the Almighty for bringing me this far to tell my story. My starting line was not from a privileged position. I was handpicked out of compassion and the goodwill of an able uncle from the ashes of my small village, Mabang.

This singular opportunity aided in nurturing me into a business dynamo.

My journey had not been a smooth one. But the nuances I encountered during this unusual journey shaped my life in a way to withstand all challenges.

I am humbled by the opportunity to have lived through the life of absolute poverty and the experience of life in squalor.

In my current state, where the turn of events rendered me abundant wealth, I am joyful I have been able to make life better, not only for myself but for many more people in my ecosystem. Many will never taste poverty the way I did.

However, my society—my heritage, of which I was an upshoot—needs a lot to be desired. It was thwarted with multiple kinks and innuendos and made one wonder whether it would ever evolve to become the way it was in the civilized world.

As I reflect on some of the areas that really bother me, I am hopeful that, one day, my people will take the cue from my reflections and bring my dream closer to perfection.

The selfish society

I could sum up the behavior of our society and compare it to that of crabs piled up in a basket. When one crab attempts to get out of the basket, the remaining try to pull it down.

Many successful nations had been built on the back of trickle-down economics. From the grassroots economic opportunities of society all the way to its pinnacle, the haves had willingly given opportunities to the have-nots to be better.

These opportunities came in the form of training, offer of jobs, provision of social services, financial assistance in the form of affordable loans, and so on.

Our society did not have to go far to sniff this laudable concept in practice. The expatriate communities who had emigrated to our country had put this in practice to help each other climb up the social ladder and live a comfortable life.

Indeed many groups in these communities had been able to put their resources together to invest in gigantic projects. They circumvented the laborious banking system that was only keen to take deposits but taxed you heavily to lend the people's money to you.

What we saw in our Black African community was the direct opposite of the concept of wealth for all. It was rather the survival of the fittest.

As soon as one man became successful, he created a cocoon around himself. He developed an attitude that made it difficult for others to achieve the same. He was happy to turn himself into a lord who needed to be worshipped by the have-nots.

The behavior was replicated across all socioeconomic strata of the nation, the magnitude of which was proportional to the level of the class in the society. And the pomposity of the privileged at the top of the ladder could be very discomfoting.

Many of our political leaders, opinion leaders, religious leaders, the very elite and educated, and our so-called role models manipulated and cheated the very people who put them there to serve. They looted the common purse with impunity.

The new generation in the Black community sees this attitude as the norm and, in attempting to emulate the same, end up perpetuating this unwarranted behavior.

Partnerships

Forming partnership in business is healthy. It promotes the growth of a business by bringing talents to the table for a common cause. When all the various talents play their part, the growth of a business becomes rapid with minimal effort.

But in the Ghanaian community, there was an obvious paucity of partnership arrangements. Many would fail at conception, and others did when the business was well-established.

Cultural practices, some of which rubbed off our egoistic heritage, might explain why such a practice that had transformed businesses in the Western world—from anthills to mountains—was not prevalent in Ghana.

I had two friends who were partners in a successful energy business. One partner became ill. The family of the sick partner, under the influence of their pastor, blamed the sickness on the other party. The friction resulted in the immediate collapse of the successful business.

An anthropological study of our society could help tease out other factors that make the behavior peculiar to our society. The solution should aim at the indoctrination of a generational mindset to accept this laudable characteristic.

The extended family system

This is a cultural practice that rubs off the humanity of *Homo sapiens* to care for one another. The practice is prevalent in many developing and third-world countries. The incidental care it accords to close members of the same family is a form of a rudimentary social welfare system.

Like the well-established social welfare systems known in the developed world, it has helped avert disasters for the have-nots, especially in times of sickness.

I was fortunate to be a star beneficiary of this rudimentary social welfare system that was very entrenched in Ghana. The olive branch that my uncle extended to my struggling mother helped solidify my foundation and metamorphosed me into a businessman with international repute.

The extended family system could be very strong when well-funded. The funding usually comes in the form of time and money. This is usually offered by the willing members of the family unit.

In many cases, it becomes a mountainous task when the support is skewed to one person. This was where I found myself. Even though I was not the eldest in my family, I had the heart that could not refuse a need when approached.

This virtue placed me in a corner that I was unable to dissociate myself from the attendant undue and unplanned burden that came with this responsibility.

What was particularly bothersome was that many members of the family unit would just refuse to take up the mantle of responsibility and face life's challenges to fend for themselves. They would rather lazily sit back with open arms, knowing that an able family member was just around the corner. He was a giver and would always breed true.

Furthermore, the extended family system has a voice. The authority of this voice could be intense and sometimes undesirable.

I encountered many circumstances where this voice influenced and indeed contributed to derailing the career paths of family members. The voice's interference in marriages and reinforcement of religious and cultural beliefs are well-known. In fact, it was the voice of the family that killed the harmony and caused the collapse of the good partnership cited above.

It is time to pause and tease out the good benefits of the extended family and address its undesirable by-products. The Western world has a weak extended family system but a better social welfare system.

The legal system

I took a cue from my travels around the world that there was a lot to be desired from our legal system. My litmus test for a good legal system was when you found yourself behind bars for bribing a policeman for a traffic offense. By this measure, Ghana, like many other African countries, had a failed legal system.

The true irony was that Ghana was not a lawless country. It had many scholars who had formulated laws to guide the nation and protect its citizens. But the goodness of the laws had, at best, remained on paper.

The malpractices of the legal practitioners were an open secret. Many instances had been cited where the prosecutor was also lining his pockets with money from the opposing party. Documentaries had revealed how some judges had, unprofessionally, been biased to pronounce judgment in favor of the highest payor.

I often wondered why some court cases could drag on for years. Some suffered a natural death with the demise of one party.

I might be singing to the choir when I pray that, for the legal system to work, the laws must be enforced. And, needless to say, the scare of going to jail for bribing the enforcer would certainly solve the problem.

Religion

I was concerned how the Western-style religion, especially Christianity, had been used to exploit the whole nation. The promise of heaven seemed to be the underpinning that had taken control of our minds and thoughts of the believers.

Many so-called evangelical leaders had used this doctrine to sway the minds of the unsuspecting in a way that it became detrimental to the individual's well-being and the nation as a whole.

It is a statistical fact that the most religious nations are the poorest in the world. The poorest nations continue to build more churches, while the rich nations continue to build more factories.

Obviously the poor nations pray more, and the rich nations work more. The poor nations pray out of their misfortunes and blame others and the devil for their problems.

Throughout my travels, I had never seen people from developed nations spend the most productive times of the week in church. The weekdays were to make money and contribute to nation building. Any such time taken away from work meant less money to your household.

Many Western nations have allowed the doctrine of hard work to take control of their destiny. They have developed their nations to have happiness on earth rather than what they have been made to believe after death.

Developed nations do not blame their sickness on other people and the devil. They research by science the cause of their ailments and build hospitals to address the solution.

Africans need to sit up against religious practices. It is a distraction to their development.

Lack of government support for indigenous industries

Developed nations take keen interest in promoting local industries in order to be self-sufficient. They support their people in the form of grants, tax reliefs, soft loans, and so on.

Ghana has talents whose dreams have been boxed in because they are unable to bring to life their full potential. The talents cut across many industries—engineering, health, agriculture, and so on.

In my area of expertise, software engineering talents have been suppressed. As a result, they are unable to develop products that can compete with those from abroad. As a result, institutions such as the banks are adopting software developed by other nations.

The problem is even worse in the health care industry, where the lack of support has significantly and directly impacted the life expectancy of the whole nation.

Research into diseases that pertains to our nation is lacking, and our hospitals still operate with the mentality of the last century.

Today we cannot take care of critical illnesses everywhere in the country, and most people resort to herbalists and pastors for their health care needs.

It is ironic when the rich are able to seek medical care abroad for a chronic illness, but when it comes to sickness that will kill them within hours, there is no place in the country that will give immediate life-saving remedy.

The story goes on with agriculture, where, with the abundant supply of fresh water and a big ocean, the country still imports fish and vegetables.

Again the culture of the behavior, analogous to that of crabs in a basket, is breeding true. Your own people will drag you into the mud when you were perceived to be doing something good for yourself and for the nation.

Care of the environment

I grew up in the rainforest of Mabang and lived in close harmony with the flora and fauna. The air was always fresh, devoid of pollution. The only river that ran through the forest provided the cleanest drinking water for us, the inhabitants, and the fauna.

Today it is not the same. We were careless in managing our resources. We have allowed greed, combined with lawlessness, to destroy our environment.

I found myself helpless when the authorities had stood aloof while these important natural resources were being reduced to the ghost of themselves. I was not surprised that the destruction of the environment was done with the connivance of the very people put in charge to protect it.

The forest in many places is now savanna land, and the rivers are muddy and polluted with mercury from illegal mining.

I feel powerless that I do not have the resources to change people's behavior regarding the ongoing destruction. To do so would require a more powerful voice backed with lots of financial resources.

Racism

During my formative years in the land I thought was my greener pasture, I encountered racism squarely in the face and its unattended consequences.

The most significant was when a White man blatantly laid me off work purely because I was Black and did not like the progress I was making in my career. This almost led to losing the life of my infant son because I lost the means and the ability to pay for his care in a hospital.

Experiences like this are very common across the length and breadth of foreign nations where Black people seek refuge because their home country cannot offer them a better life. The indigent perpetrators adopt the attitude that you are not welcome in their society.

I was appalled when I was reminded that some of these foreign lands that we ran to had been built with resources from the African continent. They left the African continent with nothing but blatant poverty.

In my case, the emptiness that was left behind could not offer me a future. The only option was to migrate to a land where I was not wanted.

The Black man, who has no choice but to be out of place, is forced to endure the psychological torture of racial inequality. They are discriminated against for career positions and have to fight twice as hard to be accepted.

The Black man adapts to derogatory racist comments by adopting an auditory and optical inattention to tunnel his existence in the racist society.

In fact, some of the unnerving racist comments, such as "*The African can only eat, sing, and dance*," attempts to say we were only good at one thing. But indeed Africans are good at much more, and this rich and uncontestable culture can never be taken away from us.

It is about time that we make changes in our own countries that will make it difficult for the Black man to leave his territory. It is a wish that I want posterity to prove me wrong.

Averse social scrupulosity

Under our very feet, we witness the erosion of the norms of society. The fallout of the convenience offered by the World Wide Web and social media has been the indiscriminate exposure to alien cultures.

Some of these have been copied to replace existing norms, sending some indigenous cultures to oblivion. Many societies have seen rectitude give way to iniquity and preposterousness sanctified to appear mundane. The volume of information accessible on social media calls for reduction of one's attention span just to keep abreast of it all.

The inability to focus and read to learn in many youths is the manifestation of the acquired abrogated attention span. Perhaps the new age no longer has to learn too much as machines with artificial intelligence have been developed to perform the thinking tasks.

I must be showing my age for thinking that things ought to remain the way they used to be. But I can see the melting together of some cultures was simultaneously destroying the rich cultural heritage of others at an alarming rate.

I have a dream

I dream of the day Ghana will have just 20 percent of like minds coming together, minds that would be selfless and have the common agenda of integrity and accountability.

These minds will form a selfless core that will promote nation-building, apply the rule of law, and promote respect for one another—a core that will become a *nidus* of exemplified character.

It will be a force that will snowball across the nation. The momentum that it will generate will be unstoppable. And the resultant wave will potentially spread across the length and breadth of Africa.

Ghana will regain and assert its influence once again as the Black Star and pathfinder of Mother Africa.

CONCLUSION

Children have no choice where they are born. But being born at the right place and at the right time can make a significant difference in one's life.

I was born at a starting line like many disadvantaged children. The combination of luck, destiny, and serendipity all came together to align the stars on my behalf. The trajectory was unidirectional for me and set me apart from all my peers in the village.

Today I can see how different I am when I ran into my peers whom I had left behind in the village. Many had succumbed to life's challenges. The living bore signs of the treachery of poverty. *Inexposure* to the outside world was reflected in their comportment.

The purpose for which I had been "handpicked" was primarily to give relief to my struggling mother who, at age twenty-six, had six mouths to feed.

But the decision, which had been primarily taken to give relief to my struggling mother, had the unintended consequence of being the rate-determining step of my life.

I had discovered the purpose of my life at a very tender age whilst I was living with my uncle. I believed, at the time, that my mind was operating at an age that was ahead of the chronological age of my body.

My origin and family circumstances played a significant role in defining my life's purpose. Right from the onset, I had been committed and determined to change the status quo of my entire family. I did not want to miss any chance of doing so.

My virtue of always seeing the glass half full rather than half empty came in handy. I never gave myself another chance to be presented with the same opportunity. I grabbed each and every one of them as golden.

I abhorred fear and procrastination. The daredevil in me that allowed me to ride off these attributes gave me the competitive advantage to discover my horizon.

The unusual way I had arrived in my dreamland, given the nuances in the way, was a testimony. I understood life's twists and turns firsthand, and the roller coaster never stopped until I got off it. I had even been thrown into detention during one of the turns.

But the most important thing was to keep believing in myself and never lose the purpose for which I was fighting.

You must always be mindful that you are the only one who can change your life, and no one else can.

Today I am thankful for the decisions I had made. They had been the right ones. I am proud to be self-made and centered in a position of financial empowerment where I am now able to give back to help other people.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

John Acquaye Awah is a physician specialist, now with Mobile Doctors Gh Limited. He graduated from the University of Ghana Medical School in 1988 and obtained his postgraduate training in medicine in England and the United States, respectively. He practiced medicine in the UK and the USA for a total of twenty-seven years.

During his medical practice in the United States, he studied French literature at the Alliance Française in Chicago for four years. It was during his study of French that he rediscovered himself as a writer.

Acquaye Awah is also a philanthropist who has helped many patients financially to regain their health. He traveled on multiple medical missions to provide free medical care in remote villages in the Philippines and Ghana.

Needless to say, Dr. Acquaye Awah is an entrepreneur who has set up businesses in the United States and Ghana. He is a world traveler, and his exposure to multiple cultures has shaped his evolving career as an author.

He has authored the following books:

1. *The American Doctor: The Boy from the African Village*
2. *The American Doctor, Part 2: The Story of the Returnee Diasporan*

He welcomes comments and ideas that will help improve my newfound career. These can be addressed to: theamericandoc-tor2018@gmail.com